A QUIET ARRANGEMENT
SECOND DRAFT

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CHAPTER I — ARRIVAL HALL

Hong Kong still had the talent for making grief feel like an administrative error.

The cabin lights rose for descent and, with them, the old reflex returned: sit up straighter, smooth your face, become the version of yourself that doesn't inconvenience anyone. Grace had crossed oceans and time zones in a wide seat with a soft blanket and discreet service; none of it mattered. On the screen, the little plane inched towards Lantau, making dread look measurable.

She had not expected to be afraid of the quiet. In London, grief could be private. You could cry on a bus and strangers would stare past you as if you were weather. Hong Kong noticed, and noticing was the first step towards management. She had been away long enough to forget that she was trained.

Her mother's last call had been calm, already on rails. "They've said he's stable. The doctors are optimistic. It's good you're coming now. Temporary, Grace. We just need you here until things settle." Temporary had been tied on like ribbon. Grace had said yes because refusing would have required a conversation her mother had already decided.

She checked her phone one last time before switching to flight mode. A calendar reminder blinked for a dinner that

had been moved to "later" without asking, and an unread email from a lecturer sat beneath it, polite and useless: We'll discuss your extension when things stabilise. Her mother's text was at the top, unadorned and final: Car ready. Straight to hospital. Don't worry. Grace stared until the words stopped being words and became instruction.

Through the window, the city appeared in slivers: dark water, clusters of light, hills like sleeping animals. From above it looked almost gentle. Grace thought of her father's hands — big, warm hands that used to smell faintly of ink and watch metal — and felt her throat tighten. He used to say, half-smiling, don't let the city see you bleed. It had sounded dramatic when she was a teenager. It no longer did.

The captain welcomed them in English, then Cantonese. The second language made her body flinch with familiarity. The wheels touched down. People clapped softly, as if survival deserved applause. Grace stared at her hands and wondered whether she was arriving to say goodbye or to maintain a family myth nobody wanted to let die.

In the jet bridge the air was too cold and too clean, disinfectant masquerading as morality. Fluorescent light flattened everyone into the same tired colour. Signs in English above Chinese pointed with the certainty of a city that did not enjoy questions.

Temporary, her mother had said. In the measured flow of arrivals, it sounded like something the family had trained itself to believe. Temporary was how panic became a schedule. Temporary was how a daughter was kept compliant without anyone having to call it obedience.

Grace joined the stream towards immigration, rolling her carry-on. The e-Channel gates blinked green like an invitation to pretend you were not arriving into anything emotional. She stepped forward, let the machine take her face and fingerprints, and the barrier opened with a soft click that sounded like agreement. There was no welcome home. There was only access.

Baggage reclaim smelled of rubber belts and duty-free perfume. Her cases arrived quickly — two identical hard shells with familiar scuffs. She took the trolley handle for a moment, then released it when an airport porter approached.

"Need help, miss?" he asked in Cantonese.

Grace answered in English without thinking, then corrected herself with a brief phrase that sounded rustier than she wanted. The porter did not react. He stacked the cases with care — handles aligned, tags outward — order as a form of respect. Grace followed a step behind.

The arrivals hall was bright and relentless, full of people waiting for other people's lives to arrive. Grace saw her

mother immediately. Some women disappeared into crowds. Her mother organised them.

She was dressed as if for lunch at the Club: pale silk, scarf arranged with casual precision, hair immaculate. No jewellery that shouted, only the kind that whispered to people who listened. She held herself still with a phone in one hand, the other resting lightly on the barrier as if she owned it.

"Grace," her mother said as the side gate opened. Not a greeting. Merely the syllables by which rooms in this city resumed their intended shape. She kissed both cheeks, quick and careful, then held her for exactly as long as affection was permitted to last. The embrace smelled faintly of powder and expensive flowers. Grace felt, absurdly, the urge to cling. She did not.

"Mum," she said. She meant it to be warm. It came out like a greeting at a meeting.

For a second she saw the shape of what was missing. Her father used to meet her at arrivals when she was younger — always positioned a little apart from the crowd, always making it look as if he had been waiting for minutes rather than hours. He would say something lightly teasing about her suitcase, about the weight of books, about how she travelled like a person moving house. He would touch her hair once, brief and fond, and she would pretend not to like it. Now there was only her mother's perfume and her

mother's calm, and the absence of him felt like a hole the airport could not fill.

"Have you eaten?" her mother asked, already scanning Grace's face like a checklist.

"On the plane," Grace lied.

"Good." Her mother did not waste time on lies that kept the machine moving. "Straight to the hospital. No detours. Your room is ready if you need to change later, but not now. Your father had a good night. He's stable."

Stable. The word dropped between them like a coin.

Grace tried to speak and stopped. The question she wanted to ask — Is he still in there? — was too raw for this lighting. Her mother filled the gap with the version she had chosen. "He knows you're here."

Grace did not trust the statement, and hated herself for not trusting it.

A message flashed on her mother's screen — Catherine — and disappeared under two quick taps. Her mother looked up as if nothing had happened. "People have been asking after you," she said. "They're relieved you're here."

Relieved. Not missed. Not loved.

"Keep your phone away for now," her mother added, almost casually, as if advising Grace not to forget a scarf. "No posts. Not even something harmless. People talk." She did not specify who. She never had to.

A security officer lifted a barrier rope without being asked. "Mrs Purvis," he said, neutral and respectful. Her mother acknowledged him with the smallest tilt of her chin, not gratitude — confirmation. Grace followed, half a step behind without meaning to, already back in a lane she had not chosen.

Near the ground transport exit, service lanes unfolded: hotel staff with discreet placards, private drivers at designated points, porters transferring luggage from one set of hands to another. Grace clocked the choreography because she could not help it. Hong Kong was a city of choreography. Even grief had a place to stand.

In the lane to their left, a Peninsula representative in green held the relaxed attentiveness of someone paid to make wealth feel safe. Beside him stood the man from baggage reclaim — the one who had spoken Cantonese with the calm of someone who belonged here.

The wrong porter reached for the wrong trolley. It was not slapstick; it was the ordinary entropy of high service. The trolley began to turn towards the Peninsula lane.

The man spoke. He did not raise his voice. He did not say you are wrong. He said something in Cantonese that sounded formal, careful, almost apologetic, as if the mistake were his own. The porter stopped. A light gesture — not accusing, only indicating — and the porter's face flickered with embarrassment before smoothing back to

professional blankness. One more sentence, softer. The porter relaxed. He had been given an exit. No one had lost face. The trolley turned back; tags were checked; reality was corrected without rupture.

Grace felt her attention sharpen. She thought of her father — how he could make decisions sound like favours — and felt guilt arrive immediately, neat and sharp.

The man's eyes lifted and met Grace's for half a beat too long to be purely incidental. Then he looked away first, choosing restraint. He spoke to the Peninsula representative in English — thank you, that's fine — his accent neither British nor American, not interested in announcing itself.

Outside, a Peninsula-green Rolls waited, absurdly glossy, a colour chosen to be recognised at a distance. The number plate was heavy on 8s. Her father used to pronounce faat with theatrical delight whilst her mother rolled her eyes. Seeing the plate now made Grace's mouth tighten with the old mixture of amusement and disgust.

The man walked to the car as if it were merely transport. The door shut with a sound more muffled than most car doors, as if noise were an indignity.

Grace's family car was waiting one lane over. She slid into the back seat beside her mother and felt herself being returned to a container.

Her mother checked her phone the way other women checked a pulse. When it rang, she answered on the first tone. "Yes," she said, voice softening into the professional kindness she used for doctors. "We've just left arrivals. Ten minutes. Yes, I understand. Keep him comfortable." A pause. "No, not yet." She ended the call and placed the phone back in her lap with the same calm she would have used for a napkin.

"What did he say?" Grace asked, and heard the plea in the question despite herself.

"They're monitoring," her mother replied. "He needs rest. You need to look steady when you go in. Don't ask questions in the corridor. If you want to ask something, you do it in the room."

"Why?" Grace kept her voice low.

"Because people listen," her mother said.

At the junction the car paused, then merged. Through the windscreen Grace caught a last glimpse of the terminal doors opening and closing like eyelids. Ahead, the Peninsula Rolls flashed green between vehicles for a second before being swallowed by traffic.

Her mother smoothed Grace's sleeve once — an almost intimate gesture that was also correction. "No melodrama," she said softly, not unkind. "You will have time to feel later."

Grace looked out at the city sliding past and wondered what later meant in this family. Later could be after dinner. Later could be never.

"We don't have long," her mother said, calm as a schedule. Grace stared at her hands and tried to decide whether her mother meant visiting hours, the day, or her father's life.

CHAPTER II — VELVET COMMAND

The car was so quiet it felt upholstered against panic.

Grace sat beside her mother and watched the terminal's silver curves slide past through tinted glass, then give way to road, cones, and the careful choreography of lanes. The driver eased them forward with the same quiet competence the porter had used with the trolley, and Grace felt the old petty insult of it: how many hands existed in her life purely to remove friction, and how easily friction had become her only proof of agency.

For a few seconds the Peninsula-green Rolls remained ahead of them, a glossy flash between vehicles, then it vanished into the flow. Grace did not know whether she was relieved or disappointed. Both felt like treason. She told herself she had noticed only the colour, the vulgar serenity of a car that seemed to move without sound. She had not, she told herself, stored the half-second when the man from baggage reclaim had looked at her and then away. It should have meant nothing. A stranger corrected a porter. Yet her mind, already raw, had kept it with the wrong kind of care.

Her mother held her phone in her lap, screen dark. She looked forward, not out of interest in traffic but out of habit; people like her did not crane to see where they were going. They were taken.

Her mother checked her watch once, then said to the driver, "Fifteen minutes." The instruction was calm, administrative, and not addressed to Grace, which made it land harder.

"Why does everything have rules?" Grace asked.

Her mother turned her head a fraction, enough to inspect Grace's face. "Because we live among people. And people talk."

Grace thought of the old table at the Peak house — linen too white, glasses too thin, conversations that sounded like laughter until you listened closely. Someone's daughter had "not coped." Someone's son had been "quietly sent away." A woman was "so brave," which meant disgraced. Reputation was never something you possessed. It was something other people temporarily granted.

"You can fall apart," her mother said, and for a heartbeat Grace felt almost hopeful. Then the sentence completed itself, neat as a trap. "But you do it in the right place."

Not because crying was wrong, but because crying could be seen. Questions announced need, and need invited management. Back here, training rose in her like muscle memory: shoulders back, voice level, face composed, do not reach for anyone in public.

The bridge came up and the water opened beneath them — dark, patient, holding ships that moved so slowly they made time itself look negotiable.

Her father would once have made a joke of the skyline. He would have pointed out who owned what, which tower had overpaid for itself, which banker had married into which family and regretted it too late. He could turn anything into story if it threatened to become feeling. Now there was only the water and her mother's calm, and the two felt equally still.

Her mother reached into her handbag and produced a small packet of tissues, then set it on the seat between them without comment, like an object placed in readiness for weather.

Grace stared at it. "For what."

"For whatever happens," her mother said, and the honesty of it was almost startling. Then she softened it at once. "Hospitals are dry."

The phone lit up again. This time Grace saw the name clearly: Catherine.

Her mother let it ring twice before answering in the voice she used with doctors and women who mattered. "Catherine." Grace turned her face towards the window, pretending not to listen — a habit from childhood: hear everything, reveal nothing.

"Yes," her mother said. "She's here. We're on our way now." A pause. "Not tonight. No. We'll see how he is. Tomorrow at the earliest." Another pause, shorter, the kind that meant Catherine was insisting. Grace heard the

small polished laugh her mother reserved for pressure she intended to manage rather than refuse. "You can send flowers to the house," she said. "Not the hospital. The hospital does not need a photograph."

Something in Grace's throat tightened with sudden, irrational gratitude. Flowers were innocent. Photographs were evidence. Catherine's kindness arrived with witnesses.

Her mother ended the call and placed the phone back in her lap as if she had merely adjusted the air-conditioning. She did not explain what she had done. She rarely narrated management. She simply performed it.

"That was Catherine," Grace said, because silence was starting to feel like complicity.

"Yes," her mother replied. "She means well."

Grace almost laughed. Meaning well was one of the city's most efficient ways to do harm.

"What did she want?"

"To help," her mother said. "To arrange something. To make sure people do not bother you."

"People are already bothering me," Grace said, and surprised herself with the bitterness.

Her mother's gaze flicked to her. "Grace." The word did what it had always done: stopped. She did not sound impatient. She sounded gently disappointed, which was worse.

"You're tired," she added. "And frightened. That's normal. But you must be careful."

"What if I want to talk to him alone?" Grace asked. It surprised them both. It was the first thing she had said that sounded like desire rather than duty.

Her mother was quiet for a moment. "You can," she said. "If he's awake."

"And if he's not."

"Then you can still talk. He may hear you."

Grace did not know whether to believe that. She did not know whether she wanted to. Talking to a body that could not answer felt perilously close to performance, and performance was already crowding every surface of the day.

They entered the tunnel and the world became a long tube of concrete and light. Orange lamps repeated at measured intervals, a metronome for fear.

"You spoke to the doctor," she said, because she needed something factual to hold.

"Yes."

"What did he say, really?"

Her mother turned her head, and for a heartbeat her face looked older — not in age, in effort. Calm in her had never been the absence of fear. It was discipline.

"He said your father is comfortable," she replied. "The sedation is working. They are watching the swelling. They are hopeful."

Hopeful. The word sat in the car like another soft object waiting to be used. Grace wanted to ask what it meant, but heard her mother's earlier sentence as though the corridor had already begun around them: not here. Not where people listen.

The tunnel gave way to daylight and the city rose in its usual layers: buildings stacked like arguments, scaffolding clinging to everything, Hong Kong always in the middle of becoming itself. Her mother's phone buzzed once more. Grace caught only the first letter of the name before the screen was turned away, but that was enough. Augusta.

"People will worry," her mother said, as though explaining weather. "Worry turns into talk. Talk turns into stories."

"And stories turn into what?" Grace asked.

"Complications."

They took the exit towards the hospital district. Buildings sat closer to the road here — older concrete, layers of repainting, flyovers stacked like decisions. Grace caught a flash of harbour between towers and felt sudden anger at its indifference. The city was still beautiful. The city was still itself. Only her life had been rearranged.

"Do you want to stop at the house first?" her mother asked.

"No. Hospital."

"Good." The approval landed like a hand on the head.

"I should have brought something," Grace said, hating the smallness of it. "Flowers."

"The hospital has enough flowers," her mother said. "Flowers are for people who need to be seen visiting."

"Do we need to be seen?"

Her mother's mouth tightened. "Grace, you are not a child."

"Then stop treating me like one."

Silence filled the back seat, clean and hard. Even the driver seemed to reduce his presence. Finally her mother spoke, still gentle, still unyielding.

"I am not treating you like a child. I am treating you like someone who is tired and frightened and likely to make mistakes."

"And what happens if I make mistakes?"

Her mother looked out at the city. "Then people will take over."

"People like you."

"People like anyone," her mother said. "People who believe they are helping."

The hospital complex appeared ahead — white walls, glass, a covered entrance built to make money look like mercy. Humidity pressed against the sealed car windows as they rolled under the drop-off. Her mother's posture shifted; composition went on like a garment being fastened.

"Remember," she said softly. "No questions in the corridor. Smile at the nurses. Thank them. If you need to cry, you do it in the room."

"And if I can't?" Grace whispered.

For a moment the matriarch fell away and a tired woman appeared beneath the silk and the certainty. Grace saw, with an unpleasant shock, the cost of never collapsing. It startled her more than anger would have.

"Then you breathe," her mother said, barely audible. "And you try again."

The car stopped. A staff member appeared to open doors, to take weight, to smooth the transition from road to building. Grace stepped out into damp air and disinfectant scent, and thought — unbidden, for the second time that day — of the man at the airport. The formal Cantonese. The face-saving correction. The deliberate looking away. Her father was upstairs under machines and she was thinking about a stranger. She noted both facts and did not know what to do with either.

Her mother's hand found Grace's sleeve. "Steady," she murmured, and walked towards the doors as if she had already decided what kind of day this would be.

CHAPTER III — STABLE

The hospital received them in marble and refrigerated calm.

The air smelled of expensive flowers chosen not to offend. Everything was too bright, too clean, too calmly organised — voices kept low by instinct rather than instruction. Grace followed her mother across the lobby and felt the old sensation of being moved. Not carried — her feet worked, her body obeyed — but moved in the way furniture is moved in a well-run room: quietly, efficiently, without being asked whether it has somewhere else it would rather be.

At reception her mother spoke in formal Cantonese, polite enough to preserve dignity and precise enough to produce outcomes. A badge was printed and slid across the counter with a soft plastic sound. Her mother handed it to Grace without looking down.

"Put it on," she murmured.

Grace pinned it to her blouse. PURVIS, GRACE sat against her chest like a label. No title. No explanation. Just name and family.

The lift rose too quietly. The carpeted corridor above smelled faintly of lavender trying to disguise antiseptic. Here the sound changed into a hush that felt purchased: doors closing softly, machines humming discreetly,

footsteps muffled as if sorrow should not be heard. A nurse in pale blue met them halfway down.

"How is he?" Grace asked before she could stop herself.

The nurse's smile did not change, but her eyes flicked — briefly — to Grace's mother, as if checking where truth was allowed to land. "He is stable," she said. "The consultant will speak with you shortly."

Stable.

The word fell into Grace's palm like a coin: small, cold, and useless. Her mother nodded as though she had been given a useful object. "Thank you," she said, and her thank you sounded sincere enough to be real.

As the nurse moved on, her mother said quietly, "Not here."

Grace swallowed whatever came next.

They stopped outside Room 818. The number was displayed in brushed steel, almost elegant. Her mother put her hand on the handle — not prayer, not exactly, only timing — and pushed.

Soft light. Curtains half-drawn. Orchids on a side table, white and immaculate. A sofa and two armchairs arranged as if this were somewhere people might choose to spend time. Private hospitals always looked like hotels pretending not to be afraid of death.

Her father lay in the bed with his head slightly elevated. Tubes ran from him in neat lines. A monitor glowed with

numbers that meant something to staff and almost nothing to families. His chest rose and fell with deliberate slowness. His face looked both familiar and wrong: the man she knew reduced to skin, breath, and a closed mouth.

Grace's body reacted before her mind did. Throat tightening. Skin cooling. The room tipping slightly, as if gravity had altered.

Her mother crossed to the bedside and set one hand over his. "Darling," she said. "Grace is here."

The word was not false. That was one of the things that made her mother so dangerous. Nothing had to be false to become unusable.

Grace stepped closer. She searched his face for a sign — anything — that he was inside it. A twitch, a flicker, a trace of recognition. There was nothing she could hold. She took his hand. It was warm, and that warmth hurt more than cold would have. Warmth implied presence. Warmth was chemistry.

"Hi," she said. Then, because the first word sounded wrong in the room, "Hi, Dad."

No response. Only the monitor's steady beep, indifferent to whether she was his daughter or merely another body in the room.

The door opened and the consultant entered with the composed briskness of someone who had learned how to ration human expression professionally. He greeted her

mother first, then Grace, and spoke in English. Grace noticed her mother relax by a fraction; English was safer in rooms like this. Cantonese could carry too much family.
"Mrs Purvis. Ms Purvis." He gave the bed a brief professional glance before continuing. "He remains stable. We're continuing sedation to allow the brain to rest. Pressure is being monitored closely."
"Will he wake?" Grace asked, because the question was a splinter she could not stop touching.
"We hope so," the doctor said. "It is too early to predict. Recovery, if it occurs, will be gradual."
Her mother asked, "So there is reason to be encouraged."
The doctor did not contradict her. "There is no reason to abandon hope," he said. Not the same sentence. Close enough to function as one.
He spoke a little longer — careful, hedged, correct — then excused himself with the promise of updates that were really promises of managed language.
When the door closed, her mother released a breath she had not admitted holding.
"You see?" she said softly. "We just need to get through the next day or two. Then it will be clearer."
Grace looked at the bed. It did not look like anything was becoming clearer. It looked like her father had been translated into a set of numbers and calm verbs and left there for everyone else to work around.

Her mother's phone buzzed. She glanced at it, typed one reply, and stood as if leaving a meeting rather than a bedside. "I'm going to take this in the corridor. Don't upset yourself before lunch."

Before lunch. The phrase sat in the room like a domestic object placed neatly on a sideboard.

The door clicked shut. Silence thickened.

Grace sat beside the bed and tried to let herself feel what she had been postponing since the wheels touched the runway. It came in fragments. Love for the man in the bed. Terror that he might never open his eyes again. Anger at her mother's calm. Shame at her own obedience.

She leaned forward and spoke softly. "Dad. I'm here."

No response. Only numbers.

Her eyes moved around the room. A side cabinet stood against the wall with a small lock, the sort private hospitals used for valuables. She stood and moved towards it. The gesture felt intrusive. It also felt necessary.

Inside was a clear bag labelled with his name and the date: PERSONAL EFFECTS.

The phrase felt obscene.

She unzipped the bag carefully. His watch. His ring. A few folded banknotes. His wallet. And his pen — a heavy fountain pen he insisted on carrying even when everyone else used phones. It smelled faintly of his cologne and

metal and ink, as if his hand had been there recently enough to leave a trace.

She touched it and a memory arrived, sharp and ordinary. Her father at the dining table, opening a letter too quickly, the paper catching the side of his thumb. He had stared at the tiny bead of blood and laughed.

"Injured by stationery," he said, and then, because he could never resist making meaning where it was not wanted, "Be careful with paper. It looks harmless."

Grace had been twelve. Worried and irritated at once. He had handed her the envelope as if making her part of the joke, the small scar near his thumb later becoming one of those details you carried without knowing why.

She could still see the pen in his hand at dinners, heavy and old-fashioned against the white linen, refusing to let convenience erase ceremony. He did not flourish it. He did not turn it into a statement. He simply used it — signing a card, writing a name, adding a line to a cheque — with the quiet insistence of a man who liked things to be definite. Men around him borrowed whatever biro appeared; her father reached into his own pocket and produced weight, ink, permanence.

The machines could keep his body warm. They could not keep that.

She rolled the pen once between her fingers and felt the ridges of the cap, the deliberate weight he had trusted against his hand.

She did not want it to become a symbol. She wanted it to be what it was: a small piece of him that was not managed language, not stable, not a photograph arranged for other people. Something she could hold without asking permission. Something that belonged to her alone, if only for tonight.

She pocketed the pen before she could dignify the act with meaning.

When she went back to the bed and took his hand again, the pen sat heavy against her thigh — a small illicit fact.

A quiet knock. The door opened and Theresa slipped inside with a paper bag in one hand and the careful gait of someone entering a room where she did not want to be noticed. Her eyes went to Grace's face before they went to the bed.

"You look like you haven't eaten," Theresa whispered.

"I'm fine," Grace said automatically.

Theresa did not argue. She placed the bag on the side table. "There's soup in there before they make you sit through some dreadful lunch."

She glanced at the monitor with the wary respect of someone who knew machines were both saving and stealing.

"He looks peaceful," she said, and Grace heard how careful the word was. Not better. Not improving. Peaceful.

"He's stable," Grace said, and heard the word leave her mouth like something borrowed.

Theresa's eyes moved to her.

"Stable is a word," she said softly.

CHAPTER IV — THE ECOSYSTEM

The lift deposited them back into the hospital lobby as if nothing had happened upstairs.

Down here, private grief altered very little. At one side of the lobby a man in a blazer was asking whether the parking validation still applied after six. Near the café, someone stood considering the muffins with the attention of a person who had not yet been told that the world was supposed to have stopped.

Grace walked beside her mother through the bright marble space and felt the eighth floor thinning behind her. Upstairs there had been her father's hand, warm and heavy, the monitor, the pen. Down here there were rolling suitcases, a florist's arrangement in a low glass bowl, a porter steering an empty wheelchair back towards the lifts. Her father had not ceased to matter. The world had simply resumed requiring proof that he mattered to it in turn.

At reception her mother stopped to speak to the woman behind the desk in formal Cantonese, polished enough to sound like courtesy and precise enough to produce outcomes. Grace caught fragments: the consultant's surname, the nurse's title, the time of the next update. A small card was printed and slid across the counter. Her mother tucked it into her wallet without looking down.

Outside, the air hit Grace like a damp hand. Cars hissed past on wet roads. A taxi horn sounded, impatient and alive. Somewhere further down the pavement a man laughed too loudly, proving he was not afraid.

The driver stood by the car with the rear door already open. Grace slid in beside her mother and felt the pen press against her thigh. She kept both hands still.

“We’ll go home,” her mother said. “You will eat. Then you will rest.”

“I’m not tired.”

Her mother’s gaze flicked to her and away. “You’re exhausted. And your face is tired.”

Grace felt heat rise. “My face.”

“It’s what people will see.” Her mother said it gently, which made it worse. “They won’t see your thoughts. They won’t see what you carry.”

A message pinged on her mother’s phone. A glance. A reply typed with both thumbs.

“Catherine is sending something,” her mother said. “Flowers. A note. She means well.”

“I don’t want visitors,” Grace said.

Her mother let silence do half the work of correction. When she finally answered, Grace already felt twelve.

“You will have visitors. For your father. People need to feel included. If they don’t, they become anxious.”

“And anxious people do foolish things,” Grace said.

Her mother gave a brief look that might, in another life, have counted as approval. “Exactly.”

Behind trimmed hedges and discreet stone, the house was already waiting.

Inside, the air was cooled and faintly floral. Someone took Grace’s coat. Someone else appeared with tea already poured. The whole house smelled of polished wood, citrus cleaning products, and fresh flowers that had been replaced while she was in the air. Grace had always thought that smell belonged to stability. Today it smelled like replacement.

“Eat,” her mother said, as if the word itself possessed curative properties.

A plate had been set before she crossed the threshold. Rice, greens, a piece of steamed fish. No choices. No spectacle. Care presented as inevitability. She took one bite because refusing would be read as drama.

Her mind kept returning to her father’s face under the hospital light, to the warmth of his hand, to the monitor’s steady beep.

“I want to go back,” she said.

Her mother set down her fork. “Not now.”

“He may wake.”

“If he wakes, they will call.”

“And if he doesn’t.”

Her mother's gaze stayed calm. "Then sitting by the bed for another hour changes nothing except your exhaustion."

Not cruelty. Arithmetic. That was always harder to fight.

"He would want you to rest," her mother said, more softly.

Grace felt something flare. "You don't know what he would want."

For half a beat the room changed temperature. Then her mother said, "Grace," and the name functioned as it always had — a hand laid lightly across the wrist before a glass could be broken.

"Don't fight me."

"I'm not fighting you," Grace lied.

Her mother's phone buzzed. "Catherine will be here in twenty minutes."

Grace looked up. "Why."

"Because she wants to help."

"She doesn't help. She positions."

Her mother's face altered by a degree. Not annoyance. Something colder and more efficient. "That's the same thing," she said.

Grace looked down at the plate. The food tasted of nothing.

The doorbell rang eighteen minutes later.

The staff moved first — one to the door, another to take flowers, another to bring fresh cups. The house always preferred to meet the world halfway down the corridor so the world could enter already softened. Grace heard

Catherine before she saw her. Some women announced themselves by volume. Catherine did it by direction. Wherever she stood, the room quietly re-ordered around her.

She entered carrying a bouquet that looked expensive and restrained enough to claim seriousness. White orchids, green stems, no gaudy colour. She kissed Grace's mother first, then Grace. Her perfume reached the dining room a second before she did.

"My darling," she said, and the endearment contained affection, possession, and social claim in equal measure. "We were all so worried."

Grace murmured something polite. Catherine's eyes skimmed her face — not with cruelty, but with appraisal. Catherine could tell whether you had slept, eaten, or cried. She could read weakness like a language.

"How is he," Catherine asked, and the question was sincere enough to be believable.

"Stable," Grace's mother replied before Grace could speak. Catherine nodded with exactly the correct amount of relief. "Good. That's good."

It was not good. Stable was indefinite. Stable was waiting. Grace said nothing.

Catherine sat at the table without being invited because invitation would have implied uncertainty. Staff appeared with tea for her as naturally as if she lived there. She

accepted the cup with absent gratitude and began talking at once in the register Grace had come to recognise as Catherine's most dangerous one: practical kindness.

Who had been told. Which Foundation calls had been managed. Which dinners could be postponed. Which appearances could be quietly dropped without producing offence. Which messages should not be answered at all because answering them would generate more messages. She spoke of people the way weather bulletins spoke of pressure systems — not unfeelingly, but with the assumption that what mattered was movement, not souls. Grace listened for almost a minute before realising Catherine had already begun rearranging the next two days around her without once pretending the right to do so was in question.

"The gala in two days," Catherine said. "It would be good for people to see you."

Grace felt something in her chest tighten. "Why are we talking about galas."

"Because life continues," Catherine replied, and the phrase arrived as both consolation and threat. "And because your father would want things to remain steady."

Her mother's eyes flicked to Catherine. Agreement passing silently between two women who did not need to waste words on alignment.

Catherine leaned forward. “Nothing strenuous. You won’t be expected to stay late. But people will look too hard at absence.”

Her mother unfolded her napkin as though the matter had already been settled. “We can’t vanish,” she said.

Grace looked from one woman to the other. “I’m not a public statement.”

“No,” Catherine said. “You’re the opposite. You’re family.”

The sentence entered the room with a softness so complete it almost disguised its teeth.

Catherine reached for the seating sheet she had brought in her bag — of course she had brought one — and laid it on the table between the teacups and the untouched half of Grace’s fish. Names in neat columns, table numbers, pencilled marks in Catherine’s hand.

“I’ve moved you to my side,” she said.

Grace looked at the page. “Without asking.”

Catherine gave the tiniest of smiles. “If I’d asked, you would have said no.”

“That’s a reason not to do it.”

“No,” Catherine replied. “That’s a reason to do it quickly.”

Her mother’s eyes remained on the seating sheet. The economy of that gesture said more than agreement would have.

Catherine traced one manicured finger further down the page. “There is one person I’d like you to meet. Swiss.

Banker. Very discreet. He's newly arrived and will likely be involved in something sensitive."

Grace felt her body go still.

"He'll be at your table," Catherine continued. "You don't need to do anything except be civil."

The formal Cantonese. The face-saving correction. The green Rolls sliding away into traffic.

Catherine noticed the stillness at once. She noticed everything.

"You've met him?" she asked.

Grace forced a small smile. "No," she lied.

Catherine's gaze stayed on her for a beat longer than the answer required. Then she smiled and let the lie pass, either because she believed it or because she had no present use for disputing it.

"You will," she said.

Grace sat very still and listened while Catherine and her mother wove the next two days into a sequence of meals, appearances, hospital visits, and manageable gaps, speaking over the seating chart as if schedule could keep death from becoming rude.

Outside, dusk had begun pressing against the windows. Somewhere upstairs a staff member moved quietly through Grace's room, preparing for a night she had not yet been permitted to imagine.

The ecosystem had returned around her — soft, polite, already tightening.

CHAPTER V — UPPER DECK

After Catherine left, the house lowered its volume.

Not into silence. Into that expensive near-silence wealthy houses preferred: the hum of air-conditioning, the softened clearing of plates, a tap clicking twice in a distant bathroom. The house did not sleep. It merely agreed to make itself less audible.

Grace lay in bed and tried, for nearly an hour, to do what her mother had prescribed. Rest. Eat. Sleep. Her body was exhausted, but her mind kept circling the same small collection of nouns, as though one of them might eventually open.

Stable. Gala. Banker. Useful. Table.

Catherine's laughter still seemed to cling to the corners of the room, the sound of someone making herself indispensable. When Grace closed her eyes she saw her father's face under the hospital light: familiar and wrong. Not dead. Not present. The monitor's beep kept returning in memory like a metronome she had not agreed to hear.

She got out of bed without deciding to. The floor was cool under her feet. In the bathroom she ran the tap and watched water move over porcelain, then stared at her own face in the mirror. She looked fine. That was the problem. She looked like a woman who had returned from a trip, not a woman whose father might never open his eyes again.

She watched herself practise the expression she would wear in two days. She did not mean to. It happened anyway: a softening around the eyes, a calm mouth, tiredness shaped into devotion rather than strain. She stopped only when she realised what she was doing and felt shame arrive immediately after. The city rewarded women who looked like they were coping. It punished women who looked like they were not.

Back in the bedroom the silence felt too clean. She could imagine her mother down the corridor — not asleep so much as paused, phone by the bed, mind still moving through names, routes, timings. Her mother did not sleep when control was at stake. She reduced activity. That was different.

Grace sat on the edge of the bed and felt the old, petty urge to disobey simply to prove she could.

She dressed quietly: dark trousers, a light jumper, flats. Nothing that belonged to the daughter in the Foundation circular. Nothing that could be photographed and interpreted. She took a small bag and slid her phone into it without checking the screen. Tonight she did not want words. She wanted motion.

In the corridor the lights were dimmed, not off — old money never fully surrendered to darkness. At the top of the stairs she paused and listened. The house held its breath. Each step down felt like a decision, which was

absurd. Leaving your own house at night should not feel like a moral act. Yet here it did, because in this house every act had the potential to become a story by breakfast.

Halfway down, a staff door opened and the night woman appeared, eyes briefly startled. She looked at Grace and then reflexively looked past her, as if expecting the matriarch to materialise just behind.

"Miss Grace?" she said softly, in Cantonese.

"I couldn't sleep," Grace replied in English, then corrected herself in Cantonese, the words clumsy with disuse. "I'm going out for a little while."

The woman's expression stayed neutral, but Grace saw the calculation in her eyes: should I tell madam, should I call the driver, is this permitted. "Do you want the car?" she asked, already offering the smooth, correct solution.

Grace's first instinct was yes. The car was how this family moved. The car made everything quiet. The car kept you from being seen. Then she felt the hidden cost at once: a driver meant a report, a route, a piece of narrative someone else would possess by morning.

"No," she said. "I'll take a taxi."

The woman hesitated. "Madam—"

Grace cut in gently. "I'll be back soon. Don't wake her."

It was a request for disobedience, small and precise. The woman nodded once, eyes lowering, and Grace understood she had just purchased a favour with the only

currency staff valued in houses like this: not money, but the promise of a quieter night than the one already underway.

Outside, humidity met her skin like a hand. The driveway light cast a pale pool on the ground; beyond the gate, the city murmured. She walked to the corner where taxis sometimes waited, her heart beating too fast for a simple errand. A red taxi appeared within minutes, the driver half-asleep behind the wheel. Grace gave an address without thinking too hard — Central, near the tram line — and the driver nodded and pulled away as though she had asked for milk.

As they descended, the Peak roads curved through darkness and trees and then the lights began, scattered at first and then clustering into density. Hong Kong at night always looked designed rather than built: neon, reflected glass, traffic moving in steady red and white streams. The driver listened to a radio programme at low volume, Cantonese voices arguing gently and then laughing. The language slid over Grace's skin in a way English did not. She caught tone, not content, and was grateful for the blur.

When the taxi reached Central the air felt heavier, more concrete, less forgiving. People still moved as though it were early evening: men in shirtsleeves smoking outside a bar, a couple stumbling out of a restaurant, a delivery worker wheeling boxes into a service entrance with a face

blank from routine. Grace paid, stepped onto the pavement, and stood still for a moment just to listen.

Then she heard it.

The bell came faintly at first, a soft double chime that could have belonged to anything. Then it came again — ding-ding — clearer, and her body reacted before her mind did. Her shoulders dropped by a fraction. The space behind her ribs loosened. The sound reached somewhere the hospital and the house had not yet touched.

The tram arrived with its stubborn slowness, a box of light moving through the city as if time were negotiable. It looked old beside the modern glass, and that oldness felt like comfort. Grace tapped her Octopus card and climbed the narrow stairs to the upper deck. The tram smelled faintly of varnished wood, damp fabric, and metal. Up here the air was warmer, less controlled.

She took the very front seat, the one with the wide view through the front window.

When she was younger, this had been her place. She liked it because nobody could see her face from behind. She liked it because she could watch the city without being watched. Most of all she liked it because the tram's motion meant she did not have to decide where to go. The city decided for her, one stop at a time.

Tonight, the seat was empty. Grace sat and felt something unclench — not joy, not relief exactly, but a loosening of

the vigilance she had been carrying since touchdown. The tram began to move, slow and steady, and the city slid forward.

She had come here because it was the only place she could be alone without making a statement. In the house, being alone would be interpreted. In the hospital, being alone would be monitored. On the tram, being alone was ordinary.

Neon signs blurred on wet pavement. A bus passed, interior full of tired faces. Shops stood half-open, half-closed, the city never entirely asleep. A handful of passengers sat upstairs — an older man with a shopping bag, a young woman scrolling through her phone, a couple holding hands without speaking. Nobody looked at Grace. Nobody cared. That indifference felt like mercy.

The bell sounded at an intersection. Ding-ding. Cars paused. People stepped back. For a moment everything obeyed this small old vehicle without complaint. Grace leaned her head back and closed her eyes for a heartbeat. When she opened them again she was not in a private ward. She was not at her mother's table being told to eat. She was simply moving through a city that, for twenty minutes at least, did not require her face to mean anything useful.

A memory arrived with the bell, uninvited and precise.

She had been seventeen and furious at her mother for something petty and enormous — a remark at dinner, a laugh that had not been a laugh. She had stormed out of the house and made it down to the tram line on foot because she wanted punishment, because she wanted wet air on her skin as proof she was alive. She had taken the front seat and stared through the window at the lights until the anger began changing shape.

Her father had found her later — not by chasing her down in anger, but by appearing quietly at the stop, hands in pockets, hair slightly disordered as if he had decided not to be perfect for once. He had looked up at her sitting at the front and smiled that half-smile that meant he understood. He had not scolded her. He had climbed upstairs and sat behind her without speaking for several stops, letting the tram do the work.

When he finally spoke it had been softly, as though not to break the spell.

"Your mother loves you," he said. "She just loves you like a system."

Grace had laughed then — partly because the phrase was so odd, partly because it was so exact. Her father had added, "It's how she survives," and Grace had wanted to ask, survives what, but she had not. She had watched the city move and felt the anger drain into something else.

Now the memory landed like a bruise pressed too hard. Grace pictured her father on the tram, alive, present, sitting behind her without trying to fix anything. She pictured his hand once — brief and fond — touching her hair as if to remind her she was not alone. She realised she had not allowed herself to think of him like this since landing. She had thought of him as a body and a monitor and a word. Stable. She had not thought of him as the man who understood she needed motion more than instruction.

The tram passed through Wan Chai. Light from bars spilled onto the pavement. A woman in high heels stood smoking outside a shop, phone pressed to her ear, voice sharp. A group of men in loosened ties laughed too loudly, proving they were not afraid. The city looked glamorous and exhausted. Grace thought of Catherine saying life continues and felt the phrase land again as both consolation and threat.

Her phone vibrated in her bag. Grace tensed instinctively and resisted the urge to take it out. The vibration could be anything: her mother, Catherine, a message from abroad. She did not want the world inside this small moving room. The phone stopped. She exhaled slowly and hated the reflexive obedience her mother's instruction had installed: keep it away.

The man from the airport surfaced in her mind again, unwanted. The formal Cantonese. The face-saving correction. The deliberate looking away. She did not want to think about a stranger when her father lay under machines upstairs. Yet her mind kept returning to him, reaching for a door she had already touched. She had noticed him twice already. That was more than she wanted to admit.

Grace stayed on until she reached a point that felt far enough to count as leaving without actually leaving. She did not choose a stop; she chose a sensation — the moment her thoughts felt slightly reordered, the moment her body felt less clenched. When she stepped off, damp air hit her skin and she stood on the pavement watching the tram pull away. The bell sounded once as it left the stop, polite and persistent — ding-ding — and then it was swallowed by the city's wet light.

She did not want to go home. Home meant her mother's calm and scheduled dinners and rules delivered as care. Home meant being watched. Home meant performing steadiness so other people could feel relieved. The rebellion flared and then drained into exhaustion.

She took a taxi back up the hill. The security guard nodded without question. The house loomed quiet and tasteful, holding its breath. Inside, air-conditioning stripped humidity and emotion with equal efficiency. The night

woman appeared again, looked at Grace, then past her. Grace shook her head slightly: don't wake her. The woman nodded and retreated.

Grace climbed the stairs quietly, paused at the top to listen, then went back to her room. She lay down and waited for sleep. Instead she found herself listening for the tram bell as if it were proof there was still a way out.

In the silence of the house, she could still hear it — ding-ding — long after the city had swallowed her again.

CHAPTER VI — HER TABLE

By late afternoon the ward had already begun to feel like routine, which was its own kind of obscenity.

The consultant returned with the same careful face and the same careful language. Numbers steady. No acute deterioration. Continue as before. The family held to the word stable. Grace watched the phrases land and leave no mark on the bed.

When they stepped back into the corridor, her mother said, with the calm of someone confirming dinner reservations, "We will go tonight."

Grace stopped by the lift. The carpet was too clean under her feet and the lavender in the air was trying too hard.

"Tonight?" she said.

Her mother did not look surprised that Grace had forgotten. Forgetting would have implied Grace still believed she had a schedule of her own. "Catherine's gala," she said. "It is already arranged."

"Mum—"

Her mother turned her head a fraction, enough to offer correction without yet offering argument. "We cannot be absent," she said softly. "Not now."

At home, food appeared at the appointed time. Grace sat because sitting was easier than arguing.

After dinner, a staff member appeared carrying a garment bag.

"Miss Grace," she said softly. "Madam says the navy."

Grace looked at the bag. "The navy?"

"The one with the high neck," the woman clarified, voice neutral enough to make the dress sound like a medical instruction.

Grace could have said no. She knew exactly how that would go: her mother's calm, a faint disappointment, the word practical, and the implication that Grace was making everything harder for everyone. The dress would become an argument, and arguments in this family never disappeared simply because nobody had written them down.

She took the bag and carried it upstairs like a task.

In her room she changed slowly, not from vanity but from fatigue. The dress was beautiful in the way discipline could be beautiful: structured, modest, expensive without shouting, designed to make a woman look like stability. Grace looked at herself in the mirror and felt something inside her shrink. This was not the face of a woman in crisis. This was the face of a daughter performing competence.

Downstairs, her mother waited by the door in pale silk, phone in hand, already prepared. She looked Grace over once — not admiring, assessing — then nodded.

"Good. Don't drink too much. Speak to people, but not for too long. If anyone asks you something you do not want to answer, you smile and say you are taking it one day at a time."

Grace felt her jaw tighten. "Is that what I'm doing?"

Her mother met her eyes. "That is what you will be doing," she said.

The driver brought the car around. They slid into the back seat and left the house behind its gates and foliage. The city beyond was already lit.

They did not speak much on the drive. Her mother answered messages in short, decisive taps. Grace stared out of the window and tried not to think of her father. She failed. She pictured his face under the hospital light, the warmth of his hand, the steady beep. She thought too of

the tram, the front seat, her father's voice saying your mother loves you like a system. The memory did not help. It only made the evening ahead feel more like surrender.

The hotel entrance was lit like a stage. Staff in dark uniforms waited with relaxed readiness, making wealth feel safe. Grace stepped out and felt the air change: cooler, scented, controlled. Inside, the lobby smelled of flowers, citrus polish, and expensive perfume.

Catherine Leung was waiting near the ballroom entrance as though she had been installed there permanently. Black silk. Pearls. The smile of someone who belonged anywhere because she had arranged it so. She moved towards Grace's mother first, kissing her cheek with practised warmth.

"My love," Catherine said, affectionate enough to be believable and possessive enough to be true.

Then she turned to Grace and kissed her cheek. "Darling," she said, and Grace felt the familiar discomfort of being addressed as if Catherine had a claim. "We've all been so worried."

Grace said nothing.

"How is he?" Catherine asked.

"Stable," Grace's mother replied before Grace could speak.

Catherine nodded. "That's good," she said.

"Tonight will do you good," Catherine added. "People will be gentle."

Grace knew what that kind of gentleness was for.

They entered the ballroom and the air shifted — colder, denser, filled with perfume, champagne, and the faint metallic scent of stage lighting. A string quartet played something pretty that nobody listened to properly. Voices layered into a constant murmur, laughter timed, attention distributed like currency.

Theresa Chow approached before Grace could be properly swallowed. Her smile was small and real. She took Grace's hand briefly, a squeeze that said more than words could safely carry.

"You made it," Theresa murmured.

"I didn't have a choice," Grace said, and surprised herself with the honesty.

Theresa's eyes flicked to Grace's mother across the room. "Sometimes that's the same thing," she said softly.

Alistair Pembroke drifted in as if summoned by the mention of a name. Tall, beautifully dressed, smiling as though life were a charming inconvenience. He greeted Grace's mother first, then Catherine, then Grace, distributing warmth like someone handing out napkins.

"Grace Purvis," he said. "Back among us. We missed you."

Grace smiled because smiling was safer than answering. She chose the line her mother had rehearsed. "One day at a time."

Alistair's smile broadened. "Perfect," he murmured.

Catherine announced seating with a soft clap. People moved towards tables with practised efficiency, as if where you sat mattered more than what you ate. Grace's mother guided her forward with a light touch on the elbow, proprietary and polite. Grace felt the familiar nausea of being placed.

At the table, name cards waited like verdicts. Grace found hers: GRACE PURVIS. No hyphen. No marriage name. The family brand intact. She let her eyes slide to the card opposite.

LUC MOREL.

The jolt in her chest was not lust. It was recognition, and something close to dread. Hong Kong did not do coincidence at this level; it did arrangements.

Her mother sat to Grace's left. Catherine sat to Grace's right. Grace understood the positioning at once: held between the family and the ecosystem, anchored so she could not drift.

A waiter offered champagne. Grace hesitated. Her mother's gaze flicked to her. Not a warning. A reminder.

Grace took the flute. Catherine smiled approvingly.

Luc arrived without fuss, stepping into place as if he had been there all along. Dark suit, expensive without looking chosen, hair neat, face calm. He carried himself with the same controlled stillness Grace had clocked at the airport:

the posture of someone who understood rooms and did not need to announce himself to them.

He greeted Grace's mother first, as etiquette demanded. "Mrs Purvis," he said, accent softening English without making it foreign. Her mother nodded, allowing the greeting. He turned to Catherine. "Ms Leung," he said, and Catherine's smile brightened with the pleasure of being named correctly.

Then his eyes came to Grace.

"Ms Purvis," he said.

The syllables landed in Grace's body like oxygen. It was not flirtation. It was accuracy. In a room where she was being treated as stabilising evidence, being addressed as herself felt indecently intimate.

"Mr Morel," she said, and heard the steadiness in her own voice as if it belonged to someone else.

Catherine leaned forward at once, delighted by her own arrangement. "Luc has just arrived," she said brightly, as if he were a new piece of glassware placed in the centre of the table. "Very discreet. Very useful."

Luc smiled politely. "I arrived this morning," he said.

Catherine's eyes gleamed. "Have you two met?"

Grace forced a small smile. "No," she lied.

Luc's eyes flicked to her for the briefest second. He did not expose her. He did not correct Catherine. He let the lie stand.

Catherine launched into "sensitive matters" in euphemisms that sounded like philanthropy and meant money. Luc answered questions with sentences that sounded helpful and revealed almost nothing. Grace recognised the skill. It was the same skill her mother used: keep people calm without giving them anything they could use.

Augusta St John appeared at the edge of the table in cream silk and moral authority. She greeted Catherine, greeted Grace's mother, then turned to Grace with warm solemnity.

"My darling," Augusta said. "How are you holding up?"

Grace murmured something.

"So brave," Augusta said. "So strong."

The same word, from a different mouth.

Augusta's gaze shifted to Luc. Catherine beamed. "Luc Morel," she said, as if introducing an acquisition. "Swiss. Discretion itself."

Augusta smiled at him in a way that implied she could be his friend or his judge. "We must all be careful in times like these," she said softly. Luc acknowledged the sentence as if it were weather. Augusta moved on.

Across the room, Grace noticed Deborah Ho — luminous in pale silk, laughing at something a man beside her said. The laughter made her look effortless. Grace told herself

she did not know who Deborah was. The city, she suspected, was about to tell her.

At one point Luc turned slightly towards her and asked, quietly enough that it might have passed for politeness, "How is your father?"

The question contained no expectation of a socially acceptable answer.

"Stable," she said.

Luc held her gaze for a beat. "Yes," he replied, as if he understood what the word meant and what it did not. Then he looked away again, choosing restraint.

Grace's mother watched the exchange without expression.

Speeches followed. A man from the charity spoke of resilience and community. Applause arrived at the correct points. When the programme ended, guests stood and milled. Hands were shaken. Condolences offered. "We were so worried," people said, offering worry like a gift. "You're so strong," they said, as if strength were not a demand. Grace smiled until her face felt stiff.

When they returned to the table to collect bags, Catherine's hand rested lightly on the back of Grace's chair — proprietary, as if Grace were an object placed correctly and now being checked.

Luc stepped closer, close enough that Grace could feel his presence without him touching her.

"Goodnight, Ms Purvis," he said softly.

The words landed like an expectation.

Grace managed a polite smile. "Goodnight, Mr Morel."

Catherine's hand remained on the chair for a heartbeat longer, then lifted as if granting release. Grace walked beside her mother towards the ballroom doors, face composed, body obedient, mind too awake.

Outside, Hong Kong waited humid and watchful, and Grace realised with a small, sick certainty that she had been seen.

CHAPTER VII — A NAME

Grace woke with the faint taste of champagne still at the back of her throat and the sensation of being watched lodged under her skin.

The ballroom's cold air, the orchids, the sponsor screen — none of it should have followed her into her bedroom, but it had. She lay still and listened to the house. It was already awake in its quiet, competent way: softened footsteps, the low hum of air-conditioning, the clink of porcelain somewhere that suggested tea had been decided for her before she had decided anything at all.

Stable. Gala. Useful. Morel.

The words were there the moment she opened her eyes, not as thoughts so much as objects arranged in her mind. She reached towards the bedside drawer by reflex and touched the pen where she had hidden it before dressing for the gala. The gesture steadied nothing.

She got out of bed slowly, not because she was tired but because speed felt like confession. In the bathroom mirror her face looked composed enough to be trusted, which irritated her more than the swelling beneath her eyes.

Downstairs, breakfast was already arranged with quiet precision. Fruit cut into neat shapes. Toast. Tea poured, cup placed exactly where her right hand would fall. A bowl of congee sat to one side because it always did, because

some things in this house did not require instruction to reappear. Grace sat and ate because she could already hear the word that would be used about her later — fragile — said with sympathy and meant as warning.

Her mother entered without sound — no stomp of presence, just arrival. Pale silk, phone in hand, face calm in the way that suggested either sleep or discipline; Grace had never been sure which. Her eyes went to Grace's plate first, then to Grace's face, checking compliance and then consequence.

"You ate," her mother observed.

"I'm eating," Grace replied, because it was safer than saying I can't taste anything.

"Good." Her mother sat opposite and poured herself tea without asking. Asking was for people who needed permission. "We'll go to the hospital at ten."

Grace's stomach tightened. "Why not now?"

"Because the consultant will be there at ten. And because you were out late."

"I wasn't out late."

"Grace." The name was a hand on her wrist again. Her mother took a sip of tea and added, as if offering kindness, "You're tired. Your face is tired. There is no point going in looking unsettled."

Grace felt heat rise at the word. She imagined it repeated by someone else: she seems unsettled. Grief as a behavioural flaw.

Her mother's phone lit, screen angled away, and she tapped once with practised certainty. "Catherine sent a message," she said.

Grace's mouth went dry. "About what."

"About last night. She said you were wonderful."

Grace held her spoon still. "Wonderful at what."

"Being present," her mother replied. "People were relieved to see you."

Relieved. The word settled in her chest like a stone.

Her mother added, almost casually, "There will be another event soon. Not a gala. Just coffee. Catherine wants you to meet someone useful."

"I don't want to meet anyone."

Her mother did not argue. She did not need to. "You don't have to want it," she said gently. "You only have to do it."

At ten, the car arrived. Grace slid into the back seat and felt herself returned to the container. The city moved outside the glass. Her mother was on her phone, replying in short decisive taps.

At the hospital, the corridor hush returned. The nurse greeted her mother first. The consultant spoke about monitoring, sedation, the next twenty-four hours. Her father remained what the doctor called stable — a door left

open enough to live with. Grace watched her mother translate possibility into certainty with the same ease she had used to translate Catherine's kindness into obligation. She held her father's hand and felt the warmth and the absence together, an indecent pairing. She wanted to ask whether he would ever say her name again. Instead she asked nothing. Her mother thanked the staff in formal Cantonese and led Grace out when the visit had reached the correct length.

They went from the hospital to lunch with an aunt because that, too, was part of holding together. The restaurant smelled of money pretending to be casual. The food arrived in courses. Her aunt's concern was pitched exactly right — soft shock at the tragedy, admiration at Grace's return, a gentle insistence on strength.

"You're so strong," her aunt said.

Grace smiled because smiling was easier than saying, I haven't had a choice.

Halfway through lunch her phone buzzed from inside her bag and her body tensed. She did not take it out. Her mother glanced at the bag once, then continued talking as if the buzzing did not exist.

Back at the house, her mother went to her study — calls, messages, arrangements — while Grace went upstairs, shut her door, and finally pulled her phone out.

There were messages from abroad, all written in the careful language of those who did not know what to say. A colleague asking whether she needed an extension. An old friend offering love in paragraphs she could not absorb. Theresa's message sat near the top: How are you. Be careful. Call me if you need. Her throat tightened at the bluntness of it. Theresa did not waste words on performance.

Then there was Catherine.

Grace stared at the name for a long moment before opening the message.

Darling, you were wonderful last night. Everyone so relieved to see you. I've just had a thought: something sensitive is coming up and I would love you to meet someone useful. Fifteen minutes. Coffee tomorrow? Lobby bar at the Peninsula. 4pm. Love, C.

Then a second message, almost immediately after:

He will be there. You don't need to do anything. Just meet. Discreet. Helpful. Don't worry, darling. P.S. Deborah Ho means well, but she's enthusiastic — keep it light.

The Peninsula. The green Rolls. The porter's embarrassment smoothed away by formal Cantonese. The deliberate looking away. The name card across the gala table.

Grace felt her pulse jump and hated herself for it. She told herself she did not care about the man. She cared about the

idea of someone who could operate in this world without belonging to her mother. She cared because she was tired and frightened and hungry for something that was not managed.

She texted Theresa: Not fine. Busy. Call later.

Theresa replied almost immediately: I can.

The simplicity of the sentence felt like kindness. Grace called.

"I'm fine," she began automatically.

Theresa cut through it. "No, you're not."

"I'm not," Grace admitted, and the admission loosened something in her chest by a fraction.

Theresa did not ask for details. She did not offer platitudes.

"Your mother?" she said.

"In the study."

Theresa exhaled softly, the sound of someone who understood without needing a lecture. "Be careful," she said, quieter this time. "This isn't just about your father."

Grace looked at Catherine's message and felt the shape of the warning. "I know."

"Deborah Ho," Theresa said, as if continuing a thought she had been holding. "She's asking questions. About the gala. About who was seated where." A beat. "She carries things."

Grace said nothing. She turned her phone face down on the bedspread.

Silence held between them. Theresa spoke first. "If you need to leave the house, leave. Don't ask permission."

Grace almost laughed. Permission was the air she had been raised breathing. "I don't know how."

"You do," Theresa replied. "You just haven't done it in a long time."

Grace closed her eyes. She could hear the house around her — quiet, alert, listening. Even solitude felt served.

When Theresa hung up, Grace stared at Catherine's message again. Fifteen minutes. Lobby bar. Useful. Discreet. The words were arranged to sound harmless. They did not feel harmless. They felt like the first step in a story Catherine had already decided would happen.

She typed a reply and erased it. Typed again and erased it again. The smallest act — accepting coffee — felt like a moral decision, which was absurd. Yet here it did, because everything in this house had already been translated into consequence.

Downstairs, a door opened softly, then closed. A footstep. The house continuing. Her mother moving in her study, making calls, sending messages, arranging the shape of Grace's days as if shape were the same thing as safety.

Grace looked at her reflection in the dark window: a woman in a beautiful house with a father in a private ward and a mother who could turn love into a schedule. She thought of Luc Morel's calm face, his formal Cantonese, his

deliberate restraint, and the way Catherine had framed him with a single word — useful — as if he were a tool she could place on a table.

Grace put the phone down and sat very still.

But the name remained, lingering like a taste she could not swallow or spit out.

CHAPTER VIII — IGNITION

Grace left the house without asking permission, which already felt like a lie.

She told herself she was stepping out for air. She told herself she was not going out to meet a man. The truth was simpler: she had been invited, and she wanted to go.

Catherine had framed it as nothing. Fifteen minutes. Lobby bar. Discreet. Useful. The words were designed to make resistance look irrational. If Grace refused, she would look fragile. If she went, she would look obedient. The machine always offered you choices like that: two versions of the same cage, one with better lighting.

She dressed in plain clothes — dark trousers, a light top, nothing that could later be described as inappropriate. She left the pen in the drawer. She could not carry her father and Luc at once.

Downstairs, the day staff had the same look the night woman had worn: eyes on Grace, then past her. "Miss Grace." "I'm going out. Taxi." The woman hesitated. Grace shook her head once. The hesitation dissolved. Even now, leaving required somebody else to absorb a portion of the disobedience.

Outside, the air was thick and close. The taxi descended through trees, walls, then the towers beginning.

The Peninsula received her in polished wood, flowers, and expensive restraint. A doorman opened the door before she reached it. The lobby bar sat off to one side, its quiet clink of glass and low conversation suggesting discretion rather than drinking.

Catherine was already there. Of course she was. Cream again — a colour that looked innocent on her and never was. She sat at a corner table with sparkling water and no visible appetite.

"My darling," she said as Grace approached. "I'm so glad you came. I didn't want you alone this afternoon."

Grace heard the double meaning at once: I didn't want you out of sight.

"Thank you," she said, because thank you was what you said when someone offered a hook.

Catherine motioned to the seat opposite. "Sit. You look tired. How is he?"

"The doctors say stable."

Catherine nodded. "That's good." Then, with professional warmth, "We'll all do what we can."

A waiter appeared. Catherine ordered for Grace without asking what she wanted. Grace let her. Choosing in front of Catherine was only another way of declaring material that could later be interpreted.

"He's coming," Catherine said, leaning forward slightly. "He understands our world. And he isn't—" she paused, letting the judgement settle, "foolish."

"Deborah Ho was asking after you," Catherine added lightly. "She means well, but she's enthusiastic — keep it light."

The lobby bar doors opened and Luc stepped in. Grace recognised the controlled stillness before anything else: posture that belonged in rooms, the absence of haste. Dark suit, white shirt open at the throat, everything expensive enough not to need explanation.

He greeted Catherine first, kissing her cheek with European ease. Catherine brightened with the pleasure of a correctly staged arrival. Then he turned to Grace.

"Ms Purvis," he said.

Catherine called her darling as if she owned her. Luc called her Ms Purvis as if she existed. Grace had known it would land the same way it had landed at the gala. It did. She had still not prepared for it.

"Mr Morel," she said, and heard the steadiness in her own voice as if it belonged to someone else.

Catherine filled the air with "sensitive matters" in euphemisms that sounded like philanthropy and meant money. Luc answered with sentences that sounded helpful and revealed nothing. Grace watched his hands — still, controlled — and felt the absurd desire to make him move,

to make him break that stillness. The desire embarrassed her.

Catherine excused herself after exactly fifteen minutes. "I'm just going to say hello to someone," she said. "Don't run away."

The line was a joke, a warning, and a permission structure all at once.

Without Catherine, the room became less supervised and more real. Grace realised with a small, vicious clarity that Catherine's presence had made her feel both safer and less like a person.

Luc said, "How is your father?"

The question contained none of the usual civility. No softening phrase. It sounded like an actual request for an answer rather than an opportunity to display one.

"Stable," she said.

He waited.

It was the waiting that undid her. Most people rushed to save the word once it had been spoken. He left it where it was, small and useless.

"I don't know what it means any more," she said, more quietly.

"Yes," he replied.

The word landed with indecent force. Not because it was kind. Because it did not correct or dilute or repurpose what she had said.

"You were very composed last night," he said.

Grace laughed once, harsh and brief. "Was I."

He chose the word carefully, and the care made it sharper. "You looked managed."

She stared at him. "Don't apologise."

"I wasn't going to." His mouth moved very slightly. "It's not a moral judgement. It's an observation."

"You speak Cantonese," she said, and the sentence came out like accusation.

"Enough. Not perfectly."

"Enough to make a porter not hate himself."

His eyes sharpened, then softened. "Yes."

"Why bother."

"Because it's rude not to." Then, after a beat, "And because it's useful."

The word landed like a hook.

He saw it. His voice lowered. "Not useful as Catherine means it. Useful as in: if you can move through a place without humiliating everyone in it, you should."

"Face," Grace said.

"Yes." He did not flinch from the ugliness of it.

She said, "My mother never named it."

"She wouldn't."

"Why."

"Because once you name a system, people start mistaking it for choice."

Grace looked towards the bar where Catherine was laughing with a man from shipping, one hand on his sleeve, already producing the next arrangement. "She'd say it's care."

Luc did not reply at once. When he did, his voice was low enough that she had to lean to hear. "It probably is."

The sentence landed as the ugliest and most adult thing she had heard all day.

"That's not a defence," Grace said.

"No. It's an observation."

Catherine returned with her smile intact. "There you are. I was beginning to worry you'd both become interesting."

Luc stood. "I should go."

Catherine waved a hand. "Nonsense. Five minutes." Then she checked her watch with performative surprise. "Actually — Grace, you should go. Early night. Hospital tomorrow."

Instructions delivered as care.

Grace stood. Luc stood too, and the symmetry felt like a private joke neither had agreed to acknowledge. "Can I walk you out?" he asked.

"My driver is waiting," Grace said, too quickly.

He inclined his head. "Of course."

Outside, the Peninsula's damp heat rushed back, lifting the scent of petrol, rain, and hotel flowers. The family car waited. The driver stepped forward.

Grace looked at the car, then at the city beyond it, and felt, with humiliating clarity, the exact shape of what she did not want. Not scandal. Not exposure. Return. Immediate, obedient return.

She heard herself say to the driver, "You can go."

The driver blinked. "Miss Grace?"

"I'll take a taxi."

The driver inclined his head and stepped back. Staff knew how to accept a deviation without appearing to witness it.

Luc's face changed by almost nothing.

Grace did not look at him. She turned and walked towards the city. The tram stop was not far — rails shining in the wet road, overhead wires humming faintly.

The bell sounded before the tram arrived.

Ding-ding.

Grace felt the sound move through her spine and settle somewhere behind the ribs.

The tram arrived with its old, stubborn slowness. She stepped on and climbed the narrow stairs. At the top she took the front seat by reflex. The tram smelled of varnished wood, damp fabric, and metal. Up here the air was warmer, less controlled. A handful of passengers sat scattered: an older man with a shopping bag, a young woman scrolling her phone, a couple holding hands without speaking. Nobody looked at Grace. Nobody cared.

The tram moved forward. Wet pavement, neon, buses, the whole bright exhausted organism sliding past.

At the next stop, someone climbed upstairs. A familiar scent — clean, not intrusive — reached her before she heard his voice.

"Ms Purvis," Luc said softly behind her. "I didn't want you getting home without knowing."

Grace did not turn at first. Turning would admit how much she had wanted to see him. She kept her eyes on the front window. "Knowing what."

"That I meant it," he said.

The tram bell chimed. Ding-ding. The city paused, obedient.

"You said I looked managed," Grace said finally.

"You do," Luc replied. "And you do it well."

"Do you think I don't know."

"I think you've been doing it so long you don't know what you feel until it's too late," he said, and the sentence was too intimate to be safe.

Grace's hands tightened on the edge of the seat. "And you," she said, because she needed to wound him back into being human. "You hide behind restraint and call it care."

His eyes flicked — a small hit. He did not deny it. He did not apologise. He simply sat with it, which was its own kind of honesty.

The tram bell chimed again. Ding-ding.

Grace turned her head. Their faces were close enough now that she could see the small details she had not allowed herself to notice. He did not look hungry. He looked deliberate.

"You can go," Grace said, and heard the lie in it.

Luc did not move. "If you want me to," he replied.

Grace stared at him and felt the cruel simplicity of it: choice. She reached back, fingers closing around his hand. The contact was warm, human, unhidden. The act startled her more than it startled him.

His thumb moved once over her knuckles. Not correction. Acknowledgement.

The tram continued forward. The city slid by. The bell chimed, patient and persistent.

Luc leaned in and kissed her.

It was not hungry. It was not frantic. It was deliberate. He had decided this was the one thing he would allow himself to do without editing. Grace felt the shock of it move through her body — heat, relief, fear — like a tide coming in too fast. She kissed him back, and the kiss felt like ignition, like a door opening she had not known she had been holding shut.

She pulled away first, not because she wanted to stop, but because she needed to breathe. She pressed her forehead lightly to his for a heartbeat, then sat back in the front seat.

Luc stayed close but did not reach for her again. His restraint returned, and this time it felt like respect rather than distance.

The tram slowed. Grace said abruptly, "My driver isn't waiting."

Luc nodded. "No."

The absurdity of the answer almost made her smile.

At the next stop he stood.

"I should go," he said.

Grace looked up at him. "Yes."

He moved down the stairs with the same quiet competence he used in every room.

The tram moved forward again. Ding-ding. Grace sat very still in the front seat, heart hammering, the wet road sliding under the window. The kiss had not solved anything. It had only made the existing world more difficult to survive honestly.

At home, her mother was waiting in the sitting room, phone in hand, as though she had been there all along. She looked up when Grace entered, eyes moving across her face once, quickly.

"You went," her mother said.

Grace nodded.

"Good," her mother said. "Did you behave?"

Grace's mouth went dry. "Yes," she lied.

Her mother nodded, satisfied, and returned to her phone. "Tomorrow. Hospital. Then we'll see."

Grace went upstairs and closed her door. Her hands shook slightly as she pulled out her phone. She found Theresa's name and typed: Need to talk. Not tonight. Tomorrow. She sent it before she could make it smaller.

Theresa replied within the minute: Come at eight. I'll have coffee.

No questions. Just a time and a place. It was enough.

Her phone buzzed again. Unknown number.

Hong Kong is smaller than you think.

Grace stared at the words until they blurred.

A second message arrived, same number.

Goodnight, Ms Purvis.

Grace sat very still, the air-conditioning hum loud in the silence, and realised she had been seen again.

CHAPTER IX — AFTER IGNITION

Grace woke with the taste of champagne and tram air still at the back of her throat and the certainty of having been seen sitting in her chest like a held breath.

For a moment she lay still, unsure whether the thudding in her chest belonged to memory or alarm. Then the room reassembled itself: pale ceiling, controlled air, the faint hum of the house already working, porcelain touching porcelain somewhere below. The city had resumed. The house had resumed. Only her body lagged behind, still carrying the night as if it had lodged itself in muscle rather than in time.

She turned her head and saw the phone where she had left it in her bag on the chair. Even after a tram, a kiss, and two messages that made ordinary sleep feel absurd, some part of her had still obeyed the old instruction: keep it away.

She crossed the room, unzipped the bag, and pulled the phone out.

Hong Kong is smaller than you think.

Goodnight, Ms Purvis.

They looked different in morning light — less like danger, more like fact. That was worse. Facts did not flare and vanish. They sat where you had left them and waited for your body to catch up.

Grace opened the thread, stared at it, then locked the screen without typing. Replying would turn the night into continuation. Not replying did not make it disappear. It only bought her a few more hours in which to pretend the shape of the thing had not yet been decided.

She dressed carefully — plain clothes, nothing that could be described as attention-seeking. She left the pen in the drawer.

Downstairs, breakfast had been set. Toast, fruit, tea placed where her hand would fall. Grace sat and ate because her body was still a body even when her mind wanted to punish it for wanting more than one thing at once.

Her mother was already at the table, paper open, phone face down beside her plate. She wore grey silk, hair pulled back, the composure of a woman who had been awake for hours and saw no reason to mention it.

She looked at Grace's plate, then at Grace.

"You're eating."

Grace nodded.

Her mother poured herself tea. "We go to the hospital at ten."

Grace's stomach tightened. "Why not now."

"Because the consultant will be there at ten. And because you need to look steady."

"I am steady."

Her mother's eyes lifted. "You were out."

"I came back."

"That is not what I said." Her voice stayed gentle, which made it worse. "Grace."

The name was a hand on her wrist again.

Her mother took a sip of tea. "And you will not carry your phone openly today."

"Why."

"Because people talk. And because Catherine is being kind. We don't repay kindness with complications."

Grace heard: don't embarrass us.

"I didn't do anything," she said.

Her mother held her gaze for a beat. "Good," she replied, and the word sounded like approval for a child not touching a hot stove. "Then it will remain nothing."

The sentence was obscene in its calmness. Reality was optional as long as nobody spoke it aloud.

Her phone buzzed faintly inside the bag at her feet. Her body tensed. Her mother did not look at the bag. She did not have to.

"Later," she murmured, and the word managed to sound like permission and prohibition at once.

Her mother's screen lit. Grace caught the name before it was tilted away: Catherine.

"Catherine says to tell you she's thinking of you," her mother said. "People were relieved to see you last night."

Relieved. The word settled in her chest like a stone.

At ten, the car arrived. They crossed the city under low sky. At an intersection a tram crossed ahead of them and the bell reached the car too faintly to count as sound and too clearly not to. Grace kept her face towards the window.

The hospital corridor received them in its chilled hush. The nurse greeted her mother first. The consultant used the same careful face and the same careful language. Numbers steady. No acute deterioration. Continue as before.

Grace watched her mother translate possibility into certainty with the same ease she had used to translate Catherine's kindness into obligation. When the consultant left, her mother turned to Grace with a soft smile. "See," she said. "Stable."

Inside the room, her father looked the same and different. The machines hummed. His chest rose and fell. His hand was warm. Grace took it and felt the warmth as both comfort and cruelty.

Her father remained what he had been the day before: warm, breathing, absent.

"I want to come in alone later," she said once the door had closed.

Her mother turned her head. "Alone."

"Yes."

Her mother chose the family version of refusal. "We'll see," she said. "If the room is quiet. If he's resting. If the staff think it's appropriate."

If, if, if. Every private wish turned into a corridor of conditions before it could move.

Grace did not argue. She only looked back at the bed. She wanted to tell her father that she had kissed a man on a tram and did not know whether that made the world larger or smaller. She wanted to tell him that his line about her mother loving like a system had come back so hard it felt less like memory than instruction. She wanted him to open his eyes and say her name the way he used to, with the sense that names could briefly restore proportion.

Instead she said, very quietly, "I'm here."

The machine continued speaking in its little obedient sounds.

Outside the room, Theresa was waiting near the lift with coffee she had no intention of finishing. Her face changed by almost nothing when she saw Grace.

"You look terrible," Theresa said quietly.

Grace smiled in spite of herself. "Thank you."

"That was kindness."

"I know."

Theresa held out the coffee and Grace took it. They stood for a moment in the expensive hush with the lift doors closed and the lavender trying too hard.

"I meant what I said," Theresa murmured. "If you need to leave the house, leave."

Grace looked down at the coffee lid. "I did."

Theresa's eyes lifted. A question appeared and was disciplined away.

"Did it help."

Grace thought of the tram bell, the front seat, Luc's thumb once over her knuckles, the kiss, the texts, the house waiting when she got back as if it had not noticed the subtraction.

"No," she said. "But I went."

Theresa's mouth altered by the smallest degree — not approval exactly, but recognition.

"That may be the same thing for now."

Lunch with an aunt followed because lunches always followed. Soft shock, admiration, a gentle insistence on strength. Grace smiled until her face felt stiff. Her phone buzzed in her bag and she did not look. Her mother noticed that she did not look. That, perhaps, pleased her. Or perhaps it simply saved her the effort of intervening.

Back at the house, her mother went to her study. Grace went upstairs, shut her door, and took out the phone.

No new message from Luc.

The silence was its own pressure. He had given her two lines and then stopped. It could be respect. It could be the same restraint she had noticed in every room he entered,

now extended into absence. She had not realised how quickly she had begun listening for him until the listening met nothing and had to admit what it was.

She typed a reply and deleted it. Typed again and deleted it again. She did not know what she was refusing: him, herself, the possibility of a sequence she would not be able to survive honestly.

She typed:

I'm not sure what happens now.

Deleted it.

Then:

Why.

She looked at the single word for a long moment and could not tell whether it was too much or too little. Why did you follow. Why did you kiss me. Why did you let the lie stand. Why did you call me Ms Purvis as if that title could still contain anything after the tram.

She deleted that as well.

A message from Catherine sat in her inbox, warm and cheerful.

Darling, just a reminder that Deborah means well but is apt to carry things. Keep all future interactions light and avoid unnecessary specificity. Love.

Carry things. The phrase chilled her more than if Catherine had named scandal outright. Carrying was how this city

moved its truths: not loudly, not with malice, only efficiently.

Grace put the phone down and lay back without undressing.

She felt the kiss on her mouth again as if her body refused to let it become memory. She felt both powerful and ashamed.

She lay still and listened to the house continue around her — a door opening softly, then closing; the low movement of air through the vent; one footstep in the corridor and then none.

The kiss had not taken her out of the city's arrangements. It had only made them harder to misunderstand.

CHAPTER X — CROSSING

By four o'clock, Grace had already lived three days' worth of other people's time.

The morning had begun in the private ward with the same careful nouns. No dramatic change. Continue monitoring. Wait. The consultant had spoken with the precise caution of a man who knew families heard hope wherever they wanted it. Grace watched her mother reshape each qualification into something the family could use, and by the time they left the hospital for lunch with an aunt who called her strong twice before coffee, the day already felt used up.

On the drive home her phone vibrated once in her bag. She did not look. Her mother noticed that she did not look, and said nothing.

At home the house resumed its expensive near-silence. Her mother disappeared into the study. Grace went upstairs, shut the door, and sat on the edge of the bed without taking off her shoes.

When Luc's message arrived, it did not pretend to be anything except itself.

If you want to see me, four o'clock. Peninsula.

No greeting. No apology. No softness. One line, like a door left open.

Grace read it three times. She looked, without quite deciding to, at the bedside drawer. The pen was inside. She kept her hand on the drawer pull for a moment, then let go.

She changed into a pale blouse and dark trousers because anything else would have felt theatrical. In the mirror she wiped off lipstick she had put on without thinking, irritated by how quickly she could imagine someone saying, softly, she's trying to look pretty at a time like this. Down the corridor a floorboard gave once under someone's careful step. The house was listening, as it always listened, without needing to ask a question.

She told the driver, "Peninsula," and nothing in his face altered. That was the danger of houses like this: the easiest lies were the ones that looked like routine.

The hotel received her in polish, flowers, and controlled air. Afternoon light lay across the lobby in expensive squares. Grace stood for a moment just inside the doors and felt the usual scan begin in her body — who was looking, who might carry a sentence.

Luc was seated off to one side, not in the bar proper but near enough to disappear into it. He had water in front of him, untouched. Dark suit, no tie, one cuff unfastened and folded back once as if the day had run longer than intended. When he stood, he did not smile as though they were meeting under simpler circumstances.

"Ms Purvis," he said, and the formality steadied her by making everything else feel less false.

"Mr Morel."

She sat opposite him. A waiter appeared, was dismissed with a glance, and disappeared. The room seemed to understand discretion as a kind of service.

They did not talk as they had talked in the bar three days ago. That conversation — managed, useful, face, the mother — had already been had. It did not need to be reopened. What remained was simpler and more dangerous: the fact of being here again, by choice, without Catherine's arrangement as alibi.

"How is he," Luc asked.

"The same."

He nodded once. He did not say he was sorry. He did not offer the word everyone else was using. The silence after the answer was its own kind of respect.

Grace looked at her hands. "I keep thinking I should be at the hospital."

"Should you."

"No." She heard the honesty of it and felt heat rise. "He doesn't know I'm there. He doesn't know I'm here. He doesn't know anything, and I keep sitting by that bed as if sitting were the same thing as helping."

Luc watched her without speaking. After a moment he said, "What would you do if nobody was watching."

The question caught like a struck match. Not because it was romantic. Because it was the one question the city never asked.

"I don't know," she said.

"Yes you do."

Grace looked at him then with an anger that was already too close to hunger. He was right. She did know. She had known since the tram. She had known since the bell and the front seat and his thumb moving once over her knuckles. The only thing she did not know was what kind of woman it would make her.

Luc stood first, unhurried. He did not reach for her hand. He did not dress the moment in language.

"I'm upstairs," he said. "You can come if you want."

That was all.

Grace sat alone at the table for almost a full minute. The lobby continued around her: a woman in linen turning pages at the bar, two men discussing something with the calm aggression of banking, a child in school uniform trailing a mother who never looked down. Ordinary life.

She stood. She crossed the lobby to the lifts with the calm of someone who belonged there. That was the most indecent part: nothing about her looked furtive. She looked like an adult moving from one polished interior to another. The hotel had already agreed not to be shocked.

The lift rose in silence.

His suite door was ajar. Warm light. Half-drawn curtains. The harbour flattened into glass and scattered light beyond the windows. A jacket on the back of one chair. A room already inhabited by a life that had existed before she entered it. Grace caught her own reflection in the darkened window — composed, steady, trained — and felt the absurd desire to ruin it.

Luc stood by the window with a glass of water. He turned when she came in. He did not cross the room. He simply waited.

Grace stepped over the threshold because she was tired of being the person who always left first.

She crossed the room first. He kissed her with deliberate restraint, and she hated how much she needed that restraint to break. She took hold of his tie and pulled him nearer, impatient with her own hesitation. His hands went to her waist, firm but unclaiming, and even then he kept leaving pauses in which she could stop. The pauses made things worse. They made the wanting hers.

She registered fragments and lost them again: the feel of his mouth at her throat, her own hand fisted in the sheet, his watch set square beside the hotel notepad, one of her blouse buttons under the chair by the window. When she went still for a second, he stopped at once.

"We stop here if you want."

The sentence was so plain it almost made her cry. Instead she kissed him again because kissing was easier than answering, and because wanting him did not cancel anything else. It only refused to wait for permission.

By the time the city had come fully alive in the glass, the sheet was twisted at her hip and the lamp was still on. She noticed stupid things because the body did that when the mind was trying not to think: the exact weight of his arm across her waist, the narrow strip of harbour light across the carpet, the sound of traffic far below like a city that had not paused to notice.

Afterwards, the quiet was too clean.

Her father arrived in her mind at once: his hand in the hospital bed, warm and absent; the muted monitor; the private ward keeping its tone level while other people decided what words could survive. Shame came with indecent speed. She turned her face away from Luc, furious at herself for how little time pleasure required to become consequence.

Luc did not fill the silence. After a while he said, very quietly, "I'm not asking you to make this into anything."

Grace let out a breath that might almost have been a laugh. "It already is something."

He accepted the sentence without trying to improve it. He stood, poured her water without asking, and set the glass

in her hand. The gesture was so ordinary it made her chest ache more than any tenderness would have.

"I have to go," she said.

"I know."

He did not ask her to stay. He did not ask when he would see her again. He did not offer a future tense that would have made the room feel cheaper.

In the lift down she steadied herself until by the time the doors opened on the lobby she looked calm enough to be invisible. The hotel had not altered. A florist was adjusting lilies. A couple argued softly over luggage.

The family car was waiting outside. Leather, hush, container.

At home, the lamps were on but the sitting room was quiet. Her mother was not waiting by the door. She was in the study, phone against her ear, speaking in the low administrative tone she used when the machine was running smoothly and did not require the visible hand. Grace stood in the hallway for a moment, listening to the even murmur of management through the closed door, and understood that her mother's absence from the sitting room was not an oversight. It was permission — the kind that could be revoked without ever having been named.

She went upstairs without being stopped. In her room she sat on the edge of the bed. The hotel soap remained on her

wrists. She held them to her face once, hating herself for it, then dropped her hands to her lap.

Her phone was already in her hand before she admitted she meant to use it. She found Theresa's name and typed:

I need you not to ask yet.

She sent it before she could make it smaller.

Theresa replied within seconds.

Whenever you're ready.

Three words. No questions. No diagnosis. No claim.

Grace put the phone down, turned off the light, and lay back without undressing. Her mouth still remembered the taste of a man who had said Ms Purvis in a way that meant she existed.

CHAPTER XI — CHIPPED MUG

Grace did not wake with regret. She woke with logistics.

Her body still remembered heat; her mind already remembered corridors. By ten thirty she had showered, dressed, gone to the ward, and heard stable again. Her mother received each hedge with grave attention and translated it, by the lift, into something livable. On the drive back she opened her phone and said, "Your aunt at one. Then home. Catherine wants a follow-up call."

"I need to be out for an hour," Grace said.

Her mother's eyes lifted. "For what."

"Air."

"We have a terrace."

"I want to go alone."

A pause. Calculation. Then the version that could be lived with. "Where."

"Central," Grace said. "Just Central."

Her mother held her gaze for a beat, then nodded. "One hour. Back for lunch." Then, softly, offering kindness in the same breath as instruction: "No drama."

At the house Grace told the driver, "No car. Taxi." He hesitated — one beat, enough to hear the unasked word — then stepped back. In this house everybody's main skill was making the inevitable look like a decision.

Central was wetter and louder than the Peak, the surfaces older, the air less curated. Grace walked without destination for several minutes simply to feel her own feet on pavement and the absence of somebody else's itinerary. She stopped at a café that did not look as if it belonged to a hotel, ordered tea without a tray or linen, and sat by the window with her phone face down on the table.

When Luc's message arrived, she did not open it at once. She let herself sit with the small power of not responding. Then she turned the phone over.

If you can be out, come here. No staff. No Catherine. Just you. Forty minutes.

A coordinate pin sat beneath the message.

He had done it again: offered something that was also an arrangement. Yet it was not her mother's arrangement. It did not feel like a leash. It felt like a room with the lights off.

Grace checked her watch. One hour. Her mother's rule. Forty minutes. His.

She left money on the table and walked out.

The pin led her to an older office building near Connaught Road. Security desk. Turnstile. A guard who glanced at her and then away. Her phone buzzed once more.

Up.

The lift was fluorescent, mirrored, indifferent. The doors opened on a quiet floor, carpet swallowing sound. No sign,

no branding. A corridor and a door with frosted glass. She knocked. Luc opened almost at once.

No suit jacket. Shirtsleeves, collar open. The absence of armour should have felt intimate. It felt real.

Inside, the room was not luxurious. It was simply a working room: desk with papers in usable piles, laptop open, books that looked handled rather than purchased by the metre, a kettle on the side counter. The window gave onto the back of another building where laundry hung on metal rails in the damp light. No harbour. No skyline. No view to perform. On the desk sat two mugs. One was chipped at the rim.

Grace looked at the chipped mug and felt something loosen. It would not have survived a day in her mother's kitchen. Here it sat without apology.

"Tea?" Luc asked.

The question almost made her laugh. Tea was what staff brought when they wanted you to behave. Tea was what her mother offered when she wanted to turn feeling into ritual. Here, beside a kettle and a damaged mug, tea felt like a choice.

"Yes," Grace said.

He filled the kettle, turned it on, then sat opposite her and left the silence alone. It was the first time that day someone had sat with her without rearranging her into a story.

"You didn't have to come," he said.

"No."

"But you did."

"Yes."

The kettle built its low mechanical sound.

"Why here," she said. "Why not the Peninsula."

Luc looked towards the back window. "Because nothing in this room pretends to be better than it is."

Grace let the sentence sit. Plain enough to be almost rude. Exact enough not to need polishing.

"Nobody pretends in hospitals," she said, and knew it was false before it finished.

"They pretend with language," Luc replied. "It keeps families calm."

The kettle clicked off. He rose, passed her the chipped mug. The rim caught lightly against her lip. Absurdly grounding.

For a moment neither of them spoke.

"Tell me about you," she said abruptly, and heard how it sounded.

Luc's mouth moved once, almost a smile. "No," he said. "Tell me about your father."

"The doctors say stable," she said.

He waited, allowing the difference between the word and its speaker.

"I don't know what it means any more."

"It means the system can keep going without changing language."

The sentence was cruel in its clarity. She almost wished he had lied.

"And your mother?" he asked.

Grace's jaw tightened. "My mother is efficient."

Luc did not smile. "Efficiency can be love."

He said it carefully — not as consolation, not as defence.

"She's kind," Grace said, and felt the contradiction tighten in her throat. "And she's suffocating."

Luc nodded once. No surprise. No appetite for simplification.

"And you are very good at coping," he said.

Grace laughed once, quick and sharp. "I'm trained."

"Yes."

Calm. Accurate. Not comforting.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket. She ignored it. Luc's eyes moved towards the sound and back.

"Time," he said.

"One hour."

"Then forty minutes was ambitious."

"I can stay longer."

"You shouldn't."

The sentence landed wrong. It landed like her mother's voice.

"Don't do that," Grace said.

"Do what."

"Decide for me." Heat rose in her face. "I have enough people deciding for me."

Luc did not apologise. He did not charm the edge away. "I'm not deciding," he said, very still. "I'm seeing consequences you're pretending don't exist."

The bluntness hurt because it was exact.

"If you stay longer, you'll be late," he said. "Then you'll lie. Lies don't stay neutral here."

She hated him for being right.

"And you," she said, because she needed to wound him back into being human. "You speak as if you're not in it. But you are. You just wear it better."

Luc held her gaze. "Yes," he said. After a beat: "I'm in it."

He leaned back slightly, as if distance were what made truth survivable, then turned the chipped mug once between his hands.

"I've been living out of a suitcase since I was seventeen. People think that's freedom."

He set the mug down.

"It's also avoidance."

Grace said nothing. She did not want him to become tragic. Yet the honesty altered something in the air.

"Here I'm nobody's son," he said. "Here I'm also everyone's tool."

Tool. Useful. Same city, different grammar.

"What do you want here," Grace asked, and meant: in Hong Kong, in your life, in this.

Luc answered without dressing it up. "I want to stop moving." He held her gaze. "I want roots. A desk. A place I don't check out of."

It was so unromantic it felt intimate.

"And your bank will let you," Grace said, half-mocking, because the only way to touch sincerity without damaging yourself was often to nick it first.

"If I'm useful." Then, after the smallest pause: "And if I'm not inconvenient."

The word went deep. Not because her mother used it. Because she didn't. Because she never had to.

Grace looked towards the back window. Laundry shifted once in the damp light and settled. Somebody else's ordinary continuity, hanging between buildings as if it were still available in the world.

Her phone buzzed again. She took it out this time. One message from her mother.

Where are you.

No accusation. Worse: a requirement disguised as punctuation.

She typed: On my way.

Luc said nothing. He did not look at the screen. He did not rescue her from the fact of it.

"I have to go," Grace said.

He let her go without making it harder. At the door he said, quietly, "Ms Purvis."

Grace looked up.

"Be careful."

Not of him. Not with him. Of the rooms waiting outside.

The lift doors closed. Grace watched her own face in the mirror and tried, by increments, to rearrange it into something acceptable. Jaw first. Then eyes. Then the set of her shoulders. The building descended anyway.

The taxi took her back into her mother's orbit. Central loosened into Mid-Levels, then tightened again into the approach to the house. By the time the gate opened she looked steady enough to be believed.

Her mother was in the sitting room, phone in hand, as if she had not moved since the hour began. Her eyes went to Grace's face once, quickly, then to the clock.

"Good," her mother said.

CHAPTER XII — BY DEGREES

Reputation never arrived as punishment. It arrived as warmth cooled by half a degree.

Grace noticed it first in the smallest places, which was how Hong Kong did its cruellest work. Not through confrontation, not through scenes, but through micro-changes that could always be denied. A greeting held a fraction shorter. A smile that did not quite reach the eyes. A message that arrived later than it used to. An invitation phrased as concern rather than request. All of it plausible. All of it shaping.

The morning after Luc's office, Grace woke with the word inconvenient lodged like a splinter. She had not expected to feel steadier. She had not expected to feel more exposed. The room with the chipped mug and the laundry at the back window had not offered escape. It had offered accuracy, and accuracy was a kind of danger in a family that survived by selecting which truths were allowed to exist.

At the house, a staff member approached her in the hallway with a cream envelope held on both palms, as if delicacy required choreography. "Miss Grace," she said softly. "Mrs Purvis asked me to give you this."

Inside was thick note-card paper, tasteful enough to pass for intimacy. Catherine's hand was neat and certain.

Darling, thinking of you. You were wonderful. Please don't do too much. I've told Deborah to give you space, but you know how enthusiastic she is. Love, C.

Deborah's name had been placed into the air again, lightly enough to sound incidental. That was how sentences began travelling here: not with force, but with pre-emptive softness.

Her mother appeared at the far end of the corridor, phone in hand. "What is it."

"Nothing," Grace said, folding the card once and slipping it into her pocket.

Her mother looked at her for a beat too long. "Nothing becomes something," she said softly, and walked past. The subject was closed before it had opened.

"We're stopping by the office before lunch," her mother added without turning. "Catherine wants to settle a few small things."

The foundation office was cold enough to flatter silk. Glass walls. A long table. Bottled water lined up with the dead precision of things meant to imply order rather than produce it. Catherine was already there with Augusta, Alistair, and — at the far end — Theresa, who sat with a legal pad and a pen uncapped, her face arranged into the neutral usefulness the room preferred from women who intended to survive it.

"Grace Purvis," Alistair said as she came in. "I've been telling everyone you're heroic." He leaned in just enough to lower his voice without surrendering the possibility of being overheard. "Held by the consultant, I heard. Of course. Of course."

He said it lightly, almost as a joke, and Grace heard at once what mattered: the detail had already left the hospital and entered the city. Held by the consultant. Enough to sound informed. Not enough to sound cruel. Stories here were always trimmed before they travelled.

Catherine touched Grace's arm and guided her to a chair with the warmth of someone seating a guest at her own table. "Only ten minutes," she said. "You look tired."

Grace sat. The room settled around that fact.

They began with the gala programme. Sponsor confirmations. Seating adjustments. A donor's wife who needed moving two places because another donor's wife had decided, privately and absolutely, that October still counted. Warm language for hard needs. Grace said almost nothing. Silence was safer than legibility.

Theresa spoke once, briefly, about timings and transport. Her voice remained level, useful, stripped of anything that could later be described as opinion. Augusta listened with the kind of concentration that behaved like concern. Alistair checked his phone beneath the table and smiled at something there. Grace could feel small decisions being

made about her in real time: how much she could be asked to do, how much she should be seen doing, what version of her exhaustion would prove most reassuring.

Then Catherine said, as if tossing in a kindness too obvious to require discussion, "Of course we've taken Grace off the committee for now. She doesn't need that burden."

No one stopped. No one said, Have we. No one said, Did you tell her. That was what made it clean. The removal had already happened somewhere else; this was only where it became social fact.

Augusta nodded at once. "Very wise," she said. "Strain can manifest in unexpected ways."

The word manifest settled with clinical softness. Not accusation. Not diagnosis. Only the suggestion that the category existed and might, under the right pressure, prove useful.

Alistair smiled across the table. "Grace is made of steel," he said cheerfully.

Catherine gave him the sort of indulgent look reserved for men whose usefulness excused their tone. "Exactly why we should protect her from unnecessary demands."

Grace kept her face still. Steel. Protect. Strain. Burden.

"Theresa will cover anything Grace might have handled," Catherine added. "Just until things settle."

Theresa's pen stopped moving for a fraction of a second. Then it moved again. "Of course," she said.

The door opened quietly and Deborah Ho came in carrying a tray of fresh water glasses. Slim, immaculate, pale dress, hair glossy enough to catch the office light without asking it to. She set the tray down beside Catherine, smiled at Augusta, at Grace's mother, at Catherine, then let her gaze settle on Grace.

"Grace," Deborah said. "I was so worried. How is he."

The table paused by half a beat. Everyone waiting to see how Grace would answer and what the answer would permit.

"Stable," Grace said.

Deborah's eyes widened. "Oh good," she said, as if the word guaranteed a future rather than delay. "If there's anything—"

"Thank you, Deborah," Catherine said, too promptly for the interruption to count as one.

Deborah's smile did not alter. She accepted the dismissal with grace, which was why she was dangerous. She gathered the tray and left carrying the impression she had come only to be kind.

Catherine closed her folder. "Right," she said, and the meeting ended in the usual way: thanks, warmth, a sense that nothing had been forced even though everything had. Augusta offered a line about strength. Alistair said they would all pull together. Grace's mother touched her elbow once, lightly, to indicate direction rather than affection.

Before they reached the door, Theresa stepped close enough that anyone watching could have mistaken it for an ordinary goodbye.

"If Deborah gets soft with you," she said under her breath, eyes on Grace's shoulder rather than her face, "be careful."

Grace turned her head a fraction.

"That's when she's most dangerous."

Then Theresa stepped back into the room before the sentence could become visible.

In the car, Grace's mother checked her phone. Grace stared out at the city.

"It was my committee," she said.

Her mother did not look up. "It was," she corrected gently. "And it will be again when things are calmer."

The sentence was delivered as fact. No anger. No triumph. Simply reality rearranged into something that sounded like patience.

"Catherine said the same thing," Grace said.

"Catherine is right." Her mother set the phone in her lap. "Let people carry you for a moment. It's what friends are for."

Friends. Another word the city could make mean anything.

Grace turned back to the window. Outside, the towers of Central slid past, glass reflecting glass. She thought of the committee email thread she had not been shown, the seating chart she had not been consulted about, the

garment bag that had arrived without being asked for. Each act of care that was also an act of removal.

That evening Grace's mother hosted a small dinner "just family," which meant enough witnesses to make a mood official. Conversation stayed on safe rails: doctors, prayers, how quickly Grace had come back, how strong she was. Strength was praised again, the word used as a weight. One auntie leaned in and said softly, "We're all so relieved you're here."

Relieved. Relief as evaluation.

Grace smiled until her face felt stiff.

At the other end of the table, Augusta turned to Grace's mother and said, just audible, "She seems very tired. I do hope she's speaking to someone."

Her mother nodded once and murmured something Grace could not catch. The conversation moved on. But something had been placed in the room — not accusation, not concern exactly. A category. A note passed between adults while children pretended not to see.

After dinner Grace said, "I want to go for a walk."

Her mother's eyes flicked to her. "Why."

"Because I want to."

A pause. Calculation. Then the version that kept the house calm. "Fine. Twenty minutes. Take your phone."

Grace went out into damp night air and walked only far enough to feel the city without witnesses. By the time she

turned back, she understood that even ordinary solitude had begun to feel like something permitted rather than owned.

When she returned before the twenty minutes were finished, her mother was already in the sitting room. Her gaze moved over Grace's face once, quickly, then returned to the screen.

Grace stood in the doorway long enough to be inventoried. Then she went upstairs without waiting for a word that did not come.

CHAPTER XIII — THE PRICE OF SEEING

Theresa's message was already on Grace's phone by the time she reached her room.

Can you talk. Five minutes.

Grace sat on the edge of the bed without taking off her shoes. The house below resumed itself at once: a cupboard closing somewhere, a footstep softened by carpet, her mother's voice already low and administrative through one wall, tidying the day. Nothing admitted the meeting. Nothing admitted Catherine's chair, or Augusta's clinical warmth, or the word manifest settling softly over Grace's name like a category they'd agreed on before she arrived.

She typed back: Yes.

The call came almost at once. Theresa did not begin with hello.

"I can't do that again," she said, and the sentence shut like a door.

"What happened," Grace said.

A small exhale on the line. Not panic. Control under strain.

"Catherine asked me to step back from the committee. She said it was to avoid conflict."

Grace felt heat rise under her skin. "Because of me."

"Because I covered for you," Theresa corrected. Her voice stayed low, which made the thing inside it harder to bear.

"Because I made you a story Catherine hadn't written herself."

"I didn't ask you to."

"I know," Theresa said. "That's why it was still worth doing."

For a moment neither of them spoke. The quiet on the line was not empty. It was crowded with everything both of them already understood: the committee room, Deborah's beautiful concern, the way social fact arrived dressed as kindness.

"What does step back mean exactly," Grace said.

Theresa gave a short laugh that stripped the phrase clean. "The title goes. The work stays."

Grace closed her eyes.

"Of course it does," Theresa said. "Sponsor list, seating grid, follow-up calls. Just not officially. Officially I'm being protected from strain. Unofficially Catherine doesn't want me anywhere a sentence about you might need handling."

"Theresa—"

"Don't apologise."

"I don't know what else to say."

"Then say nothing for a second."

Grace obeyed.

In the background a door clicked. Then a man's voice, sharp with the kind of anger that had already dressed itself as reason before it entered the room.

"Are you on the phone with her again?"

Theresa did not answer. Her silence was answer enough.

"We talked about this," he said. "We are not going to be the people who make them look bad."

Grace felt her body go still.

Theresa's voice dropped another degree. "Keep your voice down."

"No." Not loudly, which made it worse. "No, because this is exactly how it happens. One favour. One excuse. One gap you cover. And suddenly Catherine is asking what side you're on."

"There aren't sides," Theresa said.

Her husband gave a short breath that was almost a laugh. "That's naive."

The ordinary sounds of a flat continued around the argument: a cupboard door, water running briefly and stopping.

"We have a mortgage," he said. "We have dinners. We have a life in this city that depends on not being the ones who make things awkward for people like that."

People like that. Not named. Not needing to be.

Theresa's voice stayed controlled. "I didn't do anything wrong."

"You didn't do anything useful," he replied, and the word struck Grace harder than if he had shouted. "You did something emotional. That's how people get hurt."

Useful. It was always useful in the end. Clean where the other words were not. Not good, not kind, not right. Useful.

On the line, Theresa took one sharp breath.

"I'll call you back," she said, then immediately: "No. Just listen."

Her husband had not lowered his voice because lowering his voice would have admitted shame.

"Catherine asked you to step back," he said. "Do you understand what that means for us."

"It means they're frightened," Theresa said.

"It means they're watching," he snapped. "It means you're dragging us into something that isn't ours. We are not Purvis."

He broke off, as if the name had performed enough of the argument for him.

Grace could picture Theresa's face with painful accuracy: still on the outside, shaking on the inside, doing the work of remaining comprehensible to a man who believed fear was prudence.

"I didn't do anything wrong," Theresa said again.

"You made it visible," he replied. "That's the same thing."

The sentence settled in Grace's body with the force of recognition. Not because it was wise. Because it was the city speaking through an ordinary husband in an ordinary

flat. Not the act. Not the truth. The making-visible was the offence.

Theresa spoke quietly. "I'm hanging up."

She was speaking to Grace.

The line went dead.

The room around Grace had not altered. The curtains hung as they had an hour ago. Air-conditioning breathed through the vent. Yet something in the day had changed weight. It was no longer only her own life being narrowed. The narrowing had reached another woman's flat and another woman's marriage, and had entered them speaking the language of caution.

A minute passed.

Theresa's message arrived.

Be careful.

Two words. Not comfort. Not advice. Warning.

Grace read them twice, then a third time. She typed nothing back. There was nothing to say that would not make more of a mess.

Downstairs, a chair moved softly across wood. Her mother's laugh rose once from the study and stopped. Grace imagined Catherine on the other end of that call, voice warm, already reframing the day's events into a narrative in which everyone had behaved well and one person had behaved slightly less well, and that person was not Catherine. She imagined Augusta at home composing

a message to someone about how concerned she was, the concern genuine and the message already a kind of placement. She imagined Deborah carrying a sentence she had not started and would not own, the sentence travelling lightly from one lunch to the next until it arrived somewhere it could do its work.

She imagined Theresa in her flat, standing in a kitchen with the phone still warm in her hand and the cold aftertaste of being told that helping had cost more than it was worth.

The cost had arrived without fanfare. No exile. No public humiliation large enough to be named. A committee title gone, authority thinned, a husband frightened in the language of mortgage and dinners, a friend told that helping had been the same as choosing the wrong side.

Grace sat on the edge of the bed and felt the floor shifting under her.

It was not the committee. It was not Catherine's smile. It was not Deborah's luminous sympathy.

It was the knowledge that Theresa had paid a price for seeing her clearly.

CHAPTER XIV — BORROWED AIR

The next afternoon Luc was already at the ferry pier when Grace arrived. He was carrying a paper bag and saying nothing that made the meeting larger than it was.

She had told her mother she needed air. Her mother had looked at her with the kind attention that was mostly measurement. "Fine," she had said at last. "Two hours. And you answer if I call." Grace had nodded because she needed the permission even as she resented it.

The pier smelled of salt and diesel. People queued in loose lines: office workers with takeaway coffees, schoolchildren in uniforms, an old man with a Chinese paper folded to impossible neatness. Her mother would never willingly stand inside this crowd. Grace found it steadying.

Luc had not asked how she got away. He had not asked what she had told her mother. He had simply bought two tickets and stood near a pillar looking at the water.

"Ms Purvis," he said when she reached him.

"Mr Morel."

He lifted the paper bag slightly. "Food."

One line. No performance. The absence of it made her want to trust him.

They boarded the ferry without fuss. No driver following. The ferry was loud in the way public transport was loud: engines, voices, shoes scraping deck paint, the steady

metal complaint of something built to carry strangers. Grace sat by the window and watched the city begin to slip back. The towers pressed against the hillside. Green stubbornness held in the background. Boats moved slowly across the harbour like thoughts you could not speed up. She realised, with comic surprise, that her shoulders had dropped.

Luc sat opposite her with calm attention. On land that attention could look like control. Here, with engine noise under them and the city receding by degrees, it felt like presence.

Halfway across, Grace's phone buzzed. Her mother.

If she ignored it, it would become a story. If she answered, she would hear her mother's voice and feel the pocket of air collapse. She answered.

"Yes," she said.

"Where are you," her mother asked, voice calm as a schedule.

Grace looked at Luc across the table. "Central," she said. "Walking."

A pause. "It sounds windy."

"It is."

Her mother's voice softened into concern. "Don't overdo it. Come home before dinner."

"Two hours," Grace said, and hated that she sounded like her mother in reverse.

"Fine. Text me when you're on your way back."

Grace ended the call and stared at her phone for a second longer than necessary. Luc had not moved. He had not asked who it was. He had simply waited.

"She hears wind," Grace said, unable to keep the bitterness out.

Luc nodded once. "Yes."

They disembarked on an outlying island quiet enough to feel like escape and ordinary enough to be believable. The air smelled of fish, damp earth, and frying oil from a small shop near the pier. A cat sat in the shade with the bored authority of a creature that did not care about human drama. A child ran past shrieking with joy and was followed, ten seconds later, by a father too tired to make the chase convincing.

They walked without hurrying. Luc kept half a step beside her, not leading, not guiding, simply matching her pace. That small equality made her throat tighten more than any declaration could have.

They stopped at a waterfront café with plastic chairs and a view that was unglamorous and therefore honest: boats bobbing against concrete, laundry on rails, an old man cleaning something that might have been fish or might have been the day's mess. Luc ordered iced lemon tea in Cantonese good enough to be effortless. Nobody cared who they were.

For a while Grace said nothing. The silence felt different here. In her mother's house, silence was interpreted. In the hospital, silence was monitored. Here, silence was just silence.

Luc opened the paper bag and slid it across the table. Pastries wrapped in thin paper. Nothing expensive. Nothing performative. Grace took one and bit into it. Sweet, flaky, real. Crumbs fell onto the plastic table. Nobody cared.

"You planned," she said.

Luc shrugged. "Food."

She laughed once, surprised by her own sound. Real enough to sting behind her eyes.

They ate without ceremony. Tea sweated onto the table. A ferry horn sounded somewhere across the water. The island continued being itself with an indifference that felt almost tender.

Afterwards they walked again. Grace found herself talking without planning to. Not dramatic confessions. Small truths. How she could no longer stand the phrase under strain. How Catherine's kindness made her feel trapped. How her mother could be kind and suffocating in the same breath and never appear to contradict herself. Luc listened. Occasionally he said one line — yes, or I know — and then waited. The absence of commentary made her feel safer than reassurance would have.

When she mentioned Theresa, his face altered by almost nothing.

"She paid," he said.

"She did."

His jaw tightened, then relaxed. "That's what happens," he said, and the sentence sounded less like cynicism than memory.

She wanted to hate the plainness of it. Instead it steadied her. No one in her house said that happens. They said difficult, unfortunate, under strain. Luc let the cost keep its own name.

They stopped at a small lookout where you could see a slice of harbour and, beyond it, the city skyline — glass and light, beautiful and indifferent. From here Hong Kong looked almost gentle. It always did from a distance.

"It looks peaceful," Grace said.

"It isn't," Luc replied.

"No," Grace said.

They stood side by side without touching, both looking at a city that would continue whether her father woke or not. The distance between island and skyline did what distance sometimes did: turned pressure into shape. She could see the thing without being entirely inside it.

Only then did she realise she had not thought about her face for almost an hour.

Her phone buzzed again. A text.

Dinner at seven.

The net tightening from far away.

Luc did not look at the screen. He only said, "Time."

"I know."

On the ferry back, the noise felt like a return. People in suits. People on phones. Screens as the safest place to put your eyes. Grace sat by the window and watched the island loosen from them by degrees.

Luc looked at her with calm attention, then said quietly, "You're smiling."

Grace touched her face as if she did not trust it. She had not realised she was.

"Leave it," he said.

Her throat tightened. She did not answer. Answers felt dangerous.

Back in Central, Luc walked with her to the taxi rank, not touching her, not making leaving harder. At the taxi he paused.

"Grace," he said, and it was the first time without title.

She looked up.

"You can have this again."

She wanted to believe him. Belief was dangerous.

She slid into the taxi and watched him through the window as the car pulled away. He did not wave. He did not perform. He simply stood there, still.

At home the gate opened and closed. The house swallowed her. Her mother was in the sitting room, already looking up as Grace came in.

"You're late," her mother said.

"Traffic."

Her mother's eyes narrowed slightly. "Text me next time. You worry people."

Grace stood there a second longer than necessary, feeling the island air leave her by degrees. Then she went upstairs and shut her door and leaned against it, breathing harder than the stairs justified.

Salt still sat lightly in her hair. For a few hours she had been ordinary. For a few hours she had eaten a pastry without someone reading it as behaviour. For a few hours she had been outside the city that knew her and still inside it.

The feeling was already fading, but it had existed. That mattered.

CHAPTER XV — ACCESS

Grace woke with salt still in her hair and guilt still in her mouth.

The island air had been clean enough to feel like a trick. The ferry's engine noise, the plastic chairs, the pastry crumbs on a table nobody cared about — ordinary things that had loosened her chest as if her body had forgotten where it lived. She had come home with that looseness still inside her. By morning the house had begun taking it back. The air-conditioning ran with its steady confidence. Curtains had been opened to their precise width, the amount of morning that suggested readiness without admitting vulnerability. Coffee drifted from the kitchen — real beans, not pods, because even crisis required standards. The house was awake before Grace was, already arranged around a day she had not agreed to.

In the bathroom mirror her face looked lighter than it had the day before — less clenched, less frightened. She hated the relief of it. Relief made you careless. Carelessness made you visible. She caught herself rehearsing without meaning to: softened eyes, calm mouth, tiredness calibrated to read as devotion rather than strain. She stopped abruptly. Shame arrived right after, familiar and obedient.

Before leaving the room she took her father's pen from the tray on the desk and slipped it into her bag. Black barrel. Gold clip. A small real thing from a real man. It had no practical use. She wanted the weight of something that still belonged to him.

Downstairs, breakfast waited: fruit, toast, tea already poured, the cup placed exactly where her hand would fall. A bowl of congee sat to one side, waiting as if the house had already decided she needed soothing before she asked for it.

Her mother was already at the table, dressed and composed, the day's first calls already behind her. She looked first at Grace's face, then at the day.

"Hospital at ten," she said.

"Can we go earlier."

"The consultant will be there at ten."

"We could still—"

"Grace."

The name stopped the sentence in its throat. Her mother poured her own tea without asking. "You came home late," she said. Data, not accusation.

"Traffic."

"Text me next time. You worry people."

Worry meant talk. Grace nodded because arguing would only make her look like the problem her mother was already preparing to solve.

"You look better," her mother added.

Better meant presentable.

"I went for a walk."

Her mother nodded as if approving a healthy habit in a child. "Good. We'll keep things simple this week. You've had too much." A pause, the kind that meant she had already decided. "I've asked staff to manage your schedule."

"My schedule."

"So you don't have to think. So you can rest."

"I can manage my own schedule."

"Of course you can," her mother said, which was the family's way of saying I heard you while proceeding anyway. "But you shouldn't have to right now."

"Why is right now becoming everything."

"Because your father needs stability," her mother said, and the word carried the weight of an entire ecosystem. It was not medical. It was social. Stability meant the story holds.

A staff member appeared carrying a slim folder in both hands and set it beside Grace's plate. Grace opened it. A printed schedule, timed to the minute. Hospital. Lunch. A check-in call window. Rest. Dinner. Every item phrased in careful language that meant what she had been assigned, not what she had chosen.

A cage you could hold in your hands.

"This is humiliating," she said.

"It's considerate," her mother replied.

"Of whom."

Her mother let the question sit unanswered, which was answer enough.

Grace stepped into the hallway and reached for her keys where they always sat in the small bowl by the sideboard. Her fingers hit empty ceramic. A maid passing with a tray slowed by half a beat, then kept moving.

"Where are my keys."

Her mother's gaze lifted, calm as weather. "I have them."

"Why."

"Because you were out late. Because you're tired. Because if you lose them, it becomes an issue."

"I didn't lose them."

"This isn't punishment, Grace. It's protection."

Grace laughed once, sharp and brief. "You're protecting me from my own front door."

"I'm protecting you from a week you're not ready for."

The sentence was almost tender. Her mother's love did not arrive as hatred. It arrived as containment.

"Give them back."

"After the hospital. When you've eaten. When you've slept."

Each condition tightened like a leash.

Her phone buzzed on the table. Her mother looked at the screen and answered before Grace could move. "Yes," she

said, voice softening into the register she used for doctors. "She's here. Yes, she's holding up."

Holding up: another phrase that meant behaving.

When the call ended Grace said, "Why didn't you hand me the phone."

"Because it would upset you."

"It's my father."

"And you are exhausted," her mother said, so gently that the gentleness itself became the thing Grace wanted to break. "This is not about denying you. It's about timing."

At ten, the driver opened the car door and Grace slid in beside her mother without her keys. The city moved outside the glass. Ordinary people crossed streets, carried bags, lived days that did not require permission. Grace watched them with the absurd envy reserved for strangers who would never hear her mother say rest and mean route.

At the hospital the nurse greeted her mother first. Her father looked the same and different: machines humming, chest rising and falling, his hand warm in hers. Warmth implying presence. Warmth being chemistry.

The consultant arrived and spoke carefully. Then the sentence that mattered.

"Recovery — if it occurs — will be gradual."

Grace felt the clause move through her like a weight. Her mother nodded as if it were merely courtesy.

"My mother keeps saying encouraged," Grace said. "Are you encouraged."

Silence. Not long. Long enough.

The consultant folded his hands. "I think it is important to distinguish hope from expectation."

"What he means," her mother said smoothly, "is that we continue."

Grace did not look at her. "That is not what he means."

The consultant cleared his throat. "I mean that certainty would be dishonest."

"Does he know we're here."

"There may be some awareness. We speak to him as if there is."

Grace held her father's wrist for a few seconds longer than necessary. Then: "I'd like time alone with him."

Her mother said, "Not now."

"I am asking for ten minutes."

The consultant intervened with the soft cowardice of professionals unwilling to disturb a room's existing hierarchy. "Perhaps later this afternoon, depending on nursing."

Depending on nursing. Depending on her mother.

On the way out, the nurse handed a visitor leaflet to Mrs Purvis rather than to Grace. Grace watched the paper pass from one woman's hand to the other: even instructions about her father reached her through someone else first.

In the corridor her mother touched her elbow lightly. "You did well."

Grace flinched.

"Not asking too much," her mother said. "Not upsetting yourself."

Even here she was being coached.

In the lift Grace said, "I want to go in alone next time."

"We'll see. If he is awake. If the staff think it appropriate."

If, if, if.

Lunch with an aunt followed because it always did. The restaurant smelled of money pretending to be casual. Concern arrived in the correct register: soft shock, praise of strength, one hand on Grace's wrist just long enough to make sympathy visible. Halfway through, her phone lit with Catherine's name. Darling, you're doing so well. Deborah sends love. Grace set it down without replying.

One auntie said, lightly, "You mustn't make any big decisions while you're in this state."

"What state."

The woman smiled too quickly. "Oh, you know."

Her mother set down her fork. "She's tired," she said, saving the aunt from precision.

Tired today. Strain tomorrow. Some other calibrated word the day after that.

At home, Grace went upstairs and shut her door. She pulled out her phone and checked her calendar. Half the entries were greyed out.

Calendar access updated.

She stared at it, pulse hammering. Her personal calendar had been removed from the shared device. Not deleted. Simply inaccessible. It was not that she needed the calendar. It was the smallness of the violence. A click. A setting. A private list altered from elsewhere without a sound.

Her phone buzzed. Unknown number: a missed call. No voicemail. No message. It could have been anyone. It could have been Luc. The uncertainty sat in her chest like a hook. She did not call back.

She typed Theresa's name into a new message. Can you talk. Then deleted it. Theresa had already paid.

Downstairs, her mother's voice floated up from the study — soft, warm, performing reassurance for someone else. Grace lay back and tried to find the pocket of air she had carried from the island. The memory came back thinly: crumbs on a plastic table, wind off the water, the ordinary sound of nobody caring who she was. Not enough to live inside. Enough to measure the distance.

She reached into her bag and took out the pen. Rolled it once between her fingers, felt the slight scratch near the clip, put it back. Then she unfolded the printed schedule.

Hospital. Lunch. Call window. Rest. Dinner. The day reduced to a series of permissions she had been expected to experience as care.

Keys, information, time, solitude. Each had moved a little further from her hand.

Nothing slammed shut. Things just closed, softly, one after another.

CHAPTER XVI — OFFER IN PRINCIPLE

Catherine's voice came through the sitting-room speaker as if she lived in the house.

"Darling," she said, warm enough to pass for affection and precise enough to function as a tether. "How are you this evening. How is he."

Grace stood beside the sofa with her arms folded so tightly she could feel her own pulse in her forearms. The call was on speaker. Of course it was. Her mother did not keep anything private if privacy made it harder to manage. She sat as though she were hosting — back straight, phone in hand, lamp light catching the curve of her cheekbone as if she had been arranged for the call as carefully as the orchids on the sideboard.

"Stable," her mother said before Grace could decide whether she wanted to speak. "The consultant is encouraged. We're monitoring. Grace is here."

A beat of silence on the line. Catherine recalibrating.

"And how are you, Grace," Catherine asked, voice softening into something meant to sound personal. "I keep thinking of you."

Grace could have offered the line her mother preferred and ended it neatly. Instead she said, "I'm here," which was true and useless, and made her mother's gaze flick to her face.

"Of course you are," Catherine said, a small laugh tucked into the sentence as if being here were a moral achievement. "You were wonderful. Truly. Everyone was relieved to see you."

Relieved. Not love. The absence of inconvenience.

Her mother smiled faintly, pleased by a sentence that proved the machine still ran. "People worry," she said, as if explaining weather to someone who lived in it.

"That's why I'm calling," Catherine replied. "Just to make sure you're supported. The last thing we need is—" a pause, the carefulness audible, "—any unnecessary strain."

Strain arrived dressed as kindness and behaved like diagnosis.

"I've told everyone to give you space," Catherine continued. "And I've told Deborah to be sensible."

Grace felt her mother's attention sharpen at the name.

"Deborah means well," Catherine added. "She's just enthusiastic."

Grace said nothing.

"And I did speak with Theresa," Catherine went on, brightening by half a degree — the shift into business disguised as concern. "I suggested she take a step back for a little while. Not because she's done anything wrong — goodness, no — but it's delicate. You understand."

Her mother's smile held. "Of course," she said. "We appreciate your sensitivity."

Sensitive. Delicate. Words that made it sound as though people were being protected rather than punished.

"And Grace — no more late nights, all right," Catherine said. "I know you need air. But you mustn't give people a reason to fuss."

"I didn't give anyone a reason," Grace said before she could stop herself.

Her mother's eyes cut to her, warning visible.

Catherine's laugh was small and sympathetic. "No, darling. Of course you didn't. But you know how people are."

She finished with a flourish of warmth. "We love you, darling. Truly. Anything you need, you call."

Grace said thank you, because thank you was what you said when someone offered a hook and called it love.

When the line went dead, the room felt quieter rather than freer. Her mother set the phone down with the carefulness of someone placing a glass and looked up at Grace with the quiet assessment she never named.

"Good," she said.

Good meant: you didn't embarrass us.

"You should sleep," her mother added. "Hospital at ten."

Upstairs, Grace lay in bed and stared at the ceiling until morning arrived as a pale strip along the curtains. She did not dream of her father. She dreamt of doors.

By mid-morning the call had already become part of the day's substrate: Catherine's supported, Theresa being asked to step back, Deborah being sensible, the warning about late nights delivered as care. Grace could feel the boundaries tightening like invisible strings.

At ten, the hospital. The consultant spoke carefully about monitoring and sedation. Then the clause that mattered.

"Recovery — if it occurs — will be gradual."

Her mother stepped over it without breaking stride.

In the car back, her mother spoke as if laying track. Lunch. Quiet afternoon. Rest. Grace stared out of the window and felt a strange, sudden certainty: if she did not take an hour now, she would become the kind of person who only breathed when permitted. She already was. The realisation did not arrive as drama. It arrived as dryness.

"I need to go out," she said.

Her mother did not look surprised. She looked cautious.

"For what."

"A walk. Central."

"One hour," her mother said.

Grace nodded because the negotiation always ended in the same place.

She left the house with the sensation of stepping off a marked path. The air was close and warm. She shook off the driver, hailed a taxi, gave the address she had chosen

carefully: Connaught Road. Not the Peninsula. Not the pier. Not anything that sounded like romance.

At the older office building, the mechanism was familiar: guard glancing, then away; turnstile accepting her as if she had been cleared by an invisible list.

Her phone buzzed.

Up.

The lift rose. Metal walls. Fluorescent light. The doors opened on a quiet floor, carpet swallowing sound. A frosted-glass door. She knocked.

Luc opened almost at once. No jacket. Shirtsleeves. Collar open. The same room that did not pretend.

Inside, the room smelled faintly of tea and paper and something clean. Desk with papers in usable piles. Laptop open. Books that looked handled rather than purchased by the metre. A kettle on the side counter. A window onto the back of another building; laundry hung on rails in damp light. Two mugs by the kettle, one chipped at the rim.

The chipped mug. The unglamorous reality of it made her throat tighten.

Luc watched her take it in without speaking.

"You heard," Grace said. "About Theresa."

"I heard." One line. His jaw tightened, then relaxed. "I'm sorry."

Grace was not used to apologies that did not require her to become small in return. She let it sit.

Luc gestured to the chair. "Sit."

Grace sat. He turned the kettle on and did not fill the silence with purpose. Then he poured water into the chipped mug and slid it towards her. Tea, not as ritual, not as instruction. Something to hold.

"Why did you ask me here," she said, and heard the edge in her own voice.

"Because I need to show you something."

He moved to the desk, opened the laptop fully, and turned it so she could see without leaning into his space. He pointed once to the paragraph that mattered, then took his hand away. "Read it."

An email. HR header. Clean corporate language. No romance.

Internal Transfer — Hong Kong — Offer in Principle

Grace felt her throat tighten, not with tears, with shock. The words were too plain to be fantasy. That was what made them terrifying.

She read. The language was careful, conditional, but real in the only way corporate life was ever real: written, dated, reversible and therefore meaningful. Pleased to confirm. Subject to compliance review. Visa sponsorship. Effective Q3.

Hope with a bureaucratic shape.

"This is—" Grace began.

"Real," Luc said.

She looked at him and saw, beneath his restraint, hunger. Not sexual. Hunger for roots.

"You wanted this anyway," she said, needing to pin the hope to something independent of her.

"Yes." He did not try to make her feel special. He did not say he had done it for her. He let the truth stand. "Before I met you. And again after."

Grace's eyes snapped to his face.

"Not as a gesture," he said, sharp enough to be a boundary. "As acceleration."

Acceleration. A man choosing to stop moving. A man choosing Hong Kong as root, not rotation.

"And you can get it," Grace said, hearing how much she wanted the sentence to be true.

"If I'm useful." A pause. "And if I'm not inconvenient."

Inconvenient. The word her mother never said and always implied. The word Catherine wrapped in kindness. The word Augusta disguised as support. It sat between them, ugly and accurate.

Grace stared at the email again. The conditional language looked suddenly like a trap disguised as an offer. She could almost see the future in it: a phone call, a concern, a review extended into forever.

Luc watched her read without rescuing her into optimism. His restraint did not soften the truth; it held it steady.

Grace's fingers moved before she had decided. She took out her phone and held it over the screen. Luc's eyes flicked to the phone and then away. He did not tell her what to do. He did not offer instructions. He watched.

Grace took a screenshot.

The sound was tiny — a click and a flash — and it felt like a crime.

She took another, then stopped.

Luc said nothing. He did not approve. He did not disapprove. For once his restraint felt like room rather than distance.

"If you stay," Grace said quietly, and the sentence contained every fear she had not said aloud yet, "then what."

Luc did not answer with romance. "A lease," he said. "A flat. Somewhere quiet." A pause. "Not the Peninsula."

Grace's mouth twitched, a laugh without humour. Hotels were loneliness dressed as service.

"Mid-Levels," Luc said, then corrected himself, almost deliberately making it less glossy. "Or Kennedy Town."

He did not say somewhere you can breathe. He left it alone.

Her eyes stung. She did not let tears arrive. Crying in front of him would have made her feel like someone being handled again, and she could not bear it.

"I want to tell my father," she said, and the sentence came out rawer than she intended.

Luc looked at the chipped mug in her hands, giving the words time to exist.

"Not because he can approve it," she added quickly. "Because I need him to know."

Luc nodded once. "Yes."

Grace's phone buzzed on the desk. Her mother's name.

Luc's eyes flicked to the screen. "Time," he said.

She hated him for the one word and needed it in the same breath.

Grace let it ring once, twice, then answered.

"Yes."

"Where are you," her mother asked, calm as a schedule.

Grace looked at the HR email on the screen. "In Central," she said. "Walking."

A pause. "It sounds like a lift."

Grace's stomach dropped. "I'm inside," she said, conceding an inch.

Her mother's voice softened into concern. "Come home before lunch. And don't disappear."

"One hour," Grace said.

"Good," her mother replied. "Text me when you're on your way."

Grace ended the call and stared at the phone. Luc had not moved. He had not asked. He had simply waited.

"She hears lifts," Grace said.

Luc nodded once. "Yes."

Grace stood abruptly. "I have to go."

He walked her to the door without touching her. At the lift he said, "Grace."

No title.

She looked up.

"Don't erase it," he said.

She stepped into the lift alone. The doors closed. She watched her face in the mirror and tried to rearrange it into something acceptable. The lift descended anyway.

At home, her mother scanned Grace's face once, quickly, then looked away.

Grace went upstairs. The screenshots sat in her phone like contraband. Outside the study door, her mother's voice was already moving on to the next arrangement.

Her phone buzzed. A text.

Lunch. Now.

CHAPTER XVII — HER NAME

Grace woke before the house had decided it was morning. The silence felt uncurated, which in this house was as close as she came to privacy. Her phone lay on the bedside table. No messages. No new instructions. Catherine's warmth, Luc's screenshots, her mother's voice coming through the study door — all of it sat just beyond the edge of the room, waiting for the day to begin and therefore to become usable.

Grace sat up and reached for the pen before she reached for the light.

It lay where she had left it, black barrel catching the first thin seam of dawn. She rolled it once between her fingers and felt the familiar scratch near the clip. Her father's pen. Weight without argument. Yesterday she had wanted to tell him. Yesterday had been taken from her by lunch, keys, the printed schedule, the consultant's clause, Luc's email flashing on a screen like something real enough to be dangerous. If she waited until ten, the day would already belong to other people.

She dressed quietly — dark trousers, plain blouse, the sort of clothes that refused to become a conversation — and slipped the pen into her pocket.

Downstairs, the entrance hall was still half-dark. The night woman looked up from a chair by the service door, startled into full wakefulness.

"Miss Grace?"

"I'm going to the hospital," Grace said softly. "Taxi."

The woman's eyes flicked once towards the upper floor. Then back to Grace. The silent arithmetic of a house like this.

"Madam—"

"Not yet," Grace said. "Please."

The woman lowered her eyes. "Yes, miss."

Outside, the air held the last of the night's dampness. Taxis passed with roof lights glowing. Grace slid into one and gave the hospital name without embellishment. As the car descended, Hong Kong assembled itself in layers of early light: towers duller before full morning, flyovers still half-empty, a street cleaner hosing last night out of a gutter, a fruit seller lifting shutters one arm at a time. Ordinary labour beginning before the city remembered to call itself elegant.

At the hospital the lobby was quieter than she had ever known it: no florist's scent over expensive coffee, no family voices arranging hope into shareable lines, only the soft hum of refrigeration and the discreet footfall of staff who had been awake for hours already.

At reception the woman on duty looked up.

"Ms Purvis."

"I'd like to sit with him," Grace said. "Alone, if possible."

The woman's eyes flicked towards the private lift, then back. Even here permission had a geography. "He's resting," she said. "The nurse will let the ward know."

The lift rose too quietly. In the mirrored wall Grace caught her own face and looked away almost at once. She had spent too many mornings seeing what the city required there. Not today.

The corridor smelled faintly of lavender trying, as ever, to disguise antiseptic. A nurse in pale blue met her by the room.

"He's been settled," she said. "The consultant will come later."

Grace nodded. The nurse opened the door and withdrew, leaving Grace inside without the usual second body to translate the room for her.

Her father lay where he always lay now, head slightly elevated, tubes neat, monitor glowing with its steady indifference. The sight of him struck her differently alone. Without her mother's composure beside the bed, without the consultant's verbs, without anybody to witness her witnessing, he looked less like a case and more like a man overwhelmed by apparatus.

Grace crossed to the chair and took his hand.

Warmth. That obscene, ordinary warmth.

"Hi," she said softly. Then, because the word sounded too small: "Hi, Dad."

No response. Only the monitor and the hum of the room.

She sat without speaking for a moment. She had become so used to language arriving pre-managed — stable, encouraged, tired, protected, delicate — that simple speech now felt almost illicit.

"I wanted to come before she did," Grace said at last. "There's something I wanted to tell you myself. Not because you can fix it. Not because you can approve it. I just wanted one thing not to arrive through somebody else."

She did not say Luc's name. She did not say transfer, Hong Kong, offer in principle. Those words belonged to the world outside the room. Here the point was simpler and more humiliating: she wanted one fact in her life to reach her father before it reached the machine.

The pen pressed lightly against her hip through the fabric. Grace took it out and looked at it in her hand. Black lacquer. Gold clip. The old stubborn weight that had once felt faintly theatrical and now felt like the only honest object in the building.

Gently, almost absurdly careful not to make a ritual of it, she placed it in his palm.

His fingers lay where sedation and gravity had left them.

Grace rested her own hand lightly over his for a moment, then drew back. "I brought you this," she said, and almost laughed at the childishness of it. As if hospitals were merely houses in which people forgot their things.

Her phone buzzed in her bag. She did not move.

The buzzing stopped. The room went on with its purchased calm.

She sat there with her eyes on his hand, on the pen lying across it, on the possibility that nothing at all would happen and she would still have to carry this morning out of the room as if it had mattered.

Then his fingers twitched.

So slight that for an instant she thought she had imagined it.

The pen rolled a fraction, caught against the base of his thumb, and his fingers closed — not properly, not with strength, but with the weak, imperfect insistence of habit finding something familiar before the rest of the body caught up.

Grace felt the surge of it as pain first, not relief.

Recognition. Not necessarily of her. Recognition of weight, of shape, of the old choreography between hand and object. Something his body still knew how to do when so much else had been taken from it.

"Dad," she whispered.

His eyelids fluttered. Once. Then again.

Grace leaned forward, the chair whispering against the floor.

"Dad. I'm here."

His eyes opened.

Not wide. Not clear. Just open enough for the room to alter around them. His gaze moved first through the light, past the curtains, over nothing she could name, and then found her face with a slowness so painful it seemed almost deliberate.

For one second the finding held.

His lips parted. A breath. Then another.

"Gra—"

The syllable was so small she might have doubted it in any other room.

Grace bent closer, her hair brushing the back of his hand.

"Yes."

His eyes stayed on her, the effort visible in them now.

"Grace," he said.

Not her role. Not darling. Not a misfired fragment of some older script.

Her name. Spoken as if it still belonged to her.

Grace felt tears sting so hard her eyes blurred. She did not let them fall. The moment was already too brief to survive being broken open.

"I'm here," she said. "I'm right here."

His mouth moved once more. No word came. His eyes drifted, flickered, then began to close again as if the room had become too heavy to keep entering.

Grace stayed bent over him for another second, as if proximity might keep the fact intact. Then she sat back slowly, hands trembling in her lap.

The pen still lay across his palm. She reached for it carefully and freed it from his fingers, not because she wanted to take it away but because she could not bear the idea of anyone else seeing it there and translating even that into encouraging.

A nurse stepped in, glanced at the monitor, then looked at Grace with the professionally gentle face staff wore when families needed handling.

"He opened his eyes," Grace said.

"That can happen," the nurse said softly. "Brief responses can be… encouraging. The consultant will be here in about an hour."

Encouraging. The word entered the room and began, at once, to clean what had happened.

Grace looked down at the pen in her hand. "He said my name."

This time the nurse's face altered. Not sentimentally. Humanly. "Oh," she said, and for a second the room held a better word than encouraging. Then professionalism

returned. "Stay with him. The consultant will want to know."

When she left, Grace sat very still beside the bed.

He had said her name.

Her name, not her role.

She repeated the fact in her mind as if repetition might protect it from becoming something else before lunch.

She stayed through the hour. She watched the curtain move slightly under the vent. She watched the numbers keep their private counsel. Once she took his hand again. Once she said, very quietly, "Thank you," though she did not know whether the thanks was for him, or for the body remembering what the social world would immediately begin trying to use.

When her mother arrived, she came in with the same composed face, the same steady posture, the same quiet assumption that the room belonged to her as much as it belonged to the patient.

"Grace," she said softly, and the softness meant: control yourself.

Grace stood. Her hand went automatically to her pocket.

"He opened his eyes," she said. She watched her mother's face as she said it. The relief was real. So was the utility.

"Good," her mother said at once. Then, immediately, "What did the nurse say."

Information. Always information first.

"Encouraging," Grace replied.

Her mother nodded, already turning the word into something the family could live inside. "See," she murmured. "Stable."

Grace said nothing. She would not surrender that fact to Sunday faces and Catherine's warmth and the soft verbs of women who believed hope only counted once it had been distributed correctly.

In the lift down, her mother spoke quietly about lunch, about Catherine calling later, about the consultant's schedule. Track being laid. The day already cleaning itself around the one thing Grace wanted left unclean.

Grace held the pen in her pocket like a secret.

CHAPTER XVIII — THE RECORD

By the time Grace came downstairs, her face had already been arranged.

That was what the house did. It gave you a staircase long enough to compose yourself on. It gave you polished surfaces in which to check whether your mouth had become too honest. It gave you time to become presentable before you re-entered the rooms where other people would decide what your feelings meant.

Her mother was in the sitting room, phone in hand, lamp light falling over the edge of one cheekbone. On speaker, Catherine's voice arrived as warmth before it arrived as sense.

"There she is," Catherine said. "Darling, I was beginning to think you'd escaped."

Grace remained standing. She did not sit. Sitting would have implied she was joining the conversation. Standing made her feel, if not freer, then less placed.

"I'm here," she said.

"Your mother tells me there was a little encouraging moment today," Catherine said, and Grace felt her throat tighten at once. There it was — the theft already under way. Her father had opened his eyes, had found her face, had said her name, and Catherine was already turning it into

an encouraging moment, something rounded and distributable.

"It was brief," her mother said. "The doctors were careful."

"Of course," Catherine replied. "But brief is not nothing. We take what we're given."

We. Given. The language of people who thought hope was a thing you displayed correctly.

Grace said, "He said my name."

The room altered by half a degree.

Her mother turned her head just enough to look at her. There was no anger there, only the sharpness that came when Grace put a private fact into public air. Catherine was quiet for a beat.

"That's wonderful," Catherine said, and Grace hated the word at once.

"It was brief," Grace repeated. "It may not mean anything."

"Darling," Catherine said, softer now, "it means it meant something to you. That's enough."

It was nearly a good sentence. That made it worse.

Her mother set the phone down on the side table and folded her hands together as if this were now a family conversation and not an interception. "Catherine was asking about Sunday," she said.

Of course she was.

Grace looked from one woman to the other and felt something inside her go still. Her father's mouth had

barely closed around her name before the machine had begun looking for a way to use the fact of it.

"Only lunch," Catherine said brightly. "Nothing heavy. Just faces. And now that there has been a little improvement—"

"Not improvement," Grace said.

She did not raise her voice. She did not need to. The word itself landed hard enough.

Catherine laughed very softly, the kind of laugh meant to absorb objection without acknowledging it. "Forgive me. Encouragement, then."

Her mother intervened. "We'll decide tomorrow. Grace is tired."

Tired. A word that removed as much as it excused.

"We mustn't let one moment become a drama," Catherine said. "People do that when they're frightened."

"You mean people talk," Grace said.

"I mean people make stories out of things they don't understand. The kindest thing we can do is give them less to work with."

Her mother said, "That's enough for tonight."

Catherine exhaled with audible sympathy. "Sleep, darling. And do not carry today too hard into tomorrow."

The call ended. The sitting room went quieter by half a degree.

Her mother raised her eyes and looked at Grace with that measured calm which always contained both concern and assessment. "You should sleep," she said. "Tomorrow will be busy."

Grace turned away before her face did something disobedient and went upstairs without asking permission to leave the room. No one called after her.

—

In her bedroom, she shut the door and stood with her back against it. Her father had said her name, and within hours that fact had become encouraging and Sunday and faces. If she left it in the mouths of other people, it would soon become something cleaner than it had been, and less true. She crossed to the desk, opened the drawer, and took out the pen.

It lay in her palm with the old, stubborn weight of intention. She understood with a small, cold clarity what it was for next.

Not memory.

Record.

She found a plain spiral notebook at the back of a cupboard — something left from years ago, one of those ordinary objects that survive only because they have no status and therefore no one bothers to curate them. She opened to the first page.

For a moment she did not know where to begin. Not because there was too much to say, but because everything she had lived through in the past weeks had already been translated for her by other people before she could set it down herself.

She lowered the pen and wrote the date. Then the time. Then, in a hand steadier than she felt:

He opened his eyes.

He held the pen.

He said Grace.

She stopped there. Not Dad opened his eyes. Not I think he recognised me. Just the facts in the order they had occurred. The notebook did not care whether the moment was wonderful or encouraging or only brief. It simply held what had happened.

Grace turned the page and wrote:

Catherine called.

Sunday lunch.

Faces.

Do not make one moment into drama.

When written out that way, the thing was uglier, not prettier.

She wrote until her hand began to ache. Not continuously. In pieces.

Mum answered hospital call.

"She's holding up."

Keys removed.

Calendar access updated.

Committee removed.

Deborah sends love.

Offer in Principle.

Screenshots taken.

Once the list began, it frightened her how easy it was to continue. The book of the thing had already existed inside her. She had simply never given herself permission to acknowledge that she was keeping one.

When she finally stopped, the first pages were full.

She closed the notebook and sat very still, the pen still in her hand. Doors did not slam here. Furniture did not creak. Grief, too, was expected to move without noise.

Her phone lay on the bed. The screenshots of Luc's email were still there. She opened them again.

Internal Transfer — Hong Kong — Offer in Principle.

The language remained dry, conditional, almost bureaucratically embarrassed by hope. Paperwork was the kind of thing her mother respected. It was also the kind of thing her mother could destroy.

She copied the details down. Not every clause. Not every line. Just enough: date, title, quarter, the words useful and inconvenient, the fact of it existing. Paper did not move when a password changed.

When she had finished, she tore the page out carefully, folded it twice, slid it into an unmarked envelope. She did not write Luc's name on the front. She did not write her own.

At the back of the wardrobe, behind the garment bag from the gala, was the suitcase she had arrived in from London — still half-packed, because part of her had resisted unpacking fully. She unzipped the inner compartment, tucked the envelope between the lining and a stack of academic articles she knew no one in the house would voluntarily touch, and zipped it shut.

Not a perfect hiding place. Good enough for a first move.

Grace stood with one hand on the suitcase and felt, for the first time since landing, a small, shameful pulse of calm. Not safety. Simply the knowledge that something now existed in the world because she had put it there, and not because Catherine had said it, or her mother had routed it, or Luc had offered it.

—

In the morning, breakfast was already waiting. Toast. Tea poured. The same illusion that order could substitute for consent.

Grace sat and ate because there were still mornings when you complied first so that you could move later.

Her mother entered already dressed. Pale jacket. Hair perfect. Her gaze took inventory of Grace's face, but

something in Grace had shifted slightly overnight and the gaze did not land in the same place.

"You slept," her mother said.

"Enough."

"The consultant will be there at ten. Then we'll come back. You will need to be ready by twelve-thirty."

"Ready for what."

"A short lunch. Nothing heavy. Sunday has become slightly more complicated."

Which meant: more necessary.

Grace put the cup down carefully. "I'm not going."

Her mother did not react at once. That was always when she was most dangerous. "Grace," she said, very gently, "you don't know that yet."

"I do."

Her mother's mouth softened into patience. "After yesterday, it would be wise to show your face."

There it was. Not even pretending any more that the lunch had anything to do with her father, or with family comfort, or with prayer.

"No."

The word sat between them. Not shouted. Not dramatic. Simply present.

Her mother did not change expression. "No," she repeated.

"No."

For a moment the room stopped being decorative and became tactical. Then her mother picked up her cup and took a sip. "We'll talk after the hospital," she said.

Grace nodded, because she did not need to win the whole thing at breakfast. She only needed the word to have been said out loud.

At the hospital, the same corridor, the same consultant with the same careful face. The machinery of encouragement continued.

When they were left for a moment at the bedside, Grace took her father's hand. She did not need another miracle. She only needed not to hand the last one over.

"I'm keeping it," she whispered. "I'm not giving it to them."

No response. Warmth. Chemistry. The small cruelty of a body remaining itself regardless of what language gathered around it.

When they left the room, her mother said, "Lunch at twelve-thirty."

Grace said, "No."

Her mother kept walking.

In the lift, mirrored walls threw them back at themselves: mother, daughter, the practised shapes of control. Her mother looked at her reflection instead of at Grace.

"You think one no is a revolution," she said.

Grace kept her eyes on the doors. "No," she said. "I think it's a word."

The lift opened.

Back at the house, her mother went to the study and began calling people. Grace could hear the softened warmth in her voice through the closed door. She went upstairs, took the notebook from the desk, the pen from where she had left it, and the envelope from the suitcase lining. She slipped all three into her bag.

The room looked the same as it had the night before. That was what made the change real. Nothing visible had altered.

Her phone buzzed. A message from Luc.

Are you all right.

Grace stared at it, then typed:

No. But I've started.

His reply came almost at once.

Yes.

No flourish. No question. No rescue.

Grace put the phone away, lifted her bag, and walked out of the room before anyone could arrange the next hour for her.

For the first time since her return, she was carrying something the machine did not yet know existed. The ink was dry. The pages were folded. The envelope made no sound. Behind her face, her own record moved with her, unannounced, into the day.

CHAPTER XIX — NO, THANK YOU

By the time they left the hospital, Grace had said no three times.

Once at breakfast, while the tea was still too hot and her mother's voice still patient.

Once in the car, when the route made it obvious that "we'll discuss it later" had never meant discussion.

And once again in the lift, reflected back at herself in brushed metal and expensive restraint, as if the building wanted a witness.

No.

The word had not grown larger with repetition. It had grown stranger.

Her father had not opened his eyes that day. The consultant had worn the same careful face and the same language that had become so familiar it felt less like medicine than weather. If it occurs. The clause remaining where it had been, clean and impossible to love. Grace had held her father's hand and felt nothing new arrive through it. Only warmth. Machines. Chemistry.

Now the car was moving away from the hospital and not towards home.

"We will stay forty minutes," her mother said, as if length could alter purpose. "No more."

Grace looked out at the city. The route was no longer pretending. Connaught Road fell away; the turn towards the Club announced itself without shame.

"I'm not going," she said.

Her mother did not sigh. Sighing would have made this emotional. "Grace."

"No."

"Catherine has kept it small."

"No."

A beat. Not surprise. Registration. "You are tired."

Grace looked at the passing pavement — the office workers crossing at the lights, the courier on a bicycle, the woman carrying flowers in one hand and a phone in the other. Ordinary people moved through the day without needing to perform steadiness for it.

"No."

For a moment the silence in the back seat changed texture. Her mother was still operating in full sentences, in the old elegant architecture of management — named conditions, calm certainty, correction implied at the end. Grace was meeting each sentence with the smallest available word. Three letters. No furnishing. No place for the room to settle.

Her mother spoke at last. "Then you may sit there and be impossible for forty minutes."

The Club received them in cool air, polished wood, and the kind of discretion that had long ago stopped pretending not to be class. The foyer smelled faintly of lilies and old money. A woman at the desk recognised Mrs Purvis at once and lowered her voice as if sorrow improved when spoken softly enough.

"Mrs Purvis. They're waiting in the Harbour Room."

Grace followed her mother down the corridor because following still cost less than making a scene in the foyer. Carpet muted their steps. Somewhere glass touched china with the tiny sound of people being careful around themselves.

Inside, the room had already decided what sort of lunch this would be.

Catherine rose first, smile already tuned to concern. Augusta sat beside her in cream, hands folded, face arranged into the therapeutic register she preferred when power wanted to look moral. Grace's aunt — not the one from the restaurant, another, older, cleverer about where she placed her sympathy — sat nearest the window. A waiter stood near the sideboard with a silver pot and the expression of a man trained to disappear in stages.

"There she is," Catherine said. "Darling, we kept it very small."

Grace remained standing.

"Sit," her mother said quietly.

A chair was drawn back. The waiter moved towards her with tea.

"Tea, Miss Purvis?"

"No, thank you," Grace said.

The waiter paused. It was only a second, but the room registered it.

Catherine's smile did not alter. "Just hot water, perhaps."

"No, thank you."

The waiter retreated without offence. That was the thing about rooms like this: you could say no to service and still be made to feel as though the difficulty had arisen in the waiter, not in the refusal.

Augusta tilted her head slightly. "You do look very pale."

Pale was always a useful diagnosis because it could mean grief, exhaustion, instability, or merely bad lighting, depending on what the room required later.

Her aunt leaned forward. "We only wanted to see you for a moment."

"After yesterday, it felt wiser to keep things face-to-face," Catherine said.

Yesterday. As if her father's saying her name had been something collectively owned.

Grace sat because standing any longer would have turned the afternoon into a drama before it had finished showing her what it wanted.

Menus were placed before the other women. None before Grace. Catherine noticed and smiled as if that, too, were kindness.

"We thought nothing heavy," she said. "Soup, perhaps. Or simply fruit."

"No, thank you," Grace said.

This time no one looked at the waiter.

Her mother set down her napkin. "Grace."

"No."

Her aunt glanced at Catherine, and Catherine let a tiny sympathetic silence bloom — the sort that converted resistance into evidence without anyone needing to name it.

"It's all right," Augusta said softly. "People under strain often lose the practical appetite before anything else."

There it was. Not hunger. Not preference. Condition.

"I'm not under strain," Grace said. "I'm saying no."

Catherine moved first, smoothing the air before the sentence had time to harden. "Darling, nobody is disagreeing with you. We are only trying to spare you unnecessary fuss."

Relieved. Encouraged. Tired. Supported. Wise. Under strain. Each word arriving softly, none of them neutral.

"Forty minutes," her mother said. "And then you may go home. People only need to see that you're all right."

That was the sentence. Not lunch. Not family. Not comfort. Visibility. A room arranged so that other rooms could be calmed by the sight of her remaining legible.

Grace looked from one woman to another. The room had already made peace with every version except the one in which she simply meant no.

If she stayed, she was wise.

If she left, she was tired.

If she resisted, she was unwell.

Catherine was speaking again. "You know how people are. If they don't see you, they invent—"

Grace stood.

The chair legs whispered against the carpet. Nothing louder.

Her mother's voice dropped. "Sit down."

"No."

She walked to the door before anyone could turn the word into an exchange.

—

The corridor received her without surprise. Carpet, light, paintings no one really looked at. She reached the foyer before she heard her mother behind her. Not heels striking loudly. Just the precise sound of a woman who had chosen not to hurry because hurrying would imply loss of control.

"Grace."

Grace stopped. The reception desk was ten feet away. Two staff members in view. Good. Let there be witnesses.

When she turned, her mother was standing exactly far enough away to preserve the fiction of civility.

"You will come back into that room."

"No."

"You are tired."

"No."

"You are under strain."

"No."

The repetition altered something in the space between them. Her mother was still using full sentences, still operating in the old elegant architecture of control — the soft certainty, the named condition, the implication of correction waiting at the end. Grace was meeting each one with the smallest possible word. Three syllables total. The effect was not dramatic. It was flattening. Her mother was a person who required the texture of an exchange, and Grace was refusing to provide any.

"Do you understand what this looks like."

Grace thought of the notebook in her bag. "Yes. That's why I'm leaving."

For the first time, something flashed in her mother's face fast enough to be called anger before it was replaced by discipline.

"You think this helps you."

Grace almost smiled. Not because anything was funny. Because the question was so honest.

"No. I think it stays true longer."

"What does that even mean."

"It means I'm going home."

Her mother let out a breath so controlled it was almost silent. "If you walk out now, Catherine will say you were unwell."

Grace understood, finally and fully, what the ceiling actually was. It was not that she could not refuse. It was that refusal would be named for her afterwards. There were only acts that held their shape longer before translation.

"Then she'll say that," Grace said.

Her mother's face went still.

This was not victory. Catherine would say it. Augusta would believe it or pretend to. The no would not prevent narrative. It would only force the narrative to work harder. Which, suddenly, seemed enough for one day.

"You are being reckless."

Grace thought of the email. Offer in Principle. She thought of the notebook. She thought of her father's mouth shaping her name.

"No," she said. "I'm being accurate."

For one second neither of them moved.

Then her mother said, in a voice so calm it was almost conversational, "Go, then."

The permission arrived too late to be permission at all. It was a salvage operation.

Grace inclined her head because courtesy was also a weapon, then turned and walked out through the foyer and into the heat.

—

Outside, the day was bright enough to feel punishing. Cars lined the kerb. Drivers waited in the shade. The city moved on in front of her, unsentimental and precise.

Grace did not call for the family car. She walked.

Not far at first. Only to the end of the block, then another, then around the corner where the Club could no longer see her. Her pulse was still too high. Her mouth was dry. She had the peculiar sensation that everyone who passed her could somehow tell that a room full of people had just tried to convert her into a symptom and had, for now, failed. She knew this was not true. The city did not care. That was the thing the machine had never understood about the city: it was actually indifferent, and indifference, in the right moment, was a kind of shelter.

For the first time since returning to Hong Kong, something shifted in Grace that had nothing to do with Luc, nothing to do with kissing, nothing to do with a room offered by a

man who understood her. This was smaller than that and harder. This was not being swept.

She stopped at a crossing and waited for the light to change. Buses moved. Tyres passed through old rain. Nobody looked at her long enough to make a sentence.

She stopped under the shade of a tree and took the notebook from her bag.

Standing on the pavement, she opened to a blank page and wrote:

Sunday lunch. No, thank you. "You are tired." "If you walk out now, Catherine will say you were unwell." Then she'll say that.

She underlined the last sentence once. Not because it was brave. Because it was the first time she had answered consequence without pretending consequence would disappear.

The notebook lay back in her bag with the pen and the folded pages. Not safety. Not freedom. Only the first crude architecture of something that belonged to her before it belonged to language.

She did not yet know how to hold the no. She only knew she would need paper for it.

CHAPTER XX — THEY CALLED IT TIRED

By nine-thirty the story had already reached people who had not been in the room.

Grace was still upstairs when her phone began to fill. Not with drama. Drama would have been easier to fight. Not even with questions. Questions at least admitted the possibility of an answer.

What arrived instead was concern in its social form.

Thinking of you. Do rest today. Grief takes strange shapes. So wise to leave when you needed to. Be gentle with yourself.

One from an auntie she barely liked. One from a woman on the charity board who had not looked at Grace twice in six months. One from a man whose name she knew only because he had once sponsored a school auction. None of them used the word unwell. None of them needed to. The category had already been agreed.

Grace sat on the edge of the bed in yesterday's T-shirt and stared at the screen until the messages stopped looking like individual sentences and became a texture.

She opened the notebook. Date. Time. Names. She wrote them down in a single column, then beneath them:

Not present. Still told.

Another message arrived while she was writing. Deborah.

Darling. Heard yesterday was a little too much. Please don't worry — these things happen. Rest. D x

Grace looked at it for a full ten seconds before placing the phone face down on the bedspread. A little too much. These things happen. She wrote the message down almost verbatim. Not because she was afraid of forgetting the words. Because she wanted to remember the register. The ease of it. The speed with which reality had already become consensus.

When she finished, she sat very still and listened to the house. It was already awake below her in its competent, well-bred way: softened footsteps, porcelain, the faint hum of air-conditioning, a door closed with the exact amount of pressure needed not to be audible as irritation. No raised voices. No panic. The house did not stage panic. It simply adjusted.

She stood, washed her face, dressed, and went downstairs because not appearing would become another story, and she was tired of losing time to things she had not chosen.

Breakfast was already waiting. Toast. Tea poured. The quiet presumption that the day had already been set.

Her mother was in the dining room already dressed, already composed, already holding her phone as if the morning were something she needed to steer with one hand. She looked up once — a quick assessment, stripped

of ceremony, a reading taken without the trouble of disguise.

"You're up," her mother said.

Grace sat. "Apparently."

Her mother let that pass. "Eat."

Grace took the toast because it was the easiest thing to hold.

The silence lasted long enough to become deliberate. Then her mother said, "People were concerned yesterday."

Grace laughed once, without humour. "You worked quickly."

Her mother's expression did not change. "I did not work at anything. You left a room abruptly. People noticed. They formed impressions."

"You told them I was unwell."

"No," her mother said. "I told them you were tired."

The distinction was meant to sound humane.

Grace looked at her. "And what do you think tired means in those rooms."

Her mother set her cup down precisely. "It means bereaved. Overstretched. Human."

"It means manageable," Grace said.

That made her mother look at her properly. For a second neither of them moved.

Then her mother said, "Only if you insist on making it harder than it needs to be."

There was no point arguing over the wording.

Grace broke off a piece of toast she did not want. "Who have you spoken to."

Her mother's mouth softened into what other people would have mistaken for patience. "Grace."

"Who."

"People who needed to be reassured."

"About me."

"About the situation," her mother said. "You are not the situation."

The cruelty of the sentence was not in its volume. It was in its neatness.

Grace thought of her father opening his eyes. She thought of Catherine's encouraging moment. She thought of Deborah writing these things happen as if she had merely missed a step on a pavement.

Her mother said, "Augusta is dropping by later."

Not asked. Announced.

Grace felt her back go cold. "Why."

"She was worried."

"No," Grace said. "She's curious."

Her mother did not deny it. "Curiosity and concern are not always separate."

They are, Grace thought. In this city they are simply dressed alike.

"The consultant will be there at ten. You'll want to be ready."

"And after that."

"After that you rest."

"From what."

Her mother's gaze remained level. "From making ordinary things difficult."

"I don't want Augusta in the house," Grace said.

Her mother did not blink. "Then speak to her elsewhere."

It took Grace a second to understand the sentence. Her mother had not said no because her mother had already solved the problem. A meeting elsewhere could still be routed, witnessed, softened, and later described as concern. It would also keep the house itself clean of overt intervention.

"Her office," her mother said. "Forty minutes. After the hospital."

"You are trying to shape me," Grace said.

Her mother looked at her over the cup. "That is the same thing if you want to survive here."

There was no point answering that. The answer lived in every page Grace had already written.

—

At the hospital, her father did not open his eyes. When her mother stepped into the corridor with the consultant, Grace stayed beside the bed and took the pen from her

pocket. She did not put it in his hand this time. She simply held it while she held his other hand, the metal warming slowly in her palm.

"They said I was tired," she told him softly. No answer. "They said I was unwell without saying the word." No answer. The machine made its small indifferent sound. The room remained itself: expensive, quiet, precise.

Grace looked at her father's face and felt, for the first time since his brief waking, less need for him to answer and more need for herself not to lose the shape of what had happened.

"I know," she whispered.

Her mother came back in exactly on time. "We have to go." Not Are you ready. Never that.

—

Augusta's office occupied two quiet floors in a building where everyone dressed as if softness itself had a dress code. Beige carpet. Glass bowls of white stones. Water in stemless glasses. Grace sat in the waiting area and found herself thinking, absurdly, that grief in Hong Kong had far too many upholstery choices.

Augusta came out herself to greet her. Cream blouse, pale skirt, a softness simplified for professional use. She kissed Grace's cheek lightly and touched her elbow as if contact were already treatment.

"Thank you for coming," she said.

Grace wanted to say: I didn't. Instead she nodded and followed Augusta into an office arranged to imply calm without ever risking personality.

Her mother did not come in. That was new in form. Her mother was still in the room by proxy. Augusta's usefulness depended on Grace believing, for forty minutes, that what happened here would not be immediately translated into household instruction.

Augusta sat opposite, not behind the desk. For a moment she said nothing. That too was a technique.

Then: "How are you sleeping."

No preliminaries. Straight to symptom.

Grace said, "Badly." Because it was true, and because false wellness only gave this kind of room more power.

Augusta nodded. "That makes sense." Then: "Your mother is worried you're carrying too much alone."

My mother is worried I might carry it somewhere she can't reach, Grace thought.

"She's worried," Augusta continued, "that because you are so good at functioning, people may miss how much you're actually under."

Grace almost laughed. The sentence was nearly elegant. That was what made it dangerous.

"I'm not hiding," Grace said.

"No," Augusta replied, voice gentling. "You're coping."

The word was somehow worse than tired.

"And what do you think the difference is."

Augusta did not answer immediately. She was clever enough to let the room register the question. Finally she said, "Coping is expensive."

Something true. And, because it was true, all the more useful to the machinery around it.

"Did Catherine say I was unwell," Grace asked.

Augusta's expression did not change, but some small guard moved behind it. "Catherine said you had a difficult afternoon."

"Did she say I shouldn't have been at the club."

Augusta tilted her head slightly. "I don't think that's the useful question."

Grace felt the notebook opening in her head. "What is the useful question."

"How much of this you want to carry alone."

The turn again. Not answering what had been asked. Redirecting from social fact to internal condition.

"No," Grace said.

Augusta's brow shifted. "No."

"The useful question is what people have been told."

For the first time Augusta looked almost honest. "Grace," she said quietly, "sometimes when people are frightened, they reach for explanations that make them feel less powerless."

"And what explanation makes them feel less powerless about me."

Augusta held her gaze. "That you are grieving. That you are tired. That you are under a great deal of pressure."

Grace let the words sit. Not unstable. Not yet.

She could feel the structure of it though. The smaller words always arrived first, laying the floor for the larger one. Tired. Pressure. Strain. Under. Then, if you resisted too visibly, someone else would speak of fragility. Then concern. Then treatment. Every stage deniable. Every stage social.

Augusta leaned forward slightly. "You don't have to fight every room."

Grace understood that Augusta truly believed this. She did not think of herself as enforcing anything. She thought she was advising a younger woman against wasteful resistance.

"I'm not fighting every room," Grace said. "Only the ones that start speaking for me."

The sentence sat there between them.

Augusta's mouth softened. "That may be more rooms than you can afford."

There it was. Not a threat. An estimate.

Grace stood. Augusta did not look surprised. She looked disappointed, which was more efficient.

"Tell your mother I'm grateful for the tea," Grace said.

Augusta's eyes held hers one second longer than was comfortable. "I will tell her you are bright enough to make this difficult for yourself."

Grace almost smiled. "You can tell her I already know."

She left before Augusta could produce a final kindness.

—

Outside, the day had turned heavy. Heat sat against the skin rather than moving across it. Grace walked two blocks before she took her phone out. Five messages: two from the house, one from an auntie, one unknown missed call, one from Theresa.

Heard about Augusta. Are you all right.

Grace stared at the message. Theresa did not say how are you sleeping. Theresa did not soften anything. She named the fact and then asked the real question.

Grace typed back: No. But still accurate.

The reply came quickly.

Good.

Grace looked at the word. Not approval. Not data passed inspection. Simply: understood.

By the time she came home, the house had settled into the hour before dinner, when nothing visible happened and everything consequential already had. Her mother was in the study. The door was half-open. Grace paused outside it and listened.

Catherine's voice, tinny through the speaker.

"...not to worry anyone. Simply tired. Augusta agrees she is carrying too much alone."

Augusta agrees.

The seal, applied.

Grace did not step into the room. She took out the notebook instead and wrote standing in the corridor, balancing the page against the wall:

Augusta agrees. Tired. Carrying too much alone.

Seal applied.

She closed the notebook and went upstairs before anyone could see her holding it.

At dinner, her mother said nothing about Augusta. Nothing about tired. Nothing about Sunday. That was how you knew the decisions had already been made elsewhere.

CHAPTER XXI — SOMEONE HAD LOOKED

It was the blouse first.

Half an inch too far to the left on the back of the chair. Not crumpled. Not dropped. Merely no longer where she had left it. The top button faced the window instead of the wardrobe.

Enough only because Grace had become the sort of woman who noticed millimetres.

She stood in the middle of the room and looked again. The chair itself had not moved. The curtains hung as they had that morning. The bed was made with the same expensive exactness. Yet the blouse was wrong, and once it was wrong other things began loosening around it.

The suitcase beside the wardrobe was not where it had been either. Not by much. One wheel no longer sat flush with the line in the floorboards she had been using as a guide without realising she had chosen it.

Grace crossed to it, knelt, and pulled it towards her with more care than the motion required. The wheels whispered against the floor. She unzipped the inner compartment and slid her fingers beneath the lining.

Of course not empty. The academic articles were still there. The lining was still intact. Nothing obvious gone. But the articles had shifted. The corners no longer met as neatly as

they had before. One page had been bent and flattened again.

Someone had looked.

Grace sat back on her heels and felt not fear, exactly, but confirmation. Confirmation was worse in some ways. Fear could still be argued with. Confirmation simply entered the body and took up space. It did not require panic. Only acknowledgement, which was the one thing the house was perfectly designed to prevent.

She closed the suitcase carefully, pushed it back where it had been, then stood and listened. Downstairs, a staff door opened and closed. A cup touched a saucer. The house continued with the normality of a body that had learned how to hide illness from itself.

She crossed to the bag by the chair. Notebook. Pen. First envelope. Second copy. All still there. For one second she had to close her eyes against the relief, because relief had become dangerous too. Relief made you careless. Relief made you believe a thing was over when it had only changed shape.

She opened the notebook and wrote:

Room entered.

Blouse moved.

Suitcase touched.

Envelope still there.

No accusation. No interpretation. Not Mum searched. Not they are looking for proof. Just the physical evidence in sequence. It calmed her at once — not because it solved anything, but because it prevented the scene from dissolving into self-doubt. The page held what the room would otherwise keep asking her to be less sure of.

There was a knock at the door. Not loud. Not apologetic either. A knock that already assumed the answer.

"Come in," Grace said, because refusing would have required a reason and reasons were now a form of leverage.

The staff woman from the week before stepped in carrying a tray. Tea, always tea. A small plate of sliced fruit. The house's chosen grammar for female distress.

"Mrs Purvis says you've not had enough this morning," the woman said softly.

Grace looked at the tray and then at the woman's face. The woman kept her eyes lowered with the practised tact of someone whose employment depended on seeing without ever acknowledging that she had seen.

"Leave it there," Grace said.

She almost asked, Were you in here. She did not. It would have been unfair or useless or both. In houses like this, labour moved where it was sent. Asking the wrong person for truth was one of the easier ways to become decorative in your own life.

The woman turned to leave, then hesitated just enough to be visible. "Miss Grace."

Grace looked up.

"Your mother is in the study. She asked that you come down when you're ready."

When you're ready. The house had endless ways of making instruction sound like permission.

After the woman left, three facts sat in the room together without competing. Someone had looked. The house wanted her downstairs. The record needed to leave the house today.

Grace took the cheap lockbox from the carrier bag in the bottom drawer and unlocked it. Grey metal. Anonymous. She placed the notebook inside, then the spare envelopes, then the first copied page. She left the second copy out. One in the house was not the same as one in the post. One in her room was not the same as one outside it.

She locked the box and slid the key onto the ring in her bag. Then she took two clean sheets and copied what mattered most: dates, names, the lunch, tired, Augusta, the offer in principle, screenshots taken, and now the room entered. She folded each sheet into an addressed envelope. One to the solicitor's PO box in London. One to the departmental post room where paper still outlived email.

Only then did she go downstairs.

Her mother was in the study behind the desk, phone set aside, papers squared, the room arranged to make decisions look like administration rather than power.

She looked up. "There is a lunch tomorrow. You will not attend. I have said you are exhausted."

The sentence was delivered as gift rather than verdict.

Grace stood in the doorway and felt, absurdly, the urge to laugh. Yesterday she had walked out and become tired by evening. Today exhausted had been chosen for her before lunch. The vocabulary was advancing on schedule.

"Thank you," she said.

Her mother studied her face for a beat. "You will rest today."

"No," Grace said. "I'm going out."

"Where."

"Paperwork."

The word was dry enough to survive the room.

Her mother's mouth softened. "Can it wait."

"No."

A pause. "One hour," her mother said. "And answer if I call."

Grace nodded because there was no point fighting for a larger permission when the smaller one was enough.

She left the house without the driver, hailed a taxi, and gave the post office address in Central.

The post office was fluorescent, queue-numbered, practical, full of people sending parcels and paying bills. The sort of place no one from the Club would ever voluntarily be seen waiting. Grace took a numbered ticket and waited between an old man sending forms to Kowloon and a woman with three taped boxes and a child leaning against her hip. Nobody looked at her twice. Nobody cared that she came from the Club.

When her number was called, she went to the counter and sent both envelopes by registered post.

The clerk stamped, weighed, printed, slid receipts across the counter.

"Both registered," he said.

"Yes," Grace replied.

Outside, she stood beneath the awning and opened the notebook.

Envelope one posted.

Envelope two posted.

Registered.

Then, beneath them:

The house can enter a room. It cannot enter the post.

She underlined can once and post twice, then stopped before the sentence became too pleased with itself.

Her phone buzzed.

Luc.

Did they find it.

Not Are you all right. Not How bad. Not What happened.

Did they find it. He was learning the same architecture now.

Grace typed: They looked. Too late.

His reply came almost immediately.

Good.

Not approval. Not reassurance. Exact recognition of a small move having held.

Grace slipped the phone into her bag and left the post office with the receipts in her pocket, the tracking numbers in the notebook, and the city still utterly indifferent to what had just changed.

For the first time all day, Grace smiled without touching her face afterwards to check whether it had become legible.

Nothing in the visible world had altered.

It did not need a witness to become real.

CHAPTER XXII — SUPPORT

By eleven, her mother had turned Grace into an appointment.

Not publicly. Not yet. Publicly Grace was still tired, still under pressure, still being given space. Privately, the next move had already been made in the language the family preferred when the softer words stopped working. Not accusation. Not punishment. Support.

The message arrived while Grace was still upstairs, standing beside the wardrobe with the lockbox key in her hand, trying to decide whether to move the notebooks again or wait another day.

3:00 PM. Dr Chao. Augusta thought it wise. Forty minutes. Just to talk.

No greeting. No signature. The message came from her mother and wore her mother's confidence like perfume. Even just to talk had the smoothness of something already decided for her.

Grace read it twice, then opened the notebook and wrote the time and the wording exactly.

3:00 PM.

Dr Chao.

Augusta thought it wise.

Just to talk.

The thing that made her chest tighten was not the appointment itself. It was how quickly the category had moved. Yesterday she had been tired. Then, in Augusta's office, she had become a woman carrying too much alone. Overnight that had hardened into a doctor. Support was what they called intervention before the forms arrived.

Downstairs, the house had arranged itself as it always did. Tea. The quiet presumption that the day had already been set. Her mother was in the study with the door half-open, phone at her ear, her voice so soft it had to be listened to. Grace caught only the end of the sentence.

"...no, no. I agree. Better sooner than later."

Her mother saw Grace in the doorway and did not pause. She only lifted one finger — the sign of someone entitled to assume waiting as obedience. Grace stood there long enough to hate herself for doing it.

When the call ended, her mother looked up with a face that had already chosen its tone. "You saw the message."

"Yes."

Her mother nodded. "Good."

"What if I say no," Grace asked.

Her mother's mouth softened. "To what."

Such an old trick. Make the other person restate the ugly thing in full; by the time it is repeated it already sounds less defensible.

"To the appointment."

"Then you will still be tired," her mother said, "and now difficult as well."

Grace reached into her bag and touched the edge of the notebook through the lining. The pages were no defence against the room she was in, but they prevented the room from becoming the only version of itself. That mattered more now than it had a week ago. A week ago she had still been surprised by the machine. Now she was studying it.

"I'm not sick," Grace said.

Her mother's eyes did not move. "No one said you were."

"Not yet."

A pause. Her mother picked up a glass from the trolley, took one sip, and set it back untouched. "You're grieving. You're exhausted. You are carrying more than you know how to carry. Talking to someone does not make you weak."

In any cleaner world the sentence might have been true enough to be kindness. Here it arrived already pre-contaminated by the uses to which it would be put.

"And if I say something you don't like in the room," Grace said.

"Then perhaps someone neutral will help you hear yourself."

Nobody in Hong Kong was neutral at this altitude.

"Who is Dr Chao," Grace asked.

"A psychiatrist," her mother said. "Family friend. He is discreet."

Discreet meant his words would travel only to the rooms that already mattered.

Grace nodded once and said nothing. The morning moved anyway.

At ten, the hospital. The same private-ward hush. The same consultant face. Her father did not open his eyes. She no longer waited for him to; that was perhaps the worst part of the day, the speed with which even miracles began to settle into memory and lose the right to be expected.

She held his hand and tried not to think of rooms. But rooms had become the real units of the story. The room at the Club. The office with the chipped mug. The island café with plastic chairs. Her mother's study. Now another office at three o'clock where support would be converted into findings.

Dr Chao's building was in Mid-Levels, discreet and expensive in a way that wanted to feel therapeutic rather than corporate. No brass plaque. Just a muted lobby, pale stone, cool air.

Her mother did not come in. That was new in form. Not in essence. The usefulness of the room depended on Grace being able to believe, for forty minutes, that what happened inside it would not be immediately translated into household instruction.

Dr Chao came out himself.

Late fifties. Dark suit without tie. Rimless glasses. A face arranged into alert gentleness — nothing soft enough to look weak, nothing sharp enough to look threatening. He greeted Mrs Purvis first, then Grace, then stood aside.

"Grace," he said. No darling. No dear girl. No lowered voice. It was almost a relief.

Her mother rose. "I'll wait."

Of course she would.

Inside, the office was warmer than the lobby and less anonymous than she had expected. Bookshelves. A desk pushed to one side. Two chairs angled towards one another. Books that looked read. A box of tissues on the low table — blunt, almost comic in its honesty.

He gestured her to a chair, took the other, notebook on one knee, pen uncapped but not yet moving. He sat only after Grace had sat. That, too, she noticed.

For a long moment he said nothing.

Then: "How are you sleeping."

"Badly," Grace said. Because it was true, and because false wellness only gave this kind of room more power.

He nodded once. "I'm going to say something, and I want you to hear the whole sentence before reacting."

"When people are under prolonged strain," he said, "their threshold for pattern recognition changes."

Not you are imagining things. Not this is in your head. Something professionally cleaner, more deniable, and therefore more dangerous.

Grace said nothing.

He continued. "That does not mean what you are noticing isn't real. It means the meaning attached to what you notice can become overdetermined."

"I understand the word," she said.

"I assumed you would."

Grace leaned back. "What did my mother ask you to decide."

The hesitation was honest enough to register. "She asked me to consider whether support would be useful."

"And what would support mean."

"Sleep, first," he said. "Reduction in stimulus. Fewer rooms you have to manage. Possibly a short prescription. Possibly time away from family decision-making."

The architecture of it lay plain. Reduce. Rest. Step back. Let others decide while you stabilise. The same operation in medical dress.

"My father is in hospital."

"Yes."

"I am not stepping back from his life because other people prefer me easier to narrate."

He was quiet for a moment. Then: "That's not what I said."

Which was true, and almost irrelevant. Rooms like this were built on people never quite saying the thing they were nevertheless building.

Grace stood. He remained seated. Most men in rooms like this stood when a woman in distress rose too quickly. Standing was correction disguised as care. He stayed where he was and let the movement remain hers.

"I'm not taking anything."

"I didn't offer medication."

Not yet, she thought.

"Will you tell my mother I was difficult."

That made him look at her properly for the first time. "No," he said. "I'll tell her you were clear."

Grace hated how relieved that made her feel. She should not need that sentence. She did.

He set the pen on the table between them. "There is one thing I will tell her."

Grace waited.

"That you should not be spoken for in rooms you are in."

It was not enough to make him safe. It was enough to make the room more complicated than she had expected.

He did not offer his hand when she turned to go. He only said, "Sleep if you can. Write if you can't."

That stopped her. Not because it was brilliant. Because it was the first sentence in the room that did not try to reroute what she was already doing.

Her mother rose from the waiting-room chair the moment the door opened.

"Well."

Not really a question. A net lowered over the room to catch whatever had happened and make it usable.

Grace said, "He said I was clear."

For the first time in the entire day, her mother had no immediate answer.

Dr Chao came to the door behind her and said to Mrs Purvis, with the elegance of a man who understood exactly what he was doing, "She is exhausted, but not confused. I would keep things simple."

Simple. Grace heard the fault line.

Her mother smiled with enormous control. "Of course."

In the car home she said nothing for twelve whole minutes. Then: "He is very experienced."

"I'm sure," Grace said.

A pause.

"You embarrassed yourself in front of no one," her mother said, and the sentence was almost generous. "That is something."

At home, the house felt unchanged and therefore more sinister. Tea appeared. Doors closed quietly. Staff moved with the same trained invisibility. The machine did not dramatise setback. It simply absorbed and recalculated.

Grace went upstairs and opened the notebook.

Dr Chao.

Threshold for pattern recognition changes.

Support: reduce / rest / fewer rooms / possible prescription.

He said: clear.

He said: should not be spoken for in rooms she is in.

Sleep if you can. Write if you can't.

She stopped there. She had wanted to write Not neutral. Not useless, but the phrase arrived already dressed as interpretation. The notebook did not need her opinion of the room. It needed what had happened in it.

Three messages had arrived while she was in the car. One from Catherine: So glad you spoke to someone. Sensible. Rest if you can. One from an auntie: Your mother says you've finally let someone help. Good girl. One from a board woman she barely knew: Thinking of you. Wise to get support early.

She had left Dr Chao's office less than an hour ago and already the fact of having gone had been detached from her and distributed as character evidence. She was no longer a woman who had been routed into an appointment. She was a woman wise enough to seek support.

She opened the notebook again and added only what the messages had actually said.

Catherine: sensible.

Auntie: finally let someone help.

Board woman: wise.

Then she set the notebook down, took the carbon paper from the stationery bag, and made a second set of impressions from the last pages. The practical awkwardness steadied her. Carbon paper did not care whether she felt melodramatic. It simply took pressure and made a second trace.

When she finished, she tucked the duplicate pages into the second envelope and crossed to the laundry cupboard at the end of the corridor — detergent, spare towels, domestic anonymity — and slid the envelope between two unopened packets of guest soaps on the highest shelf. No one in the house would search guest soaps first. That was not certainty. It was sequencing.

Near midnight, her mother knocked.

Not the house's knock. Her mother's own. A strange courtesy.

"Come in," Grace said.

Her mother entered without phone, without jacket, without the obvious tools. Just herself in a pale robe that made her look, briefly and misleadingly, like a woman rather than a system. She sat in the chair by the window without asking. For a moment neither spoke.

Then her mother said, "He likes you."

Grace knew at once she meant Dr Chao.

"He believes I can speak," Grace said.

"Do not be glib."

The room went still.

"You wanted him to say I was tired in a more expensive accent," Grace said.

Her mother did not flinch. "I wanted him to tell me whether you were making yourself harder to help."

"And."

"And he said you were clear." Her mother's voice remained level. "That is inconvenient."

There it was, almost naked.

Grace looked at her hands. "You could stop helping it."

"No," her mother said.

The honesty of it struck harder than any denial would have.

For a moment neither moved. Then her mother's eyes shifted, not to Grace's face, but to the desk. To the drawer. To the room.

When she spoke again, her tone had returned to its ordinary softness, which was worse.

"If you are going to keep records, do not leave them where staff can find them."

CHAPTER XXIII — THE PORTABLE SENTENCE

By breakfast, the midnight sentence had altered the category of the room.

Nothing visible had changed. Tea still arrived before she asked. The curtains had been drawn to the same measured width. Her mother still sat at the table already dressed, already composed, already operating. Yet the house now contained a fact it had not contained the day before. Her mother knew about the record. Knew, accepted, and had moved at once not to confession but to instruction. If you are going to keep records, do not leave them where staff can find them. The sentence had followed Grace into sleep and then into waking. It had not interrupted the machinery. It had merely improved its route.

A small cream card sat beside her plate in Catherine's hand.

Thinking of you. Deborah is all softness at the moment, so do be gentle if she appears. Love, C.

Grace read it twice and felt, before the day had even begun, that the room had been arranged ahead of her. Deborah had not yet spoken. Deborah had already been interpreted.

Her mother buttered toast without looking up. "Catherine was worried there might be awkwardness."

"About what."

Her mother glanced at the note. The question had already answered itself. "About Deborah. She has had a difficult few days."

Grace folded the card once and set it beside her cup. "I wasn't aware Deborah and I had anything to do with one another."

"That is a luxury other people do not always enjoy," her mother said. "Not everyone enters a room without consequence."

Grace took a sip of tea and let the heat sit on her tongue before answering. "What am I meant to have done."

"Nothing dramatic," her mother said. "Only remember that not every story begins when you become aware of it."

Grace looked at her mother across the table and understood that by lunchtime some version of care for Deborah would already have become social fact.

At the hospital the consultant said nothing new, which had become its own kind of violence. Monitoring. Caution. Small changes, no promises. Her father lay in the bed under the thin blanket and clean light with the same terrible quietness he had worn all week. On the side table, among the flowers and cards and expensive tokens of managed sympathy, stood a new arrangement of pale orchids. Grace turned the card over.

Thinking of you and your father. Such delicate days. D.

Delicate. A word that made intrusion sound breakable and injury sound refined. Grace put the card back where she had found it.

Her mother, from the chair by the window, said, "Very thoughtful."

"How useful," Grace replied.

Her mother looked up sharply. "You are in a hospital room."

"Yes."

"Then at least try to behave as though the location still means something."

Grace looked at her father's face and thought that the room meant more than any of them could bear once it stopped being social. But she said nothing.

When they returned to the house, Catherine was already in the sitting room with tea she was not drinking. Pearls, silk, perfect posture. She rose as Grace entered.

"There you are," she said warmly. "This whole thing with Deborah has become more painful than it needed to be."

Grace remained standing. "What whole thing."

Catherine exchanged the briefest glance with Grace's mother, who had paused near the drinks trolley with the stillness of someone letting another person perform the first layer of unpleasantness.

"Deborah had hopes," Catherine said gently.

"For Luc."

Catherine gave a small, tactful tilt of the head. "Not in any formal sense. But people notice things. Affinity. Proximity. Possibility. You know how these situations grow."

"No," Grace said. "What I know is that everyone keeps naming Deborah before naming a fact."

Catherine's expression never lost its kindness. "The fact," she said, "is that Deborah is hurt. And when women are hurt in rooms like this, it tends to travel."

"And what story have you already told about me."

"That you are under strain," Catherine replied. "That your father is gravely ill. That you may not have full sight of how things are reading at the moment. It is kinder that way."

Her mother said quietly, "Nobody is blaming you."

"No," Grace said. "That would require a fact."

Catherine set her untouched cup down. "Do not make yourself the injured party in this. All I am saying is that Deborah is not a woman to humiliate publicly."

Grace looked from Catherine to her mother and back again. "And I am."

The silence that followed was short, but not short enough. Her mother intervened in the tone she preferred when she wished to appear the moderate centre between two extremes. "That is not what Catherine said."

"It is what the room said."

Grace left before either woman could convert the scene into one more proof of strain. In the corridor her phone buzzed.

Six. Arcade. Twenty minutes. Luc.

No greeting, no cushioning phrase. The austerity of it felt cleaner than every velvet sentence she had heard all day. She typed yes and was grateful he did not answer with anything further.

The Peninsula arcade smelt of polished stone, expensive perfume, and the sort of money that had stopped needing to announce itself decades ago. Grace arrived early and immediately resented having done so. Hotels like this were designed to turn waiting into self-consciousness.

Luc came from the lobby without hurry, jacket over one arm, tie gone, expression narrowed by fatigue rather than disorder. He stopped in front of her, took in her face in one quick reading, and said, "Walk."

So they walked. Not quickly, not intimately, not close enough for the corridor to decide anything useful before he chose the terms.

"Why did you ask me here," Grace said.

"Because pressure is moving faster than fact. And because after today you needed to hear it from me first."

"Hear what."

"That she's being used."

"At work," Grace said. "What happened."

"Pressure. Quiet. Denied if named."

"And here."

"Stories."

"What kind."

"The kind that don't need facts."

They had reached the side passage near the florist when Deborah appeared. Pale blue silk. Small earrings. A face arranged into softness so accomplished it might have passed for innocence if Grace had not spent the entire day listening to that softness prepared in advance.

"Grace," she said, touching Grace's arm lightly. "I was hoping I might see you. I've been thinking of you constantly."

Grace removed her arm without haste. "How kind."

Deborah allowed the sentence to fall without resistance. She turned slightly towards Luc, smiling with the rueful composure of a woman prepared to be misunderstood on moral grounds. "Luc."

"Deborah," he said.

"I won't keep you," Deborah said. "I only wanted to say one thing and then I'll disappear."

"No," Luc said.

Deborah smiled more sadly, as though proving his point about himself were part of the burden she had nobly chosen to bear. "You see," she said to Grace, "that is exactly

how he is. Beautiful manners, impossible edges. It's why women forgive him longer than they should."

Luc said, "Stop."

Deborah ignored him with the smoothness of someone who understood the geometry of public scenes. A calm man who objected twice risked looking harsh. A sorrowful woman who spoke softly could say almost anything before anyone would forgive interruption.

"I'm not saying this to wound you," she said to Grace. "Quite the opposite. I only wish someone had said it to me in time. He is the kind of man who never stays. Not because he is wicked. That would almost be simpler. Only because movement is what suits him. Men like that are terribly convincing for exactly as long as they are passing through."

Grace felt the sting not because she believed a word of it, but because she heard at once how perfectly the room would. Catherine could repeat half and omit the rest. Her mother could call it realism. Some auntie could turn passing through into temporary and feel wise rather than malicious.

Luc stepped slightly into Grace's line of sight, not touching her, not claiming anything, merely placing his body where Deborah would have to address him if she meant to go on.

"Leave."

This time the word carried heat. Deborah registered it and knew, Grace thought, that she had done enough.

"I do hope your father improves," she said. Then, to Grace, with one last soft lowering of the voice: "Please don't let him make you feel chosen when he only happens to be present."

Then she turned and walked back towards the brighter corridor, blue silk moving smoothly through the polished light until she disappeared into the lobby traffic.

Grace watched her go and then looked at Luc. He had not moved. His face had gone still in the way it always did when anger had been compressed too carefully to show itself.

"You let her say it," Grace said.

"I stopped her."

"No. You contained her."

"Yes," he said.

The honesty of it made the anger worse. "You could have said it wasn't true."

"To whom."

"To the room."

He looked at her with an expression so bleakly precise that for a moment she felt as though the floor under the arcade had tilted by half a degree. "The room doesn't care if it's true."

"Then say it for me."

"Not here," he said.

"Of course. Not here. Never where anyone can hear it."

"If I claim you in a corridor like this," he said, "it becomes their material."

"It already is."

"Yes."

He was right and still failing her inside the rightness. His restraint was not in the service of vanity. It was in the service of principle, and principle in the wrong room could look very like abandonment.

Her phone buzzed. Catherine: Saw Deborah. Thank you for being gentle. She is more wounded than she lets on.

Grace held the screen out. Luc read it and gave the smallest nod. "Fast."

"Designed," Grace said.

A second message came before she had put the phone away. An auntie she had not heard from in months: Poor Deborah. Temporary men can make fools of sensible girls.

Grace stared at the phrase temporary men and felt the full mechanism reveal itself. Deborah had delivered the sentence less than ten minutes ago and it had already detached from her mouth and entered general use.

Luc said, "Go home with a route in mind."

"You see," she said, "that is exactly what she means."

His gaze held hers. "I know."

"And you still do it."

"Yes."

"What does it make me," she asked quietly, "if Deborah says it, Catherine repeats it, and my mother calls it realism."

He answered without pause. "Inconvenient."

"And you."

He looked away first, towards the bright length of the arcade, the florist, the polished glass, the whole civilised corridor that had just absorbed damage without wrinkling. He did not answer.

"I'm sorry," he said.

"For what."

"For not making the room smaller."

She looked at him. Even where he failed her, he often failed from principle. It made anger impossible to keep pure.

Grace left him a minute later because staying would have forced them into either intimacy or argument and the corridor had already taken enough. He did not touch her. His restraint followed her all the way to the lift.

She took the ferry back instead of a taxi. On the upper deck, with the harbour moving bluntly below, she opened the notebook and wrote the day down in order.

Catherine: Deborah had hopes. When women are hurt in rooms like this, it tends to travel. Deborah: the kind of man who never stays. Deborah: passing through. Luc: The

room doesn't care if it's true. Auntie: Temporary men can make fools of sensible girls.

By the time she reached the house, evening had settled into the lamps and polished surfaces. As she crossed the hall she heard her own name from the study and stopped. Catherine's voice came through the speaker, softened by distance but not enough to lose its shape.

"I'm not blaming Grace," Catherine said. "One has to be realistic. Deborah was simply unlucky enough to say it aloud."

Her mother answered after a moment. "Then perhaps it is useful that she did."

Grace stood in the half-dark corridor and felt the last uncertainty disappear. Useful.

She did not enter the room. She wrote where she stood.

Catherine: unlucky enough to say it aloud. Mother: useful.

By evening, Deborah was no longer required.

The sentence would continue circulating without her, polishing itself as it travelled, shedding fingerprints as it went.

CHAPTER XXIV — STEADY FRIENDS

By mid-morning, Theresa could hear the story moving without Deborah attached to it.

She was at her desk in the foundation office, revising a seating grid she no longer officially ran. Catherine had removed her from the committee "to avoid conflict", but the work still found its way back in pieces: a sponsor list that needed checking, a dietary note nobody had remembered, a donor's wife who had to be moved two places because another wife had decided not to forgive a slight from October. The title had been taken from her. The labour remained.

The office door stood open. Someone in the corridor said, "No, poor Deborah," in the tone women used when they wanted pity to sound tasteful. Then: "She's taking it well. But really, men like that are temporary from the outset."

Temporary. Theresa stopped moving.

"Exactly. They arrive in a city, charm three rooms, and leave the women to make sense of it afterwards." A drawer closed. Then: "And Grace has enough on her plate without adding one of those."

Theresa sat back and stared at the screen until the letters lost their shape. Deborah's sentence had already escaped Deborah. It was no longer a remark from lunch. It had become the sort of thing sensible women said to one

another in corridors and powder rooms, tidying reality rather than writing it.

She opened her thread with Grace and typed before caution had time to improve the sentence into something weaker.

Heard something stupid. Don't answer anyone tonight.

She sent it and tried to return to the seating grid. Two minutes later Catherine appeared in the doorway. Not with force. Catherine never entered a room owning it. She entered as if the room had already decided to be pleased to see her.

"Theresa. Still rescuing us."

Catherine glanced at the grid with the half-focus of a woman for whom the paper itself was never the point. "You're kind to keep your hand in. I know the past few days have been awkward."

Awkward. A word that covered too much and named nothing.

"It's all right," Theresa said.

"You always say that." Catherine rested one hand lightly on the back of the visitor chair. "I've just spoken to Augusta. She may stop by tomorrow. She's worried about everyone. Grace, naturally, but also the collateral strain. People forget that ecosystems get tired too."

Not instruction yet. The silk wrapping around it.

"If Augusta wants something," Theresa said, "she can ask."

Catherine's smile cooled by half a degree, then recovered. "She only wants kindness. Which I know is never difficult for you." A beat. "Especially now."

Now meaning after the committee, after the husband's call, after being reminded that some families could afford principle as style and others had to do arithmetic first.

Catherine left before Theresa had to answer.

—

Her husband was home before she was. When Theresa opened the flat door she felt the small inward shift that came whenever unplanned domestic time had already taken its seat at the table. He was at the dining table with his laptop open and a whisky untouched beside it.

"You're late."

"I left when I finished."

He nodded once. "Catherine called." He did not wait for her response. "She said there's more talk than there needs to be. She said Augusta may see you tomorrow."

Of course she had. Theresa set her bag on the chair and waited.

He watched her. "Why are you doing this."

"I'm doing my job."

"No," he said. "You're making yourself relevant."

The sentence domestic fear had been circling for days without yet quite daring to say.

Theresa looked at him. "I'm already relevant. They made sure of that."

"That is not the same thing." He pushed the untouched whisky a fraction away from himself. "They need this to settle. Deborah is hurt. Grace is—"

"Grace is not unstable," Theresa said.

He gave her a tired look. "You know what I mean."

"No," Theresa said. "I know what people mean when they don't want to say the word they're actually building."

He exhaled through his nose, controlled enough to make the effort visible. "You keep doing this. You turn every room into a moral exam."

"No," Theresa said. "I keep noticing when other people do."

Silence sat between them. The fridge hummed. Somewhere in the building a lift opened and closed.

He lowered his voice, which meant the argument had become serious enough to deserve protection from the neighbours. "We have a life here. Mortgage, dinners, schools later if we want them. We do not have the money these people have. We do not get to be principled as a hobby."

Theresa looked at him and heard, beneath the ugliness, the truth he wanted the truth to excuse. "I know."

"Then act like it."

"What does that mean."

"It means when Augusta comes tomorrow you listen. You do not volunteer. You do not become the hinge between Grace and whatever this man is."

Mr Morel. The name did not need saying. Not in this flat.

"And if she asks what Grace says."

"She won't ask directly."

"That isn't what I asked."

He looked away first. He no longer wanted to persuade her morally. He wanted her to understand the price in terms she could not pretend were abstract. Rent, dinners, invitations, work. He wanted arithmetic to end the conversation where principle had failed.

"I haven't agreed to anything," she said.

"No," he replied. "Not yet."

That last part hung in the room after he went to the kitchen. A cupboard opened. Water ran briefly. The ordinary sounds of a flat continuing in the evening while one of the people inside it sat very still.

—

Augusta arrived the next afternoon with Peninsula biscuits and the kind of smile that made refusal look theatrical before the other person had even opened the door.

"Please don't think I've come to scold you," she said as Theresa let her in.

"No," Theresa replied. "I know why you came."

Augusta laughed softly, pleased by the efficiency of being understood. She sat where she was invited, crossed her ankles, and accepted tea she had no intention of drinking. Theresa stayed in the armchair opposite. The sitting room was suddenly too visible: books aligned on the shelf, an unpaid bill under a paperweight, the faint mark on the low table where a glass had once sweated through a coaster. Rooms always looked more confessional once someone else had entered them carrying concern.

For a minute Augusta spoke about nothing that mattered. The heat. Deborah's poor mother. How hard these weeks had been on everyone. Then, with the smoothness of a blade entering cloth, she said, "I do think Grace is at a threshold."

Theresa said nothing.

"Raymond has already tried, very delicately, to give the room a bit more proportion."

Raymond. Not Dr Chao. Discretion in a first-name suit.

Augusta folded one hand over the other. "People under pressure often mistake intensity for clarity. That is nobody's fault. But it can be unkind to let them answer one crisis with another."

"Grace is not a patient," Theresa said.

"No," Augusta replied. "She is a daughter."

That was the frame. Not a woman making intolerable choices. A daughter under strain. Every intervention renamed love.

Augusta continued in the low practical register she used when she wanted morality to sound like housekeeping. "Kindness, sometimes, is slowing a friend down."

Theresa heard the sentence in full, including everything it had not named. Do not help her call Luc. Do not help her leave. Do not help her act. The omissions were the point.

"And if calm means surrender."

"Those are your words."

"They fit."

"I'm speaking about timing. Her father is gravely ill. Mr Morel is not a husband, not a plan, not a settled future. It would be unkind to help Grace confuse intensity with rescue."

"You speak of her as having no judgement at all."

Augusta sighed in a way that made the sigh itself sound responsible. "I speak on the understanding that judgement changes under pressure. You do too."

The line hit because it was attached to truth. Theresa had watched her own judgement contract under the pressure of mortgage, marriage, position. That did not make Augusta right. It only made her dangerous.

"What happens if I don't," Theresa asked.

Augusta placed her cup on the saucer with a precision that made Theresa notice the china. "I think that would be very hard on you." Not on Grace. On you.

"Last week was unpleasant. I would hate to see your kindness cost you twice."

There it was, clean enough to touch. Not a threat. A calculation dressed as sympathy.

"What do you want me to do when Grace calls."

"Help her through the days in front of her. The hospital. Her father. Meals. Sleep. Nothing that turns this into an event she feels she must answer with another event."

"And Mr Morel."

"Mr Morel will go where Mr Morel is going. Deborah has already been hurt. There is no need to widen the field."

"So I am to help preserve the dignity of the room."

"No," Augusta said. "You are to help preserve Grace's."

It was almost enough to make Theresa laugh.

At the door Augusta kissed her cheek. "Please don't think I came to scold you."

"No," Theresa said. "I know why you came."

The corridor swallowed Augusta with carpet, soft light, and the hush expensive buildings preferred to call peace.

—

Theresa went back into the sitting room and sat where Augusta had been sitting. The Peninsula biscuits waited in

their ribboned box on the table like evidence from a crime no one would ever call by its name.

For one reckless second she considered writing the truth entire to Grace. She sat on my sofa and bought my silence with sympathy. She told me your father's illness and Deborah's hurt now make it kindness to help close the exits around you. The words rose and went nowhere. Grace would want to act. Action would require help. Help would require Theresa. Theresa had just been told, plainly enough, what that would cost.

At six twenty-four Augusta sent one final message.

Such a steady afternoon. Grateful for your care today. Grace is lucky in you. We all are. Rest well. A.

The warmth was perfect. Nothing in it could be used. Nothing in it needed to be — that was Augusta's particular skill. The message said thank you for a service Theresa had not agreed to perform. It assumed discretion had been volunteered. It placed her inside a story she had not chosen.

She took a screenshot anyway and moved it to a hidden album. Then she took a pen from the sideboard drawer and wrote on the back of an unpaid bank envelope:

Augusta arrived. Grace "at a threshold." Keep calm. Avoid agitation. Mr Morel. Discretion. Per Mrs Purvis — implied.

The list was ugly. Blunt. Not prose. That was precisely why it steadied her.

Grace: You free later?

Theresa looked at the message until the screen dimmed and woke again beneath her thumb. She could answer truthfully and set something in motion she had just been warned not to help. She could answer falsely and become one more smooth surface in Grace's path. She could do neither, type nothing, call nothing, stay suspended between the truth she was not allowed to speak and the silence that was being built for her by someone else.

She had not agreed to anything. She had only sat in her own sitting room while an older woman described the price of proximity and called it care.

She put the phone down.

Augusta's untouched tea had gone fully cold.

When the screen went black, Theresa let it stay black.

CHAPTER XXV — CLEAN SIGHTLINES

By eleven, the office had begun speaking to Luc under a rule no one intended to print.

Nothing dramatic. A breakfast meeting shifted from conference room to call without explanation. A client dinner disappeared from his assistant's calendar and reappeared three weeks later under another host. A note from legal asked whether he would mind keeping "certain family-adjacent matters" off open email for a few days until "the situation" was calmer.

The situation.

Luc read the message twice, not because he had misunderstood it, but because it had been built with such care that understanding and challenge had been separated from one another. If he asked what family, what matter, what risk, he would be the one forcing the unsaid into record.

His assistant stepped in with a folder. "Compliance wants ten minutes at noon," she said. "They said it was only to keep ahead of any possible sensitivity."

"Any papers?"

"They said none."

No papers meant no record worth keeping. Or no record they wanted him keeping.

His phone lit.

Grace: Hospital first. Then imprisoned lunch. Free after six.

He typed: Six-thirty. Quiet place.

Her reply came at once. Yes.

At noon Compliance sent not a lawyer but a managing director from regional operations whose chief talent was sounding impersonal while making everything feel pre-adjusted. They met in a conference room with a harbour view and bad coffee.

"There is no allegation," the man said. "No concern with performance. What we are asking for, purely as a prudential measure, is a bit of additional discretion while certain families are under strain."

"What does additional discretion mean."

"A little less visibility. Fewer informal crossings. Keep social and professional lanes clean for a week or two. Avoid anything that could be misread as conflict-adjacent."

"What conflict."

"None, formally."

"Then what, precisely, are we discussing."

"A conduct risk environment," the man said. "Not a conduct event. An environment."

Luc let the sentence sit. "If someone has a concern, they can name it."

"And if no one names one," the man replied pleasantly, "the prudent thing is not to force language onto what may

simply be sensitivity. We're asking you to be commercially intelligent."

At one-thirty Barrett called instead of meeting. "Let's hold the sponsor conversation where it is for a few days."

"Why."

"Timing. We don't need extra complications while everything's so delicate."

"Everything meaning what."

A pause. "You really haven't heard the room."

"Your work is excellent. This is not me losing confidence. It's just that when one or two families with that sort of reach are having a difficult spell, you don't want to look needlessly entangled. Give it a week. Then we see."

Entangled. A word that managed to imply impropriety without specifying any act by which impropriety had been committed.

By three, Central had turned the colour it often turned in late heat: silvered, overlit, faintly unreal. A client cancelled while Luc was already in the Hong Kong Club lobby. Family matter. Rain check soon. Apologies. He stayed anyway for one whisky because leaving at once would have looked like reaction.

Alistair arrived before the drink did.

"Morel," he said. "You look as though someone has explained a tax rule at you."

Luc stood. "Pembroke."

Alistair sat opposite without being asked. "Off the record, purely as weather, this is one of those Hong Kong intervals in which it helps not to look as though you are crossing too many lanes at once."

"What lanes."

"The answer to that rather depends on how naive we're both pretending to be."

Luc held his gaze.

Alistair smiled. "Certain women are feeling tender, certain families are tired, and firms get very moral when the word conduct can be floated without anyone having to prove a thing."

Two women passed behind him on their way to the dining room. Luc heard only a fragment.

"...poor Deborah, really, she's been much more dignified than anyone had a right to expect..."

Then, lower:

"Some men arrive already half gone."

Luc kept his eyes on Alistair.

Alistair lifted both brows. "You see. Decorative."

Catherine entered a minute later with Augusta and two board women Luc recognised by sight. She saw him at once. Under ordinary conditions she would have crossed the room and made a performance of warmth. Today she altered course only enough to acknowledge him from a distance.

"Luc," she said as she passed. Warm voice. Cooler eyes. "Busy week."

"Very."

Augusta added, without pausing, "Take care of yourself. Everyone's thresholds are lower than they think."

Then they moved on.

Alistair watched them go. "Nothing actionable," he said. "Only the faint suggestion that Compliance is suddenly in the mood to admire clean sightlines." He crossed one ankle over the other. "For what it's worth, nobody sensible thinks you've done anything grandly wicked. The difficulty is subtler. You've become inconvenient in more than one grammar at once."

"For whom."

"Ah, now. That is the one question this city never answers plainly, because plain answers create authors. Much easier to have an atmosphere and let everyone pretend they independently noticed it." He tilted his glass. "Let's say they prefer a shape."

Luc put his glass down. "You're enjoying this."

"Not the content," Alistair said. "Only the mechanism."

He stood. "Be boring for forty-eight hours if you can. Boring men survive Hong Kong better than interesting ones."

Back at the office, an email waited from Singapore.

Can we push tomorrow's discussion on role structure by a few days. Slight concern about avoidable visibility just now. Nothing to worry about — purely one of those HK moments.

One of those HK moments. Luc read the line and understood that by tomorrow the problem would not be that anything had been decided. It would be that decision had started to look prudent from enough angles to become self-justifying.

His phone lit.

Grace: Escaped. Hospital then mother then civilisation. See you soon.

He typed: Leave by the side entrance if you can. Less theatre.

He looked at the line, hated its resemblance to advice he would have despised in her mother's mouth, and sent it anyway.

She replied: Understood.

—

At six-thirty he was already seated when Grace arrived.

He had chosen a small hotel bar in Admiralty that business travellers found too discreet and locals found too cleanly lit for scandal. Nothing in the room announced history. That was the point.

Grace came in wearing the day on her without dramatising it. Dark dress, hair pinned badly enough to suggest she had

done it in a car, face composed in the exact register he had learned to read as effort rather than calm. She sat and said, "You picked a place my mother would approve of."

"I picked a place she would underestimate."

For the first few minutes they spoke with the strained correctness of two people attempting normality because the attempt itself might preserve something. Her father unchanged. The consultant careful. Lunch impossible. Marian apparently discovering a fresh register of piety via grilled fish. Luc said the office had been dull. She looked at him over the rim of her glass.

"Dull how."

"The administrative kind."

"That isn't a description."

"It is tonight."

She set the glass down. "You're smoothing."

He said nothing.

"Theresa's gone quiet," she said. "Not fully. Just enough to make silence look like tact. My mother has my day printed in a folder like I'm twelve. Augusta is apparently more concerned than God. Deborah has been promoted to weather. And you are smoothing."

Luc looked at the table. "Work is making noises."

"What kind of noises."

"The vague kind."

"That's not useful."

"No."

She gave a small breath that might have been a laugh if the day had been kinder. "Everyone in my life now believes opacity is mercy."

"I don't want to put this on you tonight."

"My father is not a general-purpose reason other people are allowed to curate my life."

The sentence sat between them with perfect clarity.

Luc said, "There were conversations today. Nothing formal. Nothing nameable without helping the people saying it stay unnamed."

"Because of me."

He looked at her glass rather than her face. "Not named."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only accurate one I have."

"And if you had an inaccurate but honest one."

He almost smiled at that. "Then I would still be careful before giving it to you."

"Why."

"Because I want to know what it is before I hand it to you."

Grace looked away first. "That's exactly what they say."

"I'm not your mother."

"No," Grace said. "You just occasionally borrow her method."

For a moment he had no answer. Then: "Yes."

They ordered food more from instinct than appetite. Small plates. A nurse who had referred to her mother with the authority of someone to whom the ward had been deeded. A board woman who had texted Grace a quotation about strength that sounded like upholstery. They laughed twice. Not much. Enough.

Then his phone lit. Unknown internal extension. He looked at the number, knew before answering that whatever waited at the other end would not improve by being heard in front of her, and stood.

"Sorry."

Grace did not say it's all right.

He took the call in the corridor outside the bar. A woman from regional HR said, "We may want to reframe tomorrow's conversation around role permanence until conflict checks are fully settled."

"What conflict checks."

"Nothing should be inferred from the phrasing. This is routine hygiene in a live market."

"Then why are you calling me at seven-thirteen."

A pause. "Because some of the names in the room are socially sensitive, and we'd rather not create additional exposure if it can be avoided."

Names. Plural.

"What names."

"I'm not going to help by being less discreet than the market. We'll speak tomorrow."

When he returned to the table his face had already arranged itself. Professional calm. The expression he had built over years in rooms where emotion was interpreted as cost. He saw Grace see it.

"That was not nothing," she said.

"No."

"What was it."

He looked at the water ring beneath her glass. "More of the same."

"And the same is."

"Delays. Caution. Role conversations moved."

"Because of me."

"Not named."

Grace looked past him into the room. "I'm becoming a genre," she said.

"Listen to me." She looked back. "This may be nothing larger than a week of people behaving like clerks to their own fear. I am not giving them magnitude before they earn it."

"You already are," she said. "You just won't let me see the full dimensions."

"I need one night to understand the shape of it," he said. "Then I tell you what I know."

Grace looked at him for a long moment. "You hear yourself."

"Yes," he said.

When they left, he walked her to the taxi rank. Outside the hotel the night had thickened into wet heat and reflected light.

At the curb Grace turned to him. "I know you think you're keeping me from unnecessary damage," she said. "But people who keep choosing what I can bear are becoming a problem in themselves."

The taxi pulled up before he could answer. He opened the door. She got in. Neither touched the other.

He stood under the awning until the tail-lights were taken by traffic. Then his phone lit.

APAC Role Discussion — Reframe: Can we shift tomorrow's conversation to early next week. Best to let current sensitivities settle before we discuss permanence.

Luc read the message once and put the phone away.

—

Grace did not go straight upstairs when the taxi reached the house. The front hall was lit to its usual evening register: lamps positioned to imply welcome, flowers replaced before decay could become visible. Her mother was in the sitting room with Augusta. Through the half-open door Grace caught only a slice of voice.

"...too much stimulation," Augusta was saying. Her mother answered too low for the words to carry.

Grace kept walking.

In her bedroom she took out the notebook and opened to a clean page.

Work making noises. Call in corridor. More of the same. Delays. Caution. Role conversations moved. Not named. One night to understand the shape of it.

She looked at the page.

If they never name you, they can move you everywhere.

She did not write that one down.

CHAPTER XXVI — NOT ACTIVE

By half past ten, permanence had become a phrasing problem.

The meeting appeared in Luc's calendar under a title so empty it looked deliberate: Role Structure — Follow-Up. No papers. No note from the sponsor who had once behaved as though the Hong Kong seat were merely a matter of sequence and patience. His assistant paused in the doorway with the composed face competent assistants wore when they knew enough to understand that direct questions would only humiliate both parties.

"They've moved it to ten-forty-five," she said. "Singapore dialling in."

"Who else."

"Regional operations. HR. Possibly Barrett."

Possibly. Not Barrett wants to speak to you. Not HR has a concern. Only geography and function.

When she left, he opened the original message again. Internal Transfer — Hong Kong — Offer in Principle. He did not need to reread the language. Pleased to confirm, subject to, sponsorship, effective Q3. Conditional promise. Enough, at the time, to let hope assume a bureaucratic shape. He had shown it to Grace not as romance but as proof that his wanting a life in Hong Kong pre-dated her.

Not fantasy. Something on a screen. A line you could point at.

His phone lit.

Grace: Hospital. Then lunch theatre. Can you still do tonight.

He typed back: Yes. Later than planned. Work first.

Her reply came at once: Fine. I'll survive Marian and fish.

At ten-forty-five the conference room was already cold. A screen at the end of the table carried Singapore in careful blue light. Barrett appeared from the chest up, tie perfect, expression arranged into professional regret. Beside Luc sat the managing director from regional operations who had used the phrase conduct risk environment the day before. Next to him, a woman from HR with calm hands and a notebook she had not yet opened.

"Luc," Barrett said. "Thank you for making the time." Luc said nothing. Barrett continued. "We've spent the last twenty-four hours looking closely at the Hong Kong role as framed in the offer in principle. There have been some shifts. Nothing personal. Nothing punitive. But enough movement that we need to be precise."

"Be precise, then."

The HR woman looked at the page in front of her. "The role as originally configured is no longer active in current form."

"You mean it's gone."

"Not exactly," Barrett said.

The managing director folded his hands. "We mean the permanence element cannot be progressed as planned."

Permanence element.

"What remains."

A small silence. Then the HR woman said, "We are reviewing whether aspects of the Hong Kong scope can be redistributed across existing heads while broader regional priorities settle."

Redistributed. Settle. Broader. Regional. Priorities.

"Was there a problem with my work."

"No," Barrett said at once.

"Conduct."

"No."

"Client complaint."

"No," the managing director said pleasantly. "Nothing so formed."

"Then what changed."

Barrett drew breath through his nose. "Context."

The HR woman took over. "The Hong Kong market has become more socially sensitive than anticipated in ways that create avoidable visibility around any role requiring long-horizon sponsorship."

"Avoidable visibility for whom."

"For the platform," the managing director said.

"Meaning no one wants to own the decision."

"That isn't fair," Barrett said.

"It's exact."

The HR woman slid a paper across the table.

Following review of regional priorities and current market conditions, we will not be progressing the Hong Kong permanent position in its current configuration. We remain keen to continue conversations regarding future opportunities once conditions stabilise.

Nothing denied absolutely. Nothing granted.

"Do you want me in Hong Kong or not," Luc asked.

Again the delay. Barrett said finally, "I want you where your value is easiest to defend."

The meeting ended there. No one offered a handshake. The HR woman closed her notebook. Barrett said they would speak again soon, which in rooms like this meant once the decision had acquired enough age to look inevitable.

Back in his office he typed three different messages to Grace. It's gone. They've killed the role without wanting fingerprints on it. He deleted both and sent only: Need to see you tonight. Not by message.

She took longer to answer than usual.

All right.

Nothing else. No question mark.

—

At six-thirty she stepped from the lift and found the door already open.

The office smelled faintly of tea and paper. Luc stood when she entered. No jacket. Sleeves rolled once. Laptop open. One mug beside it, not two. The chair opposite the desk waited where it had waited before.

"What happened," she said before hello could turn into another form of delay.

He looked at her for a second, and she saw him deciding how much shape to give the thing before handing it to her. So she said, more quietly, "Don't."

He understood. "All right."

He turned the laptop towards her.

Following review of regional priorities and current market conditions, we will not be progressing the Hong Kong permanent position in its current configuration.

Grace read the sentence twice. "What does that mean."

"It means the seat is gone."

She sat without remembering to do so. The chipped mug remained where it had been. Beyond the back window the laundry still hung on the rails in the narrow gap between buildings. One white shirt shifted once and settled.

"But they sent you—"

"I know."

"Because of me."

His face altered by almost nothing. "I can't prove that."

"That is not what I asked."

"I know." A beat. "I know enough to dislike the weather. I don't know enough to hand you a fact."

"When did they tell you."

"This morning."

"And you went to work all day with this."

"Yes."

"Why didn't you call me."

"Because message was wrong. Phone was wrong. And because I wanted the thing in my hand before I gave it to you."

She almost laughed. "Again."

He did not pretend not to know what she meant. "Yes."

"I'm not angry with you," she said. "I just wish the method would die."

His mouth changed by half a degree. "So do I."

She crossed to the window because sitting by the laptop felt too much like being managed by a screen. The view was still bad. Rear walls. Rails. Concrete stains. A woman in the opposite building pinning a T-shirt to the line with violent practicality.

"Tell me exactly what they said."

So he told her. Singapore on the screen. Barrett. The HR woman. No allegation. No concern with performance. Current market conditions. Long-horizon sponsorship. Not progressing the role in its current configuration. Asking whether it was because of the Purvises and

receiving an answer that answered structure rather than content.

When he had finished, she said, "It sounds like work."

"Ugly work," she said. "Cowardly work. But work."

"Perhaps."

"What else am I meant to call it."

"I don't know."

"Neither do I. So until I do, I'm calling it work."

"Do you think it's finished."

"This version is."

"That sounds like hope designed by legal."

"That's because it is."

"What happens now."

He answered in the grammar he trusted most. "I stay where I am until they tell me differently. I take the calls they still give me. I do not make this easier for them by leaving before they finish arranging it."

"I keep thinking I should cry," she said. "But the whole thing is so administrative. It feels absurd to cry over somebody else's nouns."

"Administrative damage is still damage."

"Yes. But it has the decency to look boring while it's doing it."

"That isn't decency."

"No. I know."

He poured water into the chipped mug and handed it to her. She took it because holding something prevented other gestures. The glaze caught lightly against her thumb where the rim had broken.

When they left the office together the corridor outside was nearly empty. Luc turned off the lights, locked the door, and put the key in his pocket. Grace watched the gesture and felt, absurdly, that it was the most intimate thing he had done all evening.

Outside, Central had entered that polished night phase in which every surface looked more deliberate than it really was. At the kerb she turned to him.

"What will you tell them."

"About work."

"It's true enough."

"Yes."

The taxi arrived. He opened the door. Again they did not touch.

—

The house was still awake when Grace returned. Lamps on. Fresh flowers where old ones had begun to brown. Her mother was in the study with the door half open, on the phone. Grace heard only a fragment as she crossed the hall.

"...markets do shift..."

She did not stop.

In her room she closed the door, took out the notebook, and sat at the desk without turning on the larger lamp.

Offer in principle withdrawn. Permanent position not progressing in current configuration. Future opportunities once conditions stabilise. No date.

She stopped there. Later was not a date.

She closed the notebook and placed it back in the bag.

She still believed, even now, that this was misfortune rather than design.

That belief was not innocence. It was scaffolding.

CHAPTER XXVII — 1 OCTOBER

By nine-fifteen, the date already existed in the building before it existed on paper.

Luc knew because two analysts stopped speaking when he came through the glass door by the lift bank, and one of them said good morning with the strained brightness of a man who had just learned something he had no right to know. The other kept walking with his coffee and did not look up at all.

Nothing in the office had changed visibly. Screens glowed. The harbour beyond the glass looked overlit and indifferent. Yet the air had acquired that corporate density produced when rumour reaches a room before paperwork does.

Nicki was already waiting outside his office with a printout in her hand. "You have HR at ten," she said. "Moved up."

"Yes."

"Who else."

"Regional operations. Compliance dialling in. Possibly Barrett."

Possibly. Not Barrett wants to speak to you. Not Barrett has a concern. Only function and geography.

He took the page from her. The meeting title had changed overnight. Not Role Structure. Not Transfer Review. Client Conflict Update.

"Have we acquired a client conflict."

"Not one I've been allowed to name."

His phone lit. Alistair's number.

"Morel," Alistair said. "Tell me you are not already being processed into one of those rooms where everyone starts sounding compassionate because no one wants fingerprints."

"Good morning to you too."

"Then yes," Alistair said. "Quarter-end. Ninety days, if they want something that sounds reversible. Dates soothe markets."

Then, in a lower voice: "Be boring today if you can. They prefer removal when it arrives looking administrative."

His phone lit again before Alistair had rung off.

Grace: Hospital. Then lunch theatre. Free later.

He typed: Need to see you tonight. May be bad.

Her reply came almost at once: How bad.

He wrote: Not by message.

This time she took longer.

All right.

At ten, the conference room was colder than the weather justified. The managing director from regional operations was already there, and beside him a woman from HR he had not met before, and at the far end a Compliance man who opened a notebook and said nothing. Barrett

appeared two minutes later on the screen, expression arranged into wary reasonableness.

"Luc," Barrett said. "Thank you for making the time." Luc said nothing. Barrett continued. "We've spent the last twenty-four hours looking closely at the Hong Kong role as framed in the offer in principle. There have been some shifts. Nothing personal. Nothing punitive. But enough movement that we need to be precise."

"Be precise, then."

The HR woman looked at the page in front of her. "The role as originally configured is no longer active in current form."

"You mean it's gone."

"Not exactly," Barrett said.

The managing director folded his hands. "We mean the permanence element cannot be progressed as planned."

Permanence element.

"What remains."

A small silence. Then the HR woman said, "We are reviewing whether aspects of the Hong Kong scope can be redistributed across existing heads while broader regional priorities settle."

Redistributed. Settle. Broader. Regional. Priorities.

"Was there a problem with my work."

"No," Barrett said at once.

"Conduct."

"No."

"Client complaint."

"Nothing so formed," the managing director replied pleasantly.

"Then what changed."

Barrett drew breath through his nose. "Context."

The HR woman took over. "The Hong Kong market has become more socially sensitive than anticipated in ways that create avoidable visibility around any role requiring long-horizon sponsorship."

"Avoidable visibility for whom."

"For the platform," the managing director said.

"Meaning no one wants to own the decision."

"That isn't fair," Barrett said.

"It's exact."

The HR woman slid a page across. "Ninety days. Formal reassessment on the first Monday of next quarter. 1 October."

Luc looked down.

INTERIM REDEPLOYMENT — HONG KONG / SINGAPORE. Review Date: 1 October.

A date. Calendar-shaped.

"Who flagged the conflict."

"Client review doesn't work by single authorship."

"That wasn't my question."

"No," Barrett replied. "But it is the answer you are getting."

"Is the Purvis family part of the review environment."

Nobody answered quickly enough.

At last the HR woman said, "Specific families will not be discussed in a formal setting where no adverse finding has been made."

"So yes."

"That is not what she said," Barrett snapped.

"It is exactly what she said."

The managing director leaned back. "We are not here to entertain a private conspiracy theory because a market has become inconvenient."

"No. You are here to move me while preserving the fiction that movement is nobody's decision."

The HR woman pushed a second document across. Temporary Redeployment Framework. Travel beginning tomorrow evening. Compensation remains. Title remains. Accommodation in Singapore will be handled. They had booked the body before they had informed the man inhabiting it.

"For the avoidance of doubt," Luc said, "you are freezing the Hong Kong move, extracting me from the city for ninety days, and giving it a date so it looks reversible."

No one corrected him.

He signed the acknowledgement, not because he believed them, but because refusal would have destroyed the only object in the room that still resembled a date.

Back in his office the memo sat on the desk. Interim. Temporary. Review point. No adverse finding.

He sent Grace one line: The old office. Seven. There is a date.

Her answer came back at once: I'll come.

—

At seven the older office building felt almost private. One lamp on. Chipped mug by the kettle. The back window still offering rails, laundry, and concrete. Nothing in the room had changed.

Grace came in without hesitation and closed the door behind her. "What is the date," she said.

Not hello. He handed her the memo.

She read standing. Not interim redeployment, not temporary reporting, not client environment. Straight to the middle of the page.

Review Date: 1 October.

Her body changed by almost nothing. Not relaxing. Acquiring something to stand on.

"Ninety days."

"Yes."

"Singapore."

"Yes."

"Starting when."

"Tomorrow evening."

Not because Singapore was far. Because tomorrow was.

Grace sat then, the paper still in her hand, and read the rest more slowly. When she finished, she laid it on the desk between them and said very quietly, "This is obscene."

"Yes."

She looked again at the date. "That is not forever."

"No," he said.

"Do you believe it."

"I believe it exists."

"That's not what I asked."

"I know."

She looked towards the back window. "I'm asking badly."

"No. You're asking exactly."

He told her the rest plainly. The changed meeting title. The conflict flag. The refusal to name a family. Optics. Sponsorship. The date offered as if ambiguity had been removed.

Only once did she interrupt.

"When you asked about my family."

"Yes."

"What did they do."

"Nothing dramatic. What people here do when they want a thing moved without touching it directly."

She looked down at her hands. "Then it is them."

"I do not have paper saying so."

"No," she said. "But you have a body in the room."

He sat on the edge of the desk. "I have a body in the room. And a date on a page."

Grace gave one short, humourless laugh. "And I am apparently the sort of woman who can live off dates now."

"Ninety days," he said. "I go to Singapore. I do the work. I stay boring. At quarter-end there is a review whether or not they want one. If they slide the date, I tell you first. If they keep it, I come back for the review in person."

"And in the ninety days."

"Sunday nights," he said. "A number I send you when I have it. Never the house line. Never anything that can be read by accident. If you can travel, somewhere dull and close. If not, the line and the date."

"You make it sound like a rail timetable."

"Good."

"That is not remotely good."

"No," he said. "But it is holdable."

"Say it again."

He knew which part. "1 October."

"Again."

"1 October."

She nodded once.

Grace took out the notebook then. Not theatrically. Simply because paper still held its shape. She opened to a clean page and wrote:

1 October. Singapore. Ninety days. Sundays.

"My mother will call this sensible."

"She may even believe it."

"Oh, she'll believe it," Grace said. "My mother likes dates. Dates make things look consensual."

He poured water into the chipped mug and handed it to her. She took it because holding something prevented other gestures. The glaze caught lightly against her thumb where the rim had broken.

"I want to hate them more cleanly than this," she said.

"I know."

"I want one person to point at."

"I know."

Instead she had a city, a family, a bank, a rumour, a date, a plane.

When they left the office together the corridor was nearly empty. Luc turned off the lights, locked the door, and put the key in his pocket. Grace watched the gesture and said nothing.

—

The next morning Hong Kong Station was full of travellers for whom movement remained the most ordinary thing in the world.

That was the obscenity of transit hubs. They made departure look procedural. Luc arrived early enough to check in before the crowd thickened and turned from the counter to find Grace already there by the glass wall above

the Airport Express platforms. She wore a dark dress and flat shoes, hair pulled back badly enough to suggest haste rather than styling, the notebook bag over one shoulder. She looked less like a woman saying goodbye than a woman forcing the city to witness that she had chosen to be present for the subtraction.

"You made it."

"I said I would."

They stood side by side watching trains arrive and slide out with that calm efficiency only expensive systems seemed able to achieve. The glass reflected them faintly back at themselves: two dark figures close enough to be together, not close enough to admit it.

"My mother thinks I'm at the hospital," Grace said.

"That is a bad idea."

"I know."

A voice reached them from the coffee kiosk before the man did.

"Quarter-end," Alistair said, too bright to be accidental. He paused with a paper cup in one hand and looked from Luc to Grace and back again. "Ninety days. The city will like that. Dates make removal sound temporary."

Then he moved on before either of them answered.

"Even here," Grace said.

"Yes," Luc said.

Final boarding was announced in the neutral voice stations used when inviting people into tubes that removed them from cities.

"Say it again," Grace said.

"1 October."

He held out his hand then. Not an embrace. Not a kiss. A hand, in public, the limit of what the room could use without first admitting it had been watching.

Grace looked at it for half a second and then took it. They stood like that for one beat, then two. Then she let go first.

"Go," she said.

At the barrier he turned back once. She had not moved. One hand was already inside the bag. Then he went through.

The train slid away with the calm smoothness of a thing designed not to look like loss. One second Luc was there, contained by frame and glass, and the next he had become part of the moving line. Then the line bent. Then it was gone.

Grace remained by the platform until the empty track looked less like possibility than proof. Only then did she take out the notebook and add three words beneath the date.

He left today.

She looked at it for a second, then wrote beneath it: 1 October. Nothing else.

By the time she reached the street again, she had begun to think in quarter-ends.

It gave loss a timetable and called that mercy.

CHAPTER XXVIII — SMALLER SPACES

By the second morning after the station, Hong Kong had become smaller.

Not because any street had altered. The city was smaller because there was now one fewer room in it in which Grace could arrive without being interpreted. Luc had taken a plane and the pocket of air had gone with him. What remained was the house, the hospital, the car between them, and the social organs that pretended those three spaces were enough for a woman in her condition.

She woke before the tray arrived and lay still with the notebook beside her pillow. When she opened it, the page from the station stared back in the thin morning light.

1 October. He left today. 1 October.

Three lines. The date appearing twice because twice was how one tested whether a number would hold. She looked at it until the page stopped resembling a promise and resumed resembling paper. Then she closed the notebook and slid it back into the drawer before anyone could come in and find prayer dressed as administration.

The tray arrived a minute later. Tea. Toast. Half a grapefruit already cut. Rita set it down and said, "Your mother's downstairs. Mrs Leung called earlier." Of course she had.

Downstairs, the house was already operating at a level of readiness that made spontaneity feel faintly indecent. Her mother sat at breakfast with two files open and her tea untouched.

"You're up early."

"I woke."

Her mother nodded. "Good. We need to be at the hospital by ten. And Catherine thought it best if I tell you now that she has taken you off tomorrow night's guest list."

Grace stopped at the chair. "My what."

"The Foundation dinner. You were meant to be there. You're not now."

"And this was decided when."

"Late last night."

"By whom."

Her mother lifted one shoulder. "By people with sense. Catherine thought the evening would be too much. Augusta agreed. I agreed. You do not need to spend three hours smiling at donors and pretending your father is not in a hospital bed. The story would get ahead of you."

The story had never required her help.

"I can decide for myself what is too much."

"Yes," her mother said, and the yes performed agreement while refusing it. "But this time you won't have to."

Relief as confiscation.

Her mother turned one of the files slightly in Grace's direction. "I've put together the visitor rota for the next four days. Can you look through the afternoon windows and tell me if there's anyone you absolutely cannot bear."

Grace stared at the chart. Visitors. Names. Times. Her own day entering the room as a sequence of tolerable faces chosen by somebody else.

"What happens if I can bear none of them."

"Then we do what adults do and rank inconvenience."

It was honest, which made it worse.

"I've kept Sunday morning clear," her mother added, "in case Raymond wishes to stop by. Not formally. Only to see how you are."

Grace put her cup down too carefully. "I'm not a patient."

"No," her mother said, with the same old softness that managed to soothe and reduce at once. "You're a daughter whose father is critically ill and whose judgement has been under strain. Nobody is calling you mad, Grace. Try not to reach for the melodramatic version simply because the plain one offends your pride."

At the hospital, the private ward smelt of cold flowers and controlled air. Her father remained in the same guarded quietness as before, machines making his body legible to everyone except the man inside it. Grace stood by the bed and held his hand until the consultant came in.

Monitoring. Caution. No dramatic change. Continue. The language of stabilised uncertainty.

Her mother took notes. Small precise handwriting on the back of a printed agenda, forcing even this into meeting structure and therefore making it survivable.

When the consultant had gone, Augusta arrived with lilies and concern. Pale linen. Low voice. The face of a woman whose compassion had been trained to survive expensive environments.

"My dear girl," she said. "You look better than I feared."

"That's fortunate."

"Raymond says everyone is feeling the strain," Augusta said softly.

Grace felt the same small internal hardening she now felt whenever Dr Chao arrived stripped of title and repurposed as atmosphere. Raymond meant concern in a first-name suit.

"I'm sure the room is exhausted," she said.

Augusta turned towards her with patient sorrow. "Don't punish people for loving badly."

"I don't think that is what I am doing."

"No," Augusta replied. "Not intentionally."

Her mother intervened before the room could sharpen. "Augusta is only worried you are trying to carry too much."

"There is less to carry than there was yesterday," Grace said.

It was the first direct acknowledgement of Luc's absence any of them had made in that room.

"Absence," Augusta said after a moment, "does not always lessen load. Sometimes it only removes distraction."

Grace straightened. "That is an extraordinary thing to say at a hospital bed."

"It is an ordinary thing," Augusta replied, "to notice when a life has become too agitated and hope quiet will help. You must let people reduce the unnecessary things. There is no heroism in overstimulation."

"I was not aware I had become an environment."

"You have become a daughter under strain," Augusta said. "That is enough."

Later, in the hospital café, Theresa found her by the vending machine and said, "I have six minutes."

Grace almost laughed from sheer gratitude at the honesty of the greeting. "Six is lavish."

Theresa bought two bad coffees and stood with her by the window. She looked thinner than she had a week earlier, not in the aesthetic way but in the administrative way of someone whose life had been tightened one instruction at a time.

"You look terrible," Theresa said.

"So do you."

"Yes. That's what happens when women keep being told to make this easier."

"For whom."

"For whoever can still pretend there's an answer."

"They took me off Catherine's dinner."

Theresa did not look surprised. "Of course they did."

"My mother says it's kindness."

Theresa watched the service road below. "Kindness," she said at last, "is an extremely successful tone."

"Can you still—"

Grace stopped.

Theresa finished the sentence for her without generosity, only accuracy. "Be here. Yes. But not in the old way."

Not in the old way. The nearest anyone besides Luc had come to stating plainly that even friendship now had to account for the room.

"They think if everyone keeps the days sufficiently occupied you won't have enough oxygen left for anything difficult," Theresa said.

"They may be right."

Theresa turned towards her. "Don't say that."

"I'm not surrendering. I'm noticing the arithmetic."

"Yes. Well. The arithmetic is vulgar."

Her phone lit. Theresa looked at it and did not pick it up.

"I keep repeating the date in my head," Grace said quietly.

"Then repeat it. Better a date than their language."

The line hit because it was the first that did not try to take the date away and did not insult her by pretending the date was sanctuary.

"No one should have made you easier by making you smaller."

Then Theresa's face closed again, not out of insincerity but necessity. She touched Grace's wrist once and walked away before the room could tax the gesture further.

The days that followed were not eventful enough to justify their weight. That was the point. The city tightened by subtraction, not spectacle. Catherine's kindness arrived in calls and notes and little administrative salvations that each removed one more reason for Grace to appear in public. A donor lunch she would once have attended was handled for her. A Foundation preview became something she was mercifully spared. Nobody said hidden. They said spared, protected, rested, and quiet.

By Friday afternoon, even the gaps in her calendar had begun to feel curated by Catherine's handwriting whether or not Catherine had touched them herself. The desk in the morning room became her station. Not by decree. By habit. Cards, family stationery, the hospital update sheet her mother kept revising by hand. At five her mother handed her a list of people to be called if the consultant changed the sedation plan.

Lieutenant again, without the word. She did the work because refusal would not have freed the time. It would only have converted the time into conflict, and conflict in that house was always fed back into the story of her strain.

On Saturday evening Augusta came to the house with broth and prayers.

"You look more settled," she said.

"That would depend on the observer."

Augusta smiled faintly. "I mean your nervous system seems less overrun."

"My nervous system."

"Yes. Sleep, appetite, stimulus tolerance — they all show in the face if one looks kindly enough."

Grace laughed once. Enough.

"You hear accusation where I intend care."

"No," Grace said. "I hear medicine where no one has offered a chart."

From the doorway her mother said, "That's enough." Not because Augusta had gone too far. Because Grace had made the method audible.

Augusta lowered her gaze. "I only mean that quiet has done you good."

Quiet. Meaning removal, supervision, duty, the absence of Luc, the tightening of all exits. Quiet had apparently improved her complexion.

Grace stood. "Then perhaps I should be grateful for exile too."

Her mother's expression shifted into the thinner sharper register that signalled social manageability was at risk. Augusta lifted one hand. "No. She is entitled."

Entitled. Generous on its face, faintly discrediting underneath. Grace saw the sentence land in the room and knew it would later be remembered as evidence of how wonderfully patient Augusta had been. She left before either woman could reposition her further.

—

Sunday took most of itself before the line began. At ten-twenty Grace took her toothbrush into the bathroom and locked the door.

The number Luc had sent an hour earlier was written in the notebook, not stored in the phone. A hotel line. Room extension. Singapore in digits. She dialled once, hung up before it connected, then dialled again because the first attempt had felt too much like belief.

He answered on the second ring. "Hello." Not Grace. Not anything that assumed the line was clean enough for names.

"It's me."

"I know."

The bathroom light hummed above her. Somewhere outside the door a floorboard shifted.

"How is it."

"Boring."

She closed her eyes. "Good."

"It's a bad hotel and a worse city to arrive tired in. Which is perhaps useful."

"Useful to whom."

"To me, if boredom prevents stupidity."

The line steadied her more than any tenderness might have because it remained inside the agreed grammar.

"How tight is it," he asked.

She looked at the lock on the bathroom door. "Polite."

He understood. "That bad."

She nearly laughed. "You sound like Theresa."

A pause. Then: "I'm sorry."

"For what."

"For becoming a date."

The line entered her so directly she had to grip the notebook harder. "You were already a room," she said. "The date is just what's left visible."

The silence at the other end told her he had heard the sentence whole.

They spoke for twelve minutes. No long declarations. Singapore fine. Room fine. Already a temporary problem in a permanent office, intending to remain as boring as promised. Nothing else had moved. He would tell her first if the date shifted. Yes, Sundays.

When the line ended she remained where she was for another minute, phone dark in one hand, notebook open in the other, listening to the plumbing hum and the house continue around the call unchanged.

Sunday line. Ten-twenty.

Singapore connected.

1 October unchanged.

She closed the notebook. Still temporary enough to count.

—

On Monday morning Catherine's card arrived with flowers. Not extravagant flowers. White lisianthus, pale green stems, the sort of arrangement women like Catherine sent when they wished to look restrained and therefore sincere.

Thinking of you. So glad you are being wise.

Wise.

Grace stood in the hall with the card in her hand and looked at the handwriting until it ceased to resemble Catherine's and became, instead, the city's generic script for female compliance.

Wise meant removed.

CHAPTER XXIX — SAME ROUTE

By Thursday evening, nothing new had happened and that was precisely the trouble.

The house had refined itself around her removal from public life so efficiently that, by dusk, Grace could almost have mistaken the week for care if she had not been living inside it. Breakfast arrived before she asked. The hospital car waited before she was ready. Her father remained in the same guarded quietness, his body translated into pressure, numbers, caution, and the consultant's clean refusal of promises. Augusta had not appeared that day, which only meant her language had already been distributed by other mouths. Catherine had handled two things for her and then sent a note about not wanting Grace "overextended". A donor's wife she barely knew had thanked her for being wise enough to step back. Nothing explicit. Nothing theatrical. The machine no longer needed spectacle.

After lunch her mother gave her three envelopes, a list of hospital flowers to acknowledge, and the household directory open to the pages where the consultant's office, the church women, and the Foundation were all neatly flagged. Grace wrote the notes because not writing them would only have converted the hour into a quarrel and the quarrel into evidence. Thank you for your thoughtfulness.

Thank you for your concern. Thank you for keeping us in your prayers. Each card felt less like gratitude than proof of consciousness.

By half past six the light outside the morning-room windows had gone the colour Hong Kong sometimes took before full evening: silver bruised at the edges, the city overhandled. Grace set down the last envelope and rubbed the side of her hand where the pen had pressed too long against the bone. Her father's pen. Always now.

Her mother came in carrying a revised hospital sheet and paused when she saw the completed stack of notes. "Good," she said. "That's done."

Done. The point of the hour had apparently been completion rather than occupation.

Grace said, "I'm going out for a little while."

"Where."

"For air."

Her mother looked at her face rather than the notes. "Don't be long. And don't do anything that leaves you more tired than you already are."

The permission landed more heavily than refusal would have. The exits had not closed. They had been entered into the rota.

"I'll take a taxi."

"Take the house car."

"No."

Her mother did not insist. "Very well. Be back before ten."

"Why ten."

"Because you need to sleep."

Upstairs, Grace took the notebook from the drawer, looked once at the page with the date, then put the notebook into her bag without writing. Beneath it went the pen. She simply no longer left the house without objects capable of proving sequence if the room around her later tried to soften it.

Outside, the air hit her skin with damp Hong Kong heaviness, which always felt slightly more honest than anything waiting indoors. She walked down the hill rather than wait for a taxi immediately. The act was small enough to remain hers. By the time she reached the main road, the city had properly entered evening. Buses groaned at the kerb. A woman in gym clothes argued into her phone at the crossing outside a chemist. The ordinary looked complete. A red taxi slowed. Grace got in and gave an address near the tram line without thinking too much about it. The driver nodded, turned the meter on, and pulled away with the fatalism of a man who had long ago decided that all destinations were simply variations of traffic.

She did not decide to take the tram in any dramatic sense. The decision had been waiting beneath the day, beneath the notes, beneath her mother's time limit. By the moment the taxi turned past a familiar stop and she saw the rails

embedded in the road, the choice had already happened somewhere below language. She wanted the front seat. She wanted the old wood and the forward view. She wanted the tiny, foolish ritual that had once made the city large enough to move through without explaining herself to it.

She paid, stepped out, and for a moment stood still on the pavement listening to the road.

Then the bell sounded.

It came through traffic with the same old stubborn politeness, and Grace waited — quite literally waited — for the small unclenching she remembered from before. Once the sound had reached some place the hospital and the house had not touched. On another night it had become ignition, a private bell sounding through public air. Tonight it moved through her and found no such untouched place. Her shoulders did not drop. Her chest did not loosen. The bell remained a sound in the street, not a key in the body.

The tram approached with the same stubborn slowness it had always possessed, old and boxy beside the polished glass around it, lit from within like a thing that believed in its own continuity. Grace tapped her Octopus card and climbed the narrow stairs to the upper deck.

The front seat was occupied.

A schoolgirl in trainers and an oversized cardigan sat where Grace had always sat, one foot tucked under her,

headphones on, staring through the front window with the absolute selfishness of youth. Beside her, on the other front seat, a domestic helper about Grace's age held a shopping bag between her knees and spoke softly into her phone, smiling at something Grace could not hear. The sight of them there struck her with irrational force. Not because either woman had done anything wrong. Because they had both arrived in a place she had already, privately and foolishly, started thinking of as a thing that remembered her.

It remembered nobody.

Grace took the seat directly behind them and looked out through the front glass over the schoolgirl's shoulder. The angle was slightly wrong. The city visible, but not hers. When the schoolgirl got off at the next stop, Grace moved into the front seat almost angrily, as though proving something to herself.

Here, she thought. This is the place. This is the angle. The same city sliding under the same glass. Take it, then.

Nothing.

The form was intact.

The contents were gone.

She turned, almost involuntarily, and looked at the seat behind her. Once, that seat had held memory before it held absence. Her father had once climbed up and sat behind her without speaking for several stops, letting the tram do

the work. Your mother loves you, he had said. She just loves you like a system. The sentence had once made her laugh. Now it felt like one of the few pieces of language in her life that had not been designed to route her into service. He had been the only person who could arrive at a stop and not make the room smaller.

The seat behind her remained empty.

A second memory rose then, not invited and not resistible. Luc standing close enough for restraint to become its own form of pressure. The warmth of him beside her in the front of the tram. The wet road sliding forward beneath the glass. The kiss — sudden, precise, not decorative, and therefore more dangerous than anything decorative would have been. She had not understood then how much of the tram's second register had come from his presence beside her — how much ignition had attached itself to rails and bell and varnished wood because the mind preferred to believe the vehicle itself was enchanted when in fact it had only been occupied by the right person.

The seat beside her remained empty too.

That was when the ache became physical. A pressure in the sternum, raw and exact, the body still insisting on treating memory as present tense. She put one hand flat against the bag in her lap. The pen lay under her palm. The notebook too. Fact and sequence resting against the remembered violence of wanting.

At the next stop two tourists climbed upstairs and sat halfway back. One of them pointed his phone through the front window and began filming the road. Grace watched the screen for a second and had the strange clean thought that this was what the tram now meant to outsiders: heritage, novelty, the pleasing oldness of a city clever enough to monetise its own persistence. A moving vehicle through the same city that still returned her each night to the same house, the same hospital bed, the same date.

What had comforted her before was not the tram but the belief that she could still choose to leave. The tram had once represented a city larger than the house. Larger than her mother's systems. Larger than the hospital, the women with cards, the men with polite nouns, the whole polished apparatus of being kept in place. At seventeen, she could storm out and still feel the city hold open some unnamed elsewhere. On another night she could sit at the front with Luc and imagine that motion through Hong Kong might still be convertible into adult life. None of that comfort had lived in the tram itself. It had lived in the belief that the route could lead beyond the machine if she chose the right stop, or the right person, at the right moment.

Now she knew better. She could ride the same line, hear the same bell, sit in the same front seat, watch the same road slide beneath the same window, and remain fully inside it. The city had not enlarged around her. It had

contracted. The tram did not disprove that contraction. It measured it.

There was no reason to stay on. That was the new fact. She rose at the next stop without consulting sensation. The decision was almost administrative: this stop will do because no stop will. She moved downstairs, tapped off, and stepped out into air that smelt faintly of metal, rain residue, and frying oil from a shop further down the street.

The tram remained at the stop for a moment, doors open, lights steady. Grace stood on the pavement and waited for something — regret, relief, a faint rearrangement.

Nothing came.

The doors closed. The tram pulled away, its bell sounding once into the traffic and thinning. Grace watched the lit upper deck move down the road and understood that nothing had been repaired. Not the city. Not the date. Not the ache. Not the belief that motion might still be convertible into choice. The tram had not failed because it had become hostile. It had failed because it remained perfectly itself while the terms under which she had once loved it had been revoked.

A taxi slowed at the kerb. Grace got in and gave the address of the house before pride could invent a more complicated route.

Her mother's voice came from the study, low and measured, on the phone again. Grace heard only a fragment as she crossed the hall.

"...better not to overtax her..."

She did not stop. She went upstairs, closed her bedroom door without haste, and sat at the desk with the notebook already open under her hand before she remembered opening it.

For a minute she looked at the page without writing. Then, because facts were still the only equipment left to her that did not immediately become someone else's theory, she wrote.

Tram. Front seat. Bell. Nothing.

The tram did not work.

She looked at the lines a moment longer, then closed the notebook.

From the window the city still looked large. Towers. Road lights. The dark cut of the Peak above the flatter blaze below. Somewhere in that spread the tram continued along its rails, patient and persistent, still sounding its little bell into intersections, still asking traffic to pause, still carrying bodies who believed movement and choice naturally belonged to one another.

The tram had once made leaving feel imaginable. Tonight it had only carried her through a city that had already decided she would return.

CHAPTER XXX — FAMILY CONTINUITY

By the beginning of the following week, visibility had become the new kindness.

Nothing visible announced it. Tea still arrived before she asked. The curtains still opened to the same measured width. Her mother still sat with the paper and the phone and the expression of a woman engaged in tasks too ordinary to be named as strategy. Yet the air in the dining room carried that faintly ceremonial feeling which always meant other people had already agreed what her hours would signify before she entered them.

A cream card lay beside her plate in Catherine's hand. Darling Grace. Nothing public and nothing heavy. Only a small museum-wing preview this afternoon with two donors who are already practically family. It would be useful — and, I think, protective — if you were seen for half an hour. No speeches. No strain. We'll do all the carrying. Love, C.

Grace read it twice. Her mother said, "I told Catherine you might resist the phrasing. Try not to be childish enough to resist the substance as well."

"What museum-wing preview."

"The donor look-through for the archive extension. It was due next week. Catherine has reduced it to one room and a handful of people."

"No one asked me."

"Because asking would have turned the answer into theatre." Her mother folded the card once. "It is your father's foundation. Your face matters in the room whether or not your preference wishes it did."

Grace looked at her and felt the old nausea of hearing truth used as justification for theft. "You mean the room wants reassurance."

"I mean the room wants continuity."

A beat. Then: "You do not need a ballroom. You do need placement."

Placement. Not rest. Not support. Placement. It was the nearest her mother had come in days to plainness.

At the hospital the corridor was colder than the morning justified. Augusta was already at the nurses' station, speaking to the ward sister in the same low tone she used whenever she wanted medicine to sound like prayer. The moment she saw Grace and her mother, the practicality softened into concern. "How did you sleep."

"Apparently not in a way that preserved me from view."

The consultant arrived and they moved inside the room. Her father lay exactly as he had lain the day before. Tape. Blanket. Warm wrist. The monitor giving off its soft obedient sounds. Grace sat and took his hand because that still reached him directly. Numbers steady. No material deterioration. Continue as before.

Grace asked, "Can I come back later."

The consultant said yes too quickly. "Provided it isn't too late."

Provided. Always. Her mother said, "We will not be long this afternoon."

Grace turned. "So everyone knows."

Augusta answered before her mother did. "Everyone who needs to. A little visible steadiness is kinder than letting people invent distress for themselves."

Grace kissed her father's temple before leaving, with Augusta in the room and the nurse at the door, because for one second she wanted an action no one else could quite turn into administration before it had happened.

The boardroom above the museum office had been arranged to feel small and therefore harmless. Only eleven chairs. One side table laid with tea, biscuits, and the kind of pale flowers Catherine preferred when she wished a room to look tasteful enough to disarm suspicion. But the model of the new wing occupied the centre like an altar: white, lit from below, the little implied future of it so precise that even the scale figures looked as though they had already agreed to admire what had not yet been built.

On one wall hung photographs from the foundation's earlier life. Raymond at a groundbreaking. Raymond with schoolchildren. Raymond beside a donor wall, hand half-raised as if continuity were merely another thing people

like him signed into existence. One photograph of Grace at perhaps twelve, hair clipped back, standing beside him and looking not loved exactly but included. The sight of it tightened her throat in a way none of the hospital machinery had managed that morning.

Catherine came towards her at once. "You came. Good. You look exactly right."

"That sounds less like welcome than wardrobe approval."

"Today is not the day to arrive looking hunted." Then, lower: "I have kept it properly small. Two donors, Alistair, the architect, your mother, Augusta, one board couple, and no one stupid."

"No one stupid. Only dangerous."

Alistair drifted over from the window with exactly the amount of brightness required to make the room feel free of consequence. "There she is. Everyone has been so frightfully protective that I half expected them to unveil you from behind a screen."

Grace looked at him until the grin thinned by half a degree. "Have you been helpful today."

"Only to the extent of repeating that you are tired, not to be pressed, and in need of support rather than performance."

"There it is," Grace said. "Out in the air where one can almost mistake it for kindness."

Alistair's expression altered slightly. "It is kindness," he said softly. "It is also management."

Augusta arrived a moment later with the particular solemnity she wore when grief had to be made medically legible without becoming ugly. "My dear girl," she said. "You look remarkably composed."

"Then I have understood the assignment."

Augusta took that without blinking. "People are only trying to spare you unnecessary strain."

"No," Grace said. "They are trying to spare themselves interpretation."

Her mother appeared then, and the room corrected its posture around her. Black dress. No jewellery that shouted. The face of a woman who had slept very little and intended to let no one use the fact. "That is enough," she said, not because Augusta had gone too far but because Grace had made the method audible.

The architect began explaining the wing. Grace stood beside the model because there was nowhere else to stand without making absence visible inside the room's little fiction of ease. Catherine arranged herself just behind her shoulder. Augusta slightly to one side. Her mother at the head of the table.

Halfway through the presentation, one of the donors — a widow with lacquered hair and the gift of sounding

confidential even in groups — said, "It must be a comfort to Raymond to know the family line is so visibly engaged."

Nobody corrected her. Her mother said, "We are all only doing what is necessary."

Grace looked down at the printed agenda beside the model.

Welcome. Project overview. Capital update. Family continuity. Next steps.

Family continuity. Not handwritten. Not improvised. Printed. Which meant it had existed before she did.

Her mother caught her looking. "I have also taken the liberty of formalising one small thing while Raymond is no longer able to sit through these sessions himself."

Catherine lowered her eyes in the register of a woman pretending not to have arranged what she absolutely had. "Grace will join the Museum Wing Legacy Steering Committee in a family capacity. Not because I intend to burden her, but because at moments like this one protects both the project and the person by keeping lineage visible and gossip irrelevant."

The widow smiled at Grace with the soft relief of someone who had just seen a difficult story resolved into a respectable one. "How marvellous. And so sensible."

Catherine turned to Grace. "You needn't do anything onerous. You'll simply be copied, kept close, and brought in only where it protects rather than drains."

Copied. Kept close. Brought in. Every phrase light. Every phrase a lock.

Alistair, from the window, said, "In fairness, everyone sleeps better the moment there is a shape. Hong Kong adores a shape." The room laughed lightly.

Grace heard herself say, "All right."

Catherine's relief was too quick to hide entirely. "Good."

A photographer entered then. Not a newspaper photographer. Only a young communications woman from the foundation office with a camera hanging low and the careful expression of someone wishing not to disturb a room that had already decided its own gravity. "Just a few for internal circulation."

Grace looked at Catherine.

"Only for the donors who couldn't be here and the archive note. Nothing public."

The communications woman said, "Could I have one of Mrs Purvis and Grace together first."

Her mother came beside her, one hand very lightly at the small of Grace's back in the exact manner that would read as support in a photograph and proprietorship everywhere else. Grace looked at the lens and heard, impossibly loudly in the controlled room, the tiny mechanical click.

Not a shutter. A lock.

The architect was brought in for one shot. Then Catherine. Then a wider frame with Augusta and the board couple. By

the third click Grace no longer had the sense of being photographed. She had the sense of being installed. When it ended, the room returned at once to tea and biscuits and the architect's final note about donor naming windows. Grace left before tea had fully settled in the cups. Nobody stopped her. Once the image existed, her body in the room became less necessary.

In the car home, her mother spoke of the afternoon as no more than a slight unpleasantness endured in service of something larger. "You handled that very well."

"You mean I stood still."

"I mean you understood what mattered."

"No," Grace said. "I understood what refusing would cost in that room."

Her mother let the sentence sit. Then: "Those are often the same thing."

Grace looked out at the city and said nothing else all the way up the hill.

At six-forty-two, Marian sent the first message. So good to see you this afternoon. Everyone felt calmer at once. At six-forty-nine, Mrs Wren. You were very strong. Exactly the right note. At seven-oh-three, the widow. Your father would have been comforted to know things are in such safe hands. Grace read the three messages and put the phone down without answering.

At seven-twenty-one the image arrived from Alistair. Ghastly little picture, but the city will adore it. Better you see it early.

Attached was a screenshot from the foundation's donor circular. The photograph had been cropped more tightly than Grace expected. Her mother's hand at her back. The model bright under the glass. Catherine just behind her shoulder in soft focus, smiling with relief sufficiently mannered. Grace's own face turned slightly towards the camera, not smiling, not unhappy, only composed enough to be usable.

Underneath, the caption:

The Purvis Foundation is pleased to confirm that Grace Purvis has joined the Museum Wing Legacy Steering Committee, working alongside Mrs Purvis to support continuity of the family's cultural stewardship during Raymond Purvis’s recovery.

Pleased to confirm. Joined. Working alongside. Continuity. Cultural stewardship. Recovery. The sentence had been built carefully enough to remain deniable as kindness. The photograph removed the need for denial. Her face was there. Her mother's hand was there. The room would not read it as burden. It would read it as installation.

Catherine messaged a minute later. I know you dislike the picture, but the circular needed a family image. Better this than speculation. Try to see the protection in it. Love.

Then Augusta: The image is calming. People will stop inventing drama now that they can see stability.

A third message arrived.

Theresa. I saw it.

Nothing else. No comfort. No warning. Simply witness.

Grace opened the notebook and wrote.

Legacy Steering Committee.

Family continuity.

Photographs.

My face. Their caption.

The transformation had not happened all at once. No one had dragged her into a room and renamed her while she screamed. They had only adjusted sequence, access, duty, visitors, useful absences, useful appearances. They had called the adjustments care until the care acquired a photograph. Now the photograph would do the rest of the work for them.

At eight, her mother knocked once and came in. "I imagined you would have seen it by now."

"Yes."

Her mother looked down at the circular on the screen. "It is a decent caption."

"A decent caption."

"It could have been much cruder."

"Is that what I should be grateful for."

Her mother held her gaze. "I should be grateful if you understood the difference between a room managed early and a room left to invent its own appetite."

"You have turned me into an argument," Grace said.

"No," her mother replied. "I have prevented you from becoming one."

When she left, the room remained very quiet. Grace looked again at the photograph until it stopped resembling evidence of an afternoon and became what it now was: a sentence the city could carry without effort.

By the time she closed the phone, interim had already learned how to look permanent.

CHAPTER XXXI — PER MRS PURVIS'S REQUEST

By Tuesday, Grace had begun numbering Sundays.

It was not dramatic. After breakfast she opened the notebook, turned to a clean page, and wrote the weeks out in a column until 1 October stopped behaving like abstraction and acquired intermediate furniture: this Sunday, then the next, then the next. Twelve in all if counted generously. Eleven if counted with the meanness the city preferred. She circled them because a circled day was easier to lean on than a month. The page steadied her for almost half an hour. Not because it offered hope. Because it offered sequence.

Downstairs, her mother was already at the table with the paper folded back from the markets section and a brass-clipped binder beside her cup. "Catherine sent the draft minutes," she said.

Grace sat. "Which minutes."

"The museum wing committee. Yours, apparently." Her mother turned the binder so the cover sheet faced her. "Nothing onerous. You are copied on the capital timeline, donor list, naming sensitivities, and the revised archive brief."

Grace looked down.

Museum Wing Legacy Steering Committee — Internal Minutes (Draft)

Present: Mrs Purvis. Catherine L. Augusta W. Alistair C. Board Rep. Architect. Grace Purvis (Family Continuity). Family Continuity. Not daughter. Not observer. Not under duress. A function title.

"You all move very fast," Grace said.

"One has to," her mother replied. "A room can go coarse in under a day if nobody gives it shape."

"There seems to be a great deal of shape lately."

"There seems to be a great deal of need for it."

Grace closed the binder. "You've listed me as continuity."

"The room already understands that. Better to phrase it cleanly than let worse language form around it."

"And by better you mean more useful."

"By better I mean less vulgar." Her mother spread marmalade with exact pressure. "You are in danger of becoming tiresome on this point."

"I'm in danger of noticing it."

Her mother did not answer at once. She waited until Grace had poured the tea and then said, "There is also a call at twelve-fifteen with the architect, only ten minutes, because the donor widow insists on seeing a revised plaque placement. Catherine said your silence in the room last week had an excellent effect. I would prefer not to waste it."

"My silence had an effect."

"Yes," her mother said. "It calmed people."

The hospital gave her the same corridor, the same cold flowers, the same private hush. Her father gave her the same warm wrist and no answer. The consultant gave her the same polished uncertainty in slightly altered language.

"These are maintenance days," he said.

Maintenance days. The phrase was almost funny. Her father now a building held in the weather by contractors.

Grace asked only one question. "Can I come back after the architect's call."

"Yes," the consultant said. "Provided it isn't too late."

Provided, always.

Outside the ward, Augusta was waiting by the lift. She touched Grace's sleeve lightly. "You look drawn."

"You all say that now, treating the face like a committee memo."

Augusta smiled sadly. "Pressure writes itself onto the body whether one admits the pressure or not."

"There's medicine again."

"There's observation."

"Observation dressed as diagnosis."

Augusta let that pass. "You needn't stay on the architect call if it costs too much. Catherine can always report back."

"I'll manage ten minutes," Grace said.

By the time Grace returned to the house, the call pack had been placed in the morning room with two pencils, the binder, and a note from Catherine.

Only the plaque positioning and donor sequence. Ten minutes if everyone behaves. Love.

If everyone behaves.

Grace stood in the doorway looking at the little arrangement — papers squared, pencils parallel, tea already ordered for half past twelve, no gap in the hour left large enough to admit thought.

At twelve-fifteen the architect's call began with Catherine on speaker and the donor widow patched in from a car. The architect spoke about sightlines. The widow said she did not want the plaque to feel commemorative in the funereal sense. Everyone agreed that legacy had to remain forward-looking.

Then Catherine said, with exactly the right amount of brightness, "Grace is with me, by the way. We thought it best she hear the little placement issue first-hand, since she'll be sitting with us on continuity matters going forward."

The widow, delighted, said, "My dear, how excellent. Your face in the circular did more good than anyone had hoped."

The room became very still around the phone. Catherine laughed softly. "That was the idea."

The architect asked whether the plaque should read The Raymond Purvis Archive Wing or The Purvis Family Archive Wing. Grace felt the sentence go through her like cold metal. Her father still in a bed, and the room already

asking whether family ought to outrank the man while he remained too sedated to object.

"What does Grace think," the widow asked.

Catherine said at once, "Only if she wishes. I don't want to make her carry anything today."

Muteness itself had already been assigned value.

Grace looked at the speakerphone. "Use his full name."

A small silence. Then the widow, relieved to have received something plain enough to call dignity, said, "Yes. Quite. Of course. Sensible."

The call ended seven minutes later. Her mother folded the paper. "You see. Nothing onerous."

At one-ten Theresa sent the message anyway.

Can you come to Pacific Place, lower coffee bar, four-fifteen. Alone.

No why. No softening. Grace looked at the line and felt something in her body go cold before thought had caught up. Theresa did not call meetings for effect.

Grace replied at once: Yes.

—

By noon, Theresa understood that silence had matured into collaboration.

She had known for days that silence was no longer neutral. She had known it the afternoon Augusta sat on her sofa with concern dressed as ethics. She had known it when the message arrived at six twenty-four thanking her for

discretion regarding Mr Morel — per Mrs Purvis's request — as volunteer work performed for the public good. She had known it every time Grace's name appeared on her screen afterwards and she let the phone go dark because truth, if spoken then, would have required action and action would have cost more than she yet knew how to pay. But knowing is not the same thing as watching your own caution finish another woman's enclosure.

Her phone buzzed. Her husband.

Please tell me you are not going to make yourself relevant to this.

No greeting. No softening. Just domestic fear stripped to its operative sentence. Catherine had been speaking again. Theresa locked the phone without replying and opened the hidden album instead. Augusta's message sat there among passport renewals and electricity bills, looking almost comic in that company.

Thank you, dear Theresa, for your discretion regarding Mr Morel — per Mrs Purvis's request. It was kind not to agitate Grace further today. We are all so grateful for steady friends at moments like this.

No threat. No fury. Only a line of social housekeeping sent by a woman so certain of the room's moral grammar that she had forgotten other people might one day compare notes.

At eleven-twenty-three she replied to her husband.

I already am.

He sent nothing back.

At eleven-thirty-one Catherine appeared in the doorway with the expression of a woman suggesting she had come only for paper.

"You saw the circular."

"Yes."

"We kept it as restrained as possible." She went on in the soft practical register she reserved for other women's confinement. "It should settle things. People are much calmer once they can see shape."

Then: "I know you worried that Grace might be made smaller by all this. The opposite is true. We're making sure she remains held."

Held. Not pinned. Not installed. Not used. Held.

Then the final laundering: "Please don't let imagination make this harsher than it is."

When Catherine left, Theresa remained still for a full minute. Then she took the phone, opened the encrypted note where Augusta's screenshot lived, and stared at the timestamp until the letters blurred. A phone call could still be called misunderstanding, tone, context. A screenshot with a timestamp looked like proof even when proof was only what one woman had felt arrogant enough to write down. Either way the message sat there now with the time clear at the top: 6:24 PM.

—

Grace reached Pacific Place ten minutes early and hated herself for it. The lower coffee bar was one of those spaces the city built to make waiting look like reasonable adulthood rather than dependence. Soft chairs, low tables, the scent of coffee better than anyone present deserved, glass at one end giving onto the polished movement of the mall. Theresa was already there by the back wall, a cup in front of her untouched, face turned slightly away from the main flow, trying not to be seen until the last possible second.

Grace crossed to the table and sat.

"You look ill."

Theresa gave a short breath through her nose. "That's useful."

Not hello. Not how are you. The relief of that almost embarrassed Grace.

"What happened."

Theresa looked past her for a second, checking the glass, the escalators, the woman two tables away pretending to read while hearing everything. Then she put one hand flat on the table, more to steady herself than anything else.

"I need you to read something."

Grace felt the skin along her arms go cold. "What."

Theresa took the phone from her bag, unlocked it without looking at the screen, opened the encrypted note, and

placed the phone face-up between them. Then she said the only line she had apparently allowed herself.

"Read the time."

Grace looked down. At first she saw only Augusta's name at the top and felt a small dull resistance in the body, the kind that came when the mind knew before the eyes did that the next thing would have edges. Then the time. 6:24 PM. And beneath it, in Augusta's neat, low-temperature banality:

Thank you, dear Theresa, for your discretion regarding Mr Morel — per Mrs Purvis's request. It was kind not to agitate Grace further today. We are all so grateful for steady friends at moments like this.

Grace read the message once, then again. The room around them continued exactly as before. Cups. Crockery. Escalators. The polished little noises of a mall so expensive it mistook private pain for upholstery. 6:24 PM. The exact evening Theresa had gone black on her. The exact evening before Singapore had been given a date large enough to live off.

She heard herself say, though she did not feel the mouth move, "No."

Theresa did not answer.

Grace read the phrase again.

Per Mrs Purvis's request.

Not because the city had sensed a sensitivity. Not because work had become weather. Not because sponsors had lost nerve and everyone had been terribly sorry in suitable jackets.

Per Mrs Purvis's request.

The room had not adapted. It had arranged.

Her hand moved before thought and she pulled the notebook from her bag. The pages opened badly under her fingers. She found the date page, then the entries from the week of Luc's extraction, then Catherine's line, then the auntie messages, then the circular and the caption and all of it suddenly not as sequence but as administration with her mother's signature removed because it had never required one in full daylight.

Her skin went cold first. Then hot. Then absent. The page in front of her swam once and steadied in the wrong direction, the body already tilting while the room refused to acknowledge the motion. The circled Sundays she had written two mornings earlier seemed, suddenly, not pathetic but criminally naïve. 1 October. Twelve weeks. Singapore. The date she had repeated like prayer. The date she had leaned on because numbers at least felt clean.

The date was not yet a lie proven false. That would come later. What broke now was worse. The possibility that the date had ever belonged to anything but the same machine.

"I took the screenshot that night," Theresa said quietly. "I wrote the time down as well. I know it does not prove every room. It proves this one."

Grace lifted her eyes. Theresa looked worse up close than she had from the doorway. Not guilty. Costly. The face of a woman who had finally spent something she could not replace.

"Why now."

"Because the circular made the rest of it unusable. Because once they had your face in a caption they no longer needed my silence. Because if I waited longer, I became part of the sentence."

"I should have shown you when it came," Theresa said. "I know that."

Grace did not answer.

"I told myself I was buying time. For you. For me. For anything that still looked survivable." She stopped. "I was afraid."

That, at least, remained clean.

Grace lifted her head a fraction. "I know."

Not absolution. Only the acknowledgement that fear, too, had become part of the machine's route.

In one blinding second the date in her mind — 1 October, written twice, circled, counted, leaned on, held like furniture in the centre of a collapsing room — did not dim or soften.

It shattered.

CHAPTER XXXII — NO USABLE ADDRESSEE

By four-twenty, the bright interiors had begun refusing her.

Theresa had not moved. The screenshot still lay on the table between them, the timestamp fixed at the top with its little vulgar certainty: 6:24 PM. Augusta's name. Augusta's neat, low-temperature gratitude. Per Mrs Purvis's request. The cup in front of Theresa remained untouched. Somewhere behind Grace a spoon struck porcelain and then another. The coffee bar kept doing what coffee bars in places like Pacific Place always did: turning private shocks into one more surface for soft lighting.

Grace looked at the phone and then at Theresa. "Send it to me."

Her own voice did not sound like hers. Not because it shook. Because it did not. The steadiness felt borrowed from somewhere lower in the body, from the part that had already understood panic would only blur the first line anyone had finally handed her that was not made of tone.

Theresa's fingers tightened once around the phone and then released. "Not to your ordinary thread."

"No."

"Not to email."

Grace looked at her. "Yes. Email. The other address. The one from the hospital forms."

A moment later Grace's phone vibrated in her hand. No preview, only the fact of arrival. Neither woman looked at the screen. The knowledge had changed location. It existed now in duplicate. Not safer. Only harder to soften.

"I don't know what to do," Grace said.

"That makes two of us."

The sentence should have sounded weak. It did not. It sounded costly.

Grace opened the notebook and wrote before thought could improve the wording.

6:24 PM. Per Mrs Purvis's request.

No underlining. No decoration. The facts did not need help.

Theresa watched her hand move across the page. "Do not go straight home."

"Why."

"Because if you go home in this state your mother will read your face before you have read your own plan." A pause. "And because if you confront her too early, you give her the first draft."

The phrase hit. First draft. Not the sort of thing Catherine or Augusta would ever say. Too honest about authorship.

"I have no plan," Grace said.

"I know."

"I'm sorry," Theresa said.

Grace heard the sentence and believed it and hated that both things could be true in the same breath. "I know," she said. Then she stood.

She did not go straight onto the bridge. Instead she turned into the ladies' room off the lower concourse because the body, unlike the mind, still understood when a door was required. The room was absurdly clean. Pale stone, soft light, a long mirror above white basins, one attendant folding hand towels with the serene concentration of someone whose profession required her to pretend not to witness collapse unless blood made pretending impossible.

Grace chose the furthest cubicle and closed the door. For a second she stood there with the phone in one hand and the notebook in the other, unable to decide which object now counted as the truer instrument. Then she opened the private inbox. Blank subject. Attachment only.

The screenshot filled the screen more cleanly there than it had on Theresa's phone. No hand tremor from another woman holding it out. No coffee bar around it. Only Augusta's name, the timestamp, and the sentence itself.

Thank you, dear Theresa, for your discretion regarding Mr Morel — per Mrs Purvis's request.

Grace read it once and then again until the words grew heavier rather than more familiar. Mr Morel. Not Luc. The old formality of removal. Per Mrs Purvis's request. Not a

misunderstanding. Not the city having one of its tasteful little moral panics all by itself. A request. Made. Received. Actioned. Thanked.

She saved the attachment offline. Renamed it nothing. Moved it out of the ordinary photos. Then she wrote beneath the earlier lines:

Screenshot duplicated. Private address only.

The pen bit slightly through the paper.

When she stepped back to the mirror, another woman was blotting lipstick with the mild dissociation of someone late for something tedious rather than life-altering. Grace caught their reflections together and felt the obscene split of it. She ran cold water over her wrists, dried them badly, and looked at herself. Not dramatic enough. The face too composed.

She moved through the lower level of Pacific Place with the hard, mismeasured speed of a body trying to turn impact into direction before impact had even finished entering the bloodstream. Past handbags under careful light. Past two men from some firm or other with conference badges still clipped to their belts. Past a woman applying lipstick in the black glass of a locked shop while her child hung from one arm and complained in a voice so ordinary it felt like a specific cruelty.

Her phone vibrated. Mother.

She let it ring out. A second later, a message: Where are you.

No greeting. No softening. Nothing but location. Grace opened a reply field and typed: Central. Deleted it. Typed: With Theresa. Deleted that too because it felt like paying for help by exposing it. In the end she wrote only: Walking.

Her mother answered at once: Don't overdo it.

Grace locked the screen.

She stopped under the atrium at Exchange Square and opened a booking app. Origin: Hong Kong. Destination: Singapore. Departure: today. Three flights remained, all expensive in the punitive way last-minute exits always were. She selected one. The price loaded. The seats loaded. Then the page moved to passport details, confirmation, billing address, emergency contact.

Billing address. Emergency contact.

The act stalled there, not because she could not type her name, but because the whole plan had quietly required a woman who was not, at this exact hour, still counted by hospitals, staff, cars, mothers, visitors, and the continuing warm chemistry of a father in a private ward. A woman free enough to disappear for a night without converting the disappearance into a story the city would chew before breakfast.

She closed the app.

A plan began anyway, not in full, only in broken practical flashes. Forward the screenshot to Barrett. No. Show it to a solicitor. Which one. With what money. For what cause capable of surviving polite nouns. Print it. Keep it. Wait. Every route formed and dissolved before it acquired legs.

She took the bridge towards the old building because the body had begun moving in that direction and because turning back towards the coffee bar would have implied a scene, while going home would have implied surrender.

The security desk remained where it always had. One of the men looked up with the bland attention reserved for women who might belong and might not.

"Can I help, miss."

Grace almost laughed. No. Yes. Certainly. Could you please restore the previous month of my life, revoke a donor circular, unmake a committee, and put me in a room where I can say my mother did this without sounding like an operatic child.

"I was looking for someone," she said.

"Name, miss."

She looked past him towards the lifts, towards the corridor where diaries would already have changed around a vanished body.

"No," she said. "I was mistaken."

She turned away before the man could respond and went back out into the bright air of the bridge connection.

There was no usable addressee.

That was when the energy first thinned. Not vanished. Thinned. Every plan now required more muscle than the system it meant to oppose. She could feel it in the shoulders first, then behind the eyes, then lower in the stomach where the day had begun and, apparently, intended to end.

The phone vibrated again. Mother. Then immediately after, Catherine.

Grace put the phone into the bag, took out the notebook once more, and looked at the two factual lines already there. She added nothing.

She turned back into Exchange Square, following signs rather than intention, and found the descending escalator at the far end of the atrium. She stepped onto it and let it carry her one level lower. At the next landing she kept walking because the downward route continued. Another escalator. A service corridor. Another bank lobby emptied of clients and full of cleaning staff. Signs to parking, taxis, MTR, exits. Down again.

The bright interiors had done all they could with her. The bridges, the glass, the escalators, the premium coffee, the air-conditioned corridors — none of them had absorbed the force of what had landed. They had only reflected it back with better lighting.

At the final landing before street level she paused by the rail. The city below was louder from here. Buses. Tyres through old rain. A shout from somewhere near a loading bay. The less edited register.

Grace put one hand on the rail and felt the cool metal hold without interpretation.

For a few seconds she stood there with the bag on her shoulder, the screenshot duplicated in the private inbox, the notebook closed in her hand. The proof existed. The route did not.

Then the body moved.

Not a decision. Not even a surrender.

Only descent beginning before the mind had named the destination.

CHAPTER XXXIII — THE LAST FAMILIAR THING

Street level did not receive her. It only removed the glass. When Grace stepped out from the last cooled interior into the wet heat below, the city rose to meet her in the register the bridges and escalators had spent the whole afternoon trying to filter out: bus brakes, tyres through old rain, the drag of a trolley over cracked pavement, voices crossing one another without ever becoming conversation. The air smelt of diesel, frying oil, wet concrete, and signage beginning to warm itself for evening.

For a second she stood beneath the awning with the bag on her shoulder and the phone still hot in her hand from being held too hard. Nothing in the street announced itself as the next verb.

Her phone vibrated. Mother. Then, almost at once, Catherine. She looked at the two names and felt nothing so simple as anger. Anger implied clean ownership. This was only continuation. The room reaching down through signal and glass to restore sequence before she found one of her own. She locked the screen and put the phone into the bag without answering.

The movement had the force of ritual already. Phone in bag. Screenshot in the private address. Notebook within reach. Facts carried, not spoken. The city had made her

logistical in self-defence. She knew that. She hated it. She did it anyway.

She started walking because standing still would have looked like waiting, and she could no longer bear any posture that resembled dependence.

Two crossings later she realised she had no destination in mind. That should not have mattered. People walked through Central all the time without confessing a destination aloud to themselves. Yet in her body the absence of one felt less like freedom than like a short administrative error. A system without an assigned purpose. A line the room had not yet approved.

At the next light she stopped because the signal demanded it. Cars slid past, reflecting the first hard stabs of evening light. Beside her, a woman with a pushchair argued into a headset about seven-thirty and not seven, with timing still the scale on which the world could be measured. Grace envied her with a force that felt almost obscene. Not because the woman looked happy. Because the size of her problem still matched the size of her life.

The light changed. Grace crossed with the crowd and kept going.

At some point the city around her stopped offering language she could use and began offering only texture. Stainless shutters half down. Steam from a noodle shop caught under an awning. The back smell of restaurants

rather than their front smell. A delivery boy swearing softly to himself in Cantonese with an intimacy that suggested nobody had ever tried to route his frustration into self-knowledge. The noises did not comfort her. They only refused to care.

She cut through a narrower lane because the main pavement had clogged with office workers and tourists and two delivery trolleys locked nose to nose like animals refusing to yield. Bins, stacked cardboard breaking down in damp, one cook in rubber sandals smoking beside crates and staring at nothing with the concentration of the exhausted. Grace moved through it as though through the underlining of the city. No donor circular could be made from this angle. No caption could flatter it into atmosphere.

When she came out again near Des Voeux Road, the light had gone flatter. Not dark yet. The hour when the towers still reflected day while the street had already committed to evening. Neon beginning before it was needed. Wet patches on the road holding the wrong colour for the sky. A bus leaned round the corner and exhaled hot engine breath over everyone waiting to cross. The blast of it hit her face and for one absurd second she was grateful for something blunt enough not to pretend.

Her phone vibrated again. She did not look. The vibrations had become like taps at a glass panel: proof that the

outside still desired access, not proof of anything worth hearing.

She went down another set of steps to a lower level of pavement without recognising the route. It no longer mattered. She had run out of words before she had run out of movement.

Then she heard it.

ding-ding

The sound reached her body before it reached her mind. Not memory first. Body. A small hard strike just beneath the sternum, some old mechanism inside her turning at once on hearing it and only later allowing the mind to recognise why.

She stopped without deciding to stop.

Between the rear lights of a bus and the nose of a taxi she saw the briefest flash of the tram's side, boxy and lit, and then it was gone again behind traffic. The sound had already thinned into the evening, but the mark it made remained.

Not comfort. She knew that now. The front seat had failed. The old wood and the route had offered form and no contents. The tram had remained itself while the terms under which she had loved it were revoked.

Still, the body had turned.

She crossed at the next light without fully deciding to. The road ran towards the tracks. She knew the slope of it in the

body. She had known it at seventeen when the city had still seemed larger than the house, when leaving it had still counted as argument rather than relief. She had known it with Luc when the bell had meant ignition and the wet road sliding forward beneath the glass and his hand under hers and the kiss so precise it had altered weather.

Now the sound came back stripped of all of that.

ding-ding

Closer.

She turned the corner and saw the rails. They shone faintly in the wet streetlight, two lines laid into the road with the same patient old-world certainty they had always possessed. Cars moved around them and over them and still the rails kept their claim. A taxi nosed too far forward at a stop and then reversed obediently when the bell sounded again somewhere further down the line. The whole road made room in increments, not out of reverence but habit.

A woman in office clothes stood at the stop beneath the shelter, typing with both thumbs, bag looped over one wrist. Two schoolboys argued over something on a phone. An old man with a cane watched the bend in the tracks with the concentration of someone whose body no longer granted him inattentive waiting. Nothing in any of them required acknowledgement.

Grace did not go to the stop. That would have been repetition. A ritual. A final attempt at the front seat, the upper deck, the old wood, the bell translated back into private grammar.

Instead she stood across the road at the edge of the kerb and looked along the rails. The city seemed, for a moment, to separate into layers. Traffic. Voices. A radio from a fruit stall, thin and distorted. The faint overhead hum of tram lines carrying charge between nowhere particular.

ding-ding

Not comfort. Not escape. Not memory. Only the most familiar sound in the city that did not ask her to explain herself before arriving. The thought came and she distrusted it at once. Too clean. Too nearly quotable. Too much like meaning arriving on demand in a week that had already taught her what demand did to things. Still, the body had turned. The rails existed. The sound persisted. Those two facts had the advantage of being too plain to improve.

The tram rounded the bend.

Not fast. Never fast. That was part of its obscenity and its dignity both. It came on with the same old stubborn pace, patience itself bolted into the front. Lit from within. Upper deck visible. Front window catching reflections, then losing them, then catching them again. A moving room. A route. A system older and cleaner than the ones that had

lately been making her useful. The road began, little by little, to give way.

ding-ding

The old man stepped back half an inch on instinct. The schoolboys looked up and then returned to the phone. The woman with the bag did not raise her eyes. This sound belonged to the city's bloodstream. It asked. The city paused. It went on.

Grace watched the front of the tram and felt nothing so sentimental as relief.

What she felt was recognition.

This too. This sound, this speed, these rails, this little old insistence moving through wet light. The last familiar thing in a city that had stopped being navigable by thought. The bridges above had offered routes and none had held. The coffee bar had offered a table and the table had split. The notebook had offered fact and fact had given her no usable verb. Words had run out. Plans had run out after them.

She remembered her father behind her on the upper deck not speaking for several stops because he had understood that speech was sometimes the smaller instrument. She remembered Luc beside her at the front, the whole wet city moving under the glass, the bell turning the ride into ignition. The recognitions passed through her without order and without rescue.

What remained was not any of those.

Only the sound.

Only the rails.

Only the fact that the tram still moved on the same old line whether or not anyone's life had become uninhabitable in the meantime.

ding-ding

The tram was close enough now that she could see the pale blur of faces through the front glass and the driver's shoulder shifting with each tiny adjustment of hand and brake and route. Close enough that motion itself acquired body. The city made room.

Grace moved.

CHAPTER XXXIV — SMALL TYPE

The morning edition carried his name on the front page.

RAYMOND PURVIS, 82, INDUSTRIALIST AND CULTURAL PATRON

His daughter appeared in the Deaths section on page sixteen, in the lower half of the third column, between a notice for a retired surveyor and an advertisement for private wealth management.

PURVIS Grace Amelia, died in Hong Kong, aged 31. Daughter of Raymond Purvis. Private funeral. No flowers. Donations, if desired, to the Purvis Foundation Museum Wing Legacy Fund.